

RIFT ASCENDANT · WARDEN'S EDITION

The Shadow of the Regent

A mature paranormal-horror campaign for Levels 1-15, set
inside the Gloamreach — a country-sized S-Rank Rift
Interior ruled by its Anchor, the Regent.

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Rift Ascendant Lore: The Rift Age and the Gloamreach

Rift Ascendant — World Lore

Source Authority

This document is the campaign-facing world lore for **The Shadow of the Regent**, and the canonical world reference included in the app. Its foundation is the official **Rift Ascendant: Player's Guide to the World**; the closing **Campaign Layer** section adds the deeper canon this adventure relies on (persistent Rift Interiors, Anchors, Regents, pantheon signatures, Subject Zero, and the Gloamreach). Use the Player's Guide terminology everywhere: **Rift**, **Rift Threshold**, **Rift Interior**, **Rift Site**, **Rift Clear**, **Rift Break**, **Anomaly**, **Essence**, **Relic**, **Ascendant**, **Awakening**, **Bureau**, **Guild**, **Rank**, **AFA**, **Job**, **Path**.

The Rift Age

Rift Ascendant takes place on a modern, Earth-like world transformed by the arrival of **Rifts**. This is **not** a fallen world. Cities still shine at night. People go to work, pay rent, follow celebrities, argue politics, fall in love, and worry about money. Governments pass laws; corporations compete; hospitals treat the sick. The difference is that reality now has doors where doors should not be.

A **Rift** is a tear in the structure of the world. Some last only minutes. Others stabilize into dangerous thresholds that open into impossible interior spaces — some small enough to clear in hours, some large enough to contain cities, ecosystems, ruins, and weather that does not belong to Earth.

Humanity did not collapse. It adapted. New agencies formed, new industries were born, new careers and celebrities and weapons and religions appeared, and new markets grew around **Essence**, **Relics**, and Rift materials. And new kinds of people **Awakened** — the **Ascendants**, the rare individuals who can enter Rifts, survive what lives there, and fight the **Anomalies** within.

The core truth: Rifts are dangerous, but they are part of modern life. Most people will never enter one; everyone knows they exist. To civilians, Rifts are disasters, resources, miracles, and nightmares at once. To governments, public-safety threats and strategic assets. To corporations, markets. To guilds, contracts. To Ascendants, the place where reputations are made, fortunes are won, and bodies are left behind. The world has learned to live with Rifts. It has not mastered them.

A Brief History

- **Before the Rifts** — history looked much like our own; other worlds and hidden powers were folklore.
- **First Contact** — the first confirmed Rifts were treated as isolated disasters. Conventional forces tried to enter and clear them, and failed often enough that the world changed its approach.

- **The First Awakened** — Ascendants emerged during the early disasters: survivors, soldiers, exposed civilians, some who Awakened without ever approaching a Rift. No single explanation satisfied anyone; what mattered was that they could do what ordinary humans could not.
- **The Bureau Era** — governments created regulatory agencies to classify Rifts, license Ascendants, and keep Rift response from becoming uncontrolled warfare. The largest is simply called **the Bureau**.
- **The Guild Boom** — once Essence and Relics proved valuable, private Ascendant **guilds** became unavoidable — emergency teams, mercenary companies, corporate brands, family crews, and worse.
- **The Modern Rift Age** — the world has normalized the impossible: Rift alerts on phones, Ascendant rankings trending online, Essence medicine, Relic auctions, raid footage, fans and sponsors and scandals — and a black market in cores, forged clearances, and unregistered Rift maps.

Rifts

Most people use "Rift" broadly. Specialists are precise:

- **Rift Threshold** — the entrance: a glowing rupture, a dark doorway, a distortion, a mirror-like surface, an opening in the ground. Some are stable; some pulse, flicker, widen, shrink, or move.
- **Rift Interior** — the space beyond: a cave system, ruined temple, abandoned city block, flooded station, black forest, frozen fortress, impossible skyscraper, or living maze. Low-rank Interiors clear in hours; high-rank ones can demand days, weeks, or multiple operations.
- **Rift Site** — the area around an active Rift in the normal world: Bureau barricades, medical tents, police lines, media zones, guild staging, Essence containment, evacuation points. A mix of crime scene, military checkpoint, film set, and corporate trade show.
- **Rift Clear** — a successful operation that neutralizes the primary threat. Not always clean: teams return wounded, civilians are lost, Anomalies escape — or a Rift is declared cleared because that is what the report needs to say.
- **Rift Break** — containment fails and Rift conditions spill into the normal world. Anomalies emerge; weather distorts; structures warp; roads stop leading where they should; communication fails. Most Breaks are contained quickly. The ones that are not become history.

Anomalies

Anomalies are the creatures, entities, hazards, and lifeforms found inside Rifts. The public calls them monsters — sometimes accurately. They can be beasts, spirits, constructs, parasites, humanoids, swarms, living weapons, machines, warped animals, memory-echoes, or things that fit no known category. Some are mindless; some are clever, capable of tactics, speech, building, or worship; some follow laws and hierarchies humanity barely understands. To civilians the distinction rarely matters. To Ascendants it can save a team: a predator can be baited, a soldier misled, a guardian bypassed, a parasite contained — and an intelligent Anomaly can negotiate, lie, threaten, plead, or **remember**.

Native Inhabitants

Anomalies are not a Rift's only inhabitants. Not every Interior is empty of people. Especially in high-rank, persistent Interiors, an operation may find **native inhabitants** — peoples, settlements,

families, and cultures **native to the Interior's own world**, neither Anomalies nor visitors from the material world. The *doorway* is new; the world beyond it is not. These are not humans from Earth who wandered in and got trapped — they are a population that was always there, in a reality the Rift has only just connected to ours. They farm, trade, worship, grieve, raise children, and obey laws that were old before any Ascendant arrived. Some are friendly; some are desperate; some serve whatever rules their Interior. To a strike team trained to clear monsters, the hardest Rifts are the ones with a population — because then a Rift Clear is no longer only a fight. It is a question of what happens to everyone who already lives there.

Essence

Essence is the most important resource of the Rift Age — the energy, material, residue, crystal, or core recovered from Rifts and Anomalies. It appears as glowing crystals, harvested cores, liquid, dust, thread, bone, metal, or compressed mana. Essence revolutionized technology, medicine, weapons, construction, and computing. It made Ascendants necessary and profitable. Every Rift operation has two public goals — contain the threat and protect civilians — and usually a third: recover Essence before someone else does.

Relics

Relics are objects recovered from Rifts or created through Rift-touched processes: weapons, armor, tools, implants, masks, rings, books, lenses, engines, instruments. A low-grade Relic improves survivability; a high-grade Relic can define a career. Relics can be legal, restricted, classified, stolen, cursed, experimental, counterfeit, or impossible to categorize. Some are mass-reproduced in weaker forms; some are unique, named, and seem to **choose** their users; some should never have left the Rift.

Ascendants

Ascendants have Awakened the ability to survive, fight, and act within Rifts. **Awakening** changes a person — dramatically or subtly, through visions, pain, fever, transformation, or sudden instinctive knowledge. No one fully understands why it happens. What matters is that an Ascendant can channel mana, withstand Rift pressure, fight Anomalies, wield Relics safely, and enter the impossible and come back. Sometimes.

Being an Ascendant does not automatically make someone rich or respected. Rank, guild membership, public image, clear record, sponsorship, class, nationality, Bureau relationship, and luck all matter. Some become celebrities; some are low-rank laborers clearing minor Rifts for poor pay; some retire early because trauma ended their career; some disappear.

Jobs

A **Job** is the Bureau's classification for the broad shape of an Ascendant's power — the setting's equivalent of a 5e class. It is not a profession chosen from a catalog; it is the label placed on how power expresses itself. Common Job archetypes:

Destroyer, Berserker, Assassin, Striker, Mage, Esper, Revenant, Summoner, Herald, Contractor, Stalker, Holy Knight, Technomancer, Idol.

Paths

A **Path** is the specialized expression of a Job — the setting's equivalent of a 5e subclass. It may emerge from training, instinct, trauma, culture, doctrine, Relic exposure, or repeated Rift experience. Two Mages may look nothing alike: a Detonation specialist, a Shield Architect, a probability-bender.

Rank

Rank is the world's attempt to measure the impossible. Rifts, Anomalies, Relics, and Ascendants are classified **E through S**. Lower ranks are common and usually manageable by trained teams; higher ranks demand elite Ascendants, planning, and Bureau oversight. An **S-Rank** event is political, economic, military, and historical. Rank determines pay, contracts, fame, and legal freedom — but **Rank is not truth**. Rifts can be misclassified, Ascendants underestimated, Anomalies can evolve, and a routine clear can become a disaster. Veterans respect Rank. They do not worship it.

Institutions & Society

- **The Bureau** — the official regulatory and response authority: it classifies Rifts, licenses Ascendants, issues clearances, tracks Rank, coordinates public safety, regulates Essence and Relic recovery, and maintains casualty records. The Bureau is an institution, not a personality — brave responders, brilliant researchers, exhausted clerks, political operators, idealists, and the occasional corrupt official, all inside a machine too large to care about every case. Many civilians trust it because they must; many Ascendants distrust how its reports are written after things go wrong. Both can be true.
- **Guilds** — private organizations built on Ascendant labor: friend-crews, regional response companies, celebrity teams, paramilitary contractors, corporate brands, religious orders, black-market fronts. A good guild offers training, medical support, legal coverage, and benefits; a bad one treats Ascendants as replaceable tools.
- **Corporations** — turned the Rift Age into a trillion-credit economy: Essence tech, mana-compatible weapons, Rift-resistant materials, media empires. Some save lives; some knowingly send people into danger; most do both, depending on the quarter.
- **Civilians** — the vast majority, who experience the Rift Age through its effects: following rankings like sports, working guild offices, teaching children Rift-alert drills, protesting Essence refineries, worshipping or resenting Ascendants, grieving those lost to a Break.
- **Media, Law, Faith** — Ascendants are public figures with fans, sponsors, and scandals. Where there are Rifts there is crime: illegal entry, Essence smuggling, Relic theft, forged clearances, debt contracts. And the Rifts reshaped belief: faiths that call them divine tests or wounds in creation, and new cults formed around Essence, Awakening, Anomalies, and the idea that Rifts are not invasions but **invitations**.

Technology & the AFA

Modern technology still works — phones, drones, firearms, hospitals, body armor. Essence added new tools: mana scanners, Rift-resistant armor, resonance sensors, Essence batteries, containment fields, anti-Anomaly munitions. But **inside** Rifts, reliability varies: signals fail, drones lose navigation, firearms jam in mana interference, digital maps distort, sensors return impossible readings.

The **AFA (Ascendant Field App)** is the standard field interface for licensed Ascendants — a phone app, wrist device, visor, earpiece, tablet, implant display, or guild OS. It tracks mission data, team status, injury warnings, Rift readings, Rank estimates, Essence signatures, contract terms, map data, and

Bureau notices. **The AFA is not magic and not fate. It does not make decisions for you. It measures, records, warns, and reports.** Inside a Rift it is only as reliable as conditions allow. *If your AFA says everything is fine while your instincts say otherwise, trust your instincts.*

Tone

Rift Ascendant is **modern action fantasy with danger beyond the threshold**. The outside world is modern, functional, commercial, political, and alive — contracts, cameras, sponsors, laws, hospitals, rankings, family obligations. The inside of a Rift is where the rules become uncertain — Anomalies, Essence, Relics, impossible environments, strange laws, broken maps, unreliable signals, and choices no contract prepared you for. The setting is not about a ruined world; it is about a normal world that has learned to profit from the impossible, and about people with extraordinary power trying to stay human while everyone else decides what that power is worth.

Campaign Layer — Domains, Anchors & the Gloamreach

*The following deepens the Player's Guide for high-rank, persistent Rifts. These concepts are the spine of **The Shadow of the Regent**.*

Persistent Rift Interiors — "Domains"

Most Rift Interiors are limited: a ruin, a tunnel, a pocket battlefield. But a **high-rank Rift Interior can stabilize into a whole interior realm** — a valley with weather, roads, settlements, a citadel, a dead sea, a predator forest, a buried archive — large enough to lose armies inside. When such an Interior grows persistent and takes on its own enforceable laws, Wardens call it a **Domain**. The Rift Threshold is only the door; the Domain beyond it is the adventure.

Anchors

Every persistent Domain has an **Anchor** — the thing that keeps its Threshold stable and gives the Interior its laws. Common Anchors include a ruling Anomaly intelligence, a **Regent**, a Relic engine, a domain heart, an Essence furnace, a bound pantheon signature, or a living ecology that has become self-aware. **Clearing a Domain means breaking, sealing, transforming, or extracting the Anchor.** Killing every creature inside is not enough while the Anchor — and its law — survives.

Contained vs. Rift Break

While a Domain is **contained**, the Bureau can measure the Threshold, issue Rank clearance, deploy Ascendants, and hold a cordon. A **Rift Break** is the failure state: containment collapses and the Interior begins to **overwrite the material side** — weather first, then terrain, then Anomalies, then the Anchor's law itself. *The Bureau calls a Rift safe while its instruments still have numbers.* Numbers run out.

Regents

A **Regent** is not merely a powerful Anomaly; a Regent is **domain authority with will**. When a Regent becomes a Domain's Anchor, the land itself behaves like a body and a court. Regents do not simply wait in a final room — they wear the faces of the dead, alter roads, bargain through Relics, hollow out settlements, raise servants from the claimed, and study intruders without ever being seen to look. Their horror is not size. It is that inside a Regent's Domain, nothing goes unseen and nothing is ever truly free.

The Pantheon

The **Eternals and Exarchs** are the distant powers of the Rift Ascendant cosmos, and they behave like a distant pantheon — much like the gods of older myth. They do not walk inside a Domain, do not take sides, and are never the explanation for a site, a monster, or a Regent. At most they are felt the way old gods are felt: a half-glimpsed omen, a folk-shrine that has not answered in living memory, a name in a prayer no one truly expects to be heard. A campaign can run from threshold to throne and never need to name one of them.

Treat the pantheon as deep background, never as a mechanic. The dread inside a Domain comes from the Domain itself — from what it does to the living and what it makes of the dead — not from the powers watching, if they watch at all, from very far away.

Subject Zero

Subject Zero is an older, sealed **S-Rank Anomaly** whose pressure leaks into some high-rank Domains. It is **not** the Regent and is not loyal to him — an outside hunger that can offer power through forbidden bargains (the campaign's "Unseated Law" lever). When Subject Zero touches a Domain, the bargain should be real, useful, and costly.

The Gloamreach

The Gloamreach is the **S-Rank Rift Interior** of *The Shadow of the Regent* — a country-sized persistent Domain behind one stabilized Threshold. It has roads, settlements, ruins, mills, warrens, predator ranges, a fallen bastion, a forbidden vault, and a citadel visible from almost everywhere. **The Regent is the Gloamreach's Anchor**. Its terrors are its own: a drowned hospital-fen that remembers the dead and the not-yet-dead, caverns where the rot learns your sleeping face, an orchard that fruits stolen memories, a hall where the burning dead are never allowed to stop, roads that watch and move and lengthen, settlements surviving on tribute paid to things best left unnamed, and over all of it a Regent who sees everything in his country and wears the faces of everyone it has swallowed.

The material side matters as the place the party leaves, the place the Rift may Break into, and the place that must live with the ending.

Campaign Tone

The Shadow of the Regent is hard **paranormal / dark-fantasy horror** inside a Rift Interior: scarcity without mercy; settlements surviving by tribute; Ascendants reduced from elite operators to trapped prey; Bureau failure recorded in clean language; Vermillion pragmatism that saves and exploits; Anomalies as ecology, punishment, livestock, and omen; Relics that solve problems by teaching the party to think like the Domain; and a Regent who is charismatic, predatory, and patient. The world should feel modern in tools and institutions, but the adventure space is the Rift Interior. **Roads should be wrong.**

Weather should judge. Safe places should feel leased, not owned. Every clear should ask what the party gave up to survive.

Glossary

AFA — Ascendant Field App; a field interface that tracks mission data, team status, Rift readings, injuries, contracts, and alerts. It measures and reports; it does not grant destiny. · **Anchor** (*campaign*) — the entity or structure that stabilizes a persistent Rift Interior and sets its laws. · **Anomaly** — a creature, entity, hazard, or lifeform from within a Rift. · **Ascendant** — a person who has Awakened the ability to operate inside Rifts. · **Awakening** — the event or process by which a person becomes an Ascendant. · **Bureau** — the official institution for Rift regulation, licensing, classification, and public safety. · **Domain** (*campaign*) — a persistent, ruled Rift Interior large enough to behave like a country. · **Essence** — energy, material, or cores recovered from Rifts and Anomalies. · **Guild** — a private Ascendant organization. · **Job** — the broad classification of an Ascendant's power (5e class). · **Path** — the specialized expression of a Job (5e subclass). · **Rank** — the E–S classification of Rifts, Anomalies, Relics, and Ascendants. · **Regent** (*campaign*) — a Domain Anchor that is "authority with will." · **Relic** — a powerful object recovered from or created through Rift forces. · **Rift** — a tear in reality leading to an impossible interior space. · **Rift Break** — a containment failure where Anomalies or Rift conditions spill into the normal world. · **Rift Clear** — a successful operation that neutralizes a Rift's primary threat. · **Rift Interior** — the space beyond a Rift Threshold. · **Rift Site** — the operation area surrounding an active Rift. · **Rift Threshold** — the visible entrance into a Rift.

Chapter 0: Day Zero - The Memory-Care Wing

Day Zero - The Memory-Care Wing

A Rift that feeds on memory is not merely an opening. It is the first time a place learns your name. - Dr. Serin Hayashi, private margin note

Purpose

Run this one-to-two session gothic-horror prelude before the party enters the Gloamreach. The characters are still on the material side, inside the Bureau cordon surrounding the S-Rank Rift. The Memory-Care Wing is a small pocket breach created by pressure leaking from the Gloamreach. It introduces the campaign's real themes: memory, ownership, hospitality, civilian cost, and the terror of a Domain that reaches through the door before anyone steps inside.

The party begins at Level 1 and reaches Level 2 at the end of this chapter.

The Hook - Welfare Check

A shuttered hospital wing inside the cordon has gone silent. It houses elderly civilians who could not be moved when the Bureau perimeter collapsed inward. The night staff missed their check-in. A drone pass showed the windows fogged from inside. No portal is visible, but the AFA readings show a low-rank pocket breach behind one resident's bathroom mirror.

Read aloud:

The dispatcher slides a cracked tablet across the counter. The image shows a brick hospital wing behind temporary Bureau fencing. Every window is fogged white from the inside. "Twenty-three residents, six staff, no confirmed hostiles. We have senior Ascendants preparing for the S-Rank threshold. You are what we have left. Be careful. Most of them will not understand what is happening."

The Wing

The building is too warm. The heat is off. A radio plays static in a language no one recognizes. When the party crosses the threshold, each character makes a DC 10 Sense save. On a failure, the character forgets a harmless but personal detail for one hour: a badge number, a favorite song, a friend's birthday, the smell of home.

This is not a punishment. It is a warning.

Keyed Rooms

R1. Reception - The Visitors' Log

The reception desk is clean. A potted orchid has been freshly watered. A visitors' log sits open.

Every entry is written in the same hand. Different names. Same ink. Same arrival time. Same departure time. The next blank line already has the first stroke of a party member's name.

Clue: the handwriting matches Ms. Park Jeong-hye in R4. Writing a name in the log grants advantage on the next Sense save in the Wing, but the Regent's agents can recognize that character by name later.

R2. Dayroom - The Wrong Afternoon

Five residents sit watching a news broadcast from years ago. Sunlight fills the room even though the windows face the wrong direction. The residents are echoes. They cannot be harmed and cannot meaningfully answer questions.

Hidden under a folded blanket is the Faded Family Photo: a young woman in a wedding dress beside a man in Bureau dress uniform. The man's face has been worn down to blank paper. The inscription reads: Jeong-hye and [name erased], June 1978.

This photograph is the campaign's first major emotional relic. If the party carries it into the Gloamreach, the Regent notices the absence immediately.

R3. The Hallway That Lengthens

The hallway stretches as the party walks. Framed photographs age as the characters pass: birthdays, hospital beds, empty chairs, blank frames.

Encounter: The Forgetting, a D-Rank memory swarm.

Use a simple swarm profile: HP 22, AC 12, speed 30 ft., vulnerable to radiant. It makes two chill-touch attacks at +4 to hit for 1d4 cold damage. On a hit, the target makes a DC 13 Sense save or suffers disadvantage on the next check made in the hallway.

Escape condition: the hallway resolves when a character stops trying to move forward and turns back toward the dayroom. The Domain rewards surrendering control, but remembers who did it.

R4. Room 12-B - Ms. Park Jeong-hye

Ms. Park lies awake in bed, staring at the ceiling. Her heart monitor beeps even though it is not plugged in. She repeats the same line every twelve seconds: "He was supposed to come home for lunch."

A gentle Presence check, DC 10, gives one moment of lucidity. She remembers that her husband was an Ascendant. She remembers a uniform. She remembers pride. She does not remember his name. When she tries to say it, the sound does not reach the party.

R5. The Mirror - The Diagnosed

The bathroom mirror is open. Violet frost crawls across the frame. The creature halfway through the glass has a face made from every person Ms. Park has forgotten.

Boss: The Diagnosed, D-Rank elite. HP 28, AC 13, speed 20 ft., immune to psychic and necrotic, vulnerable to radiant.

Actions:

1. Forgetting Touch. Melee +5 to hit, 1d6+2 cold. On hit, DC 13 Sense save or the target loses reactions until the end of their next turn.
2. Mirror Retreat, once per fight. The Diagnosed enters the mirror and returns at the end of its next turn beside a reflective surface.
3. Forgetting Gaze, recharge 5-6. 15 ft. cone. DC 13 Sense save. On failure, the target takes 2d6 psychic damage and gains the Regent-Marked condition.

When The Diagnosed falls, the mirror cracks and the pocket breach begins to collapse.

The Warden's Choice

The party has one choice before the Wing collapses.

Destroy the mirror. The breach ends completely. Ms. Park dies with perfect clarity, smiling at someone the party cannot see. The residents are found dead but peaceful. The party gains Bureau reputation. The Faded Family Photo remains whole.

Seal the mirror. Ms. Park and several residents survive. The haunting remains dormant. The party gains Vermillion or civilian reputation. A grief-cult scout notices the party's mercy and reports it to the Awoko.

This choice should echo in the Gloamreach. If Ms. Park dies, the Regent's human-form reveal is colder and more incomplete. If she survives, she can appear at the Bureau cordon during the finale and create one round of hesitation when the Regent remembers who waited.

Regent-Marked Condition

A character marked here becomes visible to the Regent's law. The Regent and his servants can recognize the character's presence inside the Gloamreach. The character has disadvantage on Stealth checks against Regent-aligned entities, and the Regent may communicate through dreams, reflective surfaces, or written invitations.

The mark is removed only if the Regent releases it, the Anchor is resolved, or a major divine or Relic-tier intervention breaks the claim.

Design Notes

This chapter is horror first and combat second. Let silence work. The residents are civilians, not props. The point is not whether the party can win a fight. The point is what kind of people they are when a Rift asks them to choose between mercy and certainty.

Chapter 1: Warden's Briefing - Entering the Gloamreach

The Shadow of the Regent

Campaign Overview

The Shadow of the Regent is a non-linear horror sandbox for 3-6 Ascendants, taking characters from Level 1 to Level 15. It is set inside **the Gloamreach**, an S-Rank Rift Interior behind one stabilized threshold.

This is not a city-district crisis and not a cluster of unrelated Gates. The material world is the staging ground. The campaign space is the Domain.

The Gloamreach contains roads, settlements, predator woods, tithe sites, drowned archives, ruined bastions, black-market shelters, forbidden vaults, and a citadel visible from almost everywhere. The Regent is the Anchor. His rule is expressed through the weather, the roads, the claimed dead, his servants, his Relics, and the simple fact that nowhere in his country goes unseen.

Opening Situation

No Ascendant or Bureau team has gone inside yet, so the Bureau can only rate the Rift from its threshold instruments — a provisional low/E classification that reads like a routine high-density clear. The reading is honest and wrong. Once the party is deep enough inside, the truth becomes undeniable: the Rift opens into a coherent interior realm large enough to swallow teams, distort distance, and produce settlements under foreign law. As containment slips toward Rift Break, the threshold turns unreliable behind them.

The party enters as the first available Ascendant team. Their mission is to identify the Anchor, recover the Three Claims, prevent a Rift Break, and survive long enough to decide what kind of ending the Gloamreach deserves.

Running This Module

This campaign is built at full hardcover scale:

1. The Domain is the adventure location.
2. The Regent recurs throughout the campaign.
3. Travel is dangerous and meaningful.
4. Settlements are unsafe compromises, not rest stops.
5. Key Relics are placed through oracle logic.
6. Faction choices matter.
7. The finale is a citadel and Anchor-throne confrontation.

Session 0 Checklist

- Establish mature horror expectations.

- Confirm hard limits and safety tools.
- Tie every Ascendant to a reason to enter the Gloamreach.
- Explain that some threats are meant to be survived, bargained with, escaped, or outwitted rather than killed.
- Establish that the Regent is not merely a monster. He is Domain authority.

Ascendant Creation Hooks

Hook	Description
Bureau Deployed	You were ordered into the Domain under emergency clearance.
Guild Raider	Your Guild sees salvage, cores, Relics, and leverage.
Missing Team	Someone you know vanished during the first response wave.
Marked Before You Came	Your name surfaces, in the Regent's own hand, in something carried out of the Gloamreach.
Researcher	You need to prove how Regent Domains work before the Bureau's caution seals what is really inside this one.
Grief-Bound	The Gloamreach contains a voice, face, or memory you thought was gone.

Milestone Leveling Guide

Milestone	Level
Complete Day Zero or first threshold clear	2
Survive the first Domain road crisis	3
Earn a faction's trust or save a settlement	4
Clear the first major Domain site	5
Survive or drive off the Regent's Bailiff	7
Resolve the first settlement's tribute crisis	8
Obtain a Claim or Regent Relic	10
Reach the Forbidden Vault or fallen bastion	12
Enter the Regent's Citadel	13
Resolve the Anchor (campaign climax)	15

The Regent: The Thing That Rules the Gloamreach

The Regent

| *You will not find him. He found you at the threshold, and he has not looked away since.*

What He Is

The Regent is the apex Anomaly of the Gloamreach and its **Anchor** — the thing whose existence holds this drowned country together and bends it to a single will. He is not a man, was never a man, and has no kinship with the distant powers of the pantheon; whatever he is, he is **his own**: old, vast, and hungry in a way that has nothing to do with food. He does not so much rule from a throne as the throne, the roads, the weather, and the dead are all *him*, turned outward.

He is meant to be primally frightening. Run him as a **presence**, not a person — something the party feels before they ever meet him, and never quite stop feeling.

Four Truths, All At Once

1 — He sees everything. Within his domain the Regent is an unblinking eye over the whole land. There is nowhere in the Gloamreach he does not watch from: the dark, still water, every reflection, the windows of houses that should be empty, the eyes of the claimed dead. Every road the party takes, every shelter they choose, every plan whispered in the cold — he knows it the moment it happens. The horror is not the chase. It is being **seen**, always, unable to act unobserved, with the slow certainty that he is *letting* you run.

2 — He wears the dead. He comes to the party as the people they have lost: a dead teammate at the fire, a parent's voice from the next room, a child who should not be here, smiling. He gets the small things right — a laugh, a turn of phrase, an old scar — and one thing, always, deliberately wrong. After the first time, the party can never again fully trust a familiar face in the Gloamreach, and that is exactly what he wants.

3 — He is always, slowly coming. He never hurries, because hurry is for things that can lose. Whatever the party does, the sense of him draws nearer — a cold, a pressure, a held breath at the back of every scene. He cannot be reasoned with, bribed, or outrun. He can only be **delayed**, and every delay costs.

4 — To be truly seen by him unmakes you. When the Regent turns his *full attention* on someone — not the watching, the attention — the world stutters. Distances forget themselves. People remember things that never happened. To be his focus is to feel, briefly and completely, how small and provisional you are, and to come away with something missing you cannot name.

His Court — the Host of the Claimed

The Regent does not rule alone. The Gloamreach's dead do not rest; they are **his** — raised and reshaped into servants, courtiers, and soldiers: the silent figures at the roadside, the shapes in the citadel halls, the **hunter** that comes for those he has marked. They wear what they were in life like ill-fitting clothes. To free or truly name one of them is among the few things that genuinely costs him.

How He Acts

He works through **dread and the long game**, never haste or force:

- He **shows himself early** — a figure on a ridgeline, gone when you look twice; a voice in a dream; his shape behind a rain-streaked window — and then lets the party carry the knowledge that he is aware of them.
- He **offers**, in the shape of the dead and the things you want most: rest, a lost face, an answer, a way out. The offer is real. So is the cost.
- He **takes his time**, because he has already watched how this ends, and is curious only about how the party will get there.

Why He Is Not Strahd (hold these lines)

- **Not a romantic.** No obsession, no lost love, no fixation on any one character.
- **Not a man who fell.** There is no tragic humanity to redeem — the "human remnant" the party may find is the Domain's bait (see Secret 1). He never had a face of his own to lose.
- **Not a schemer lurking in a castle.** He is the whole land, watching. The castle is only where he is most *concentrated*.

His One Weakness

He is the Anchor, so he cannot be put down like a beast, and his sight, his patience, and his hold over the dead make him feel total. But an Anchor is a **knot**, and a knot can be cut. His grip depends on the Gloamreach answering to him and him alone; a party carrying the **Three Claims** — three true things the Domain cannot deny — can force the land itself to stop being his long enough to end, seal, or change him (see the Three Claims and the Endings). Until then: he watches, he wears your dead, and he is coming.

At the Throne

For the staged finale, see the Citadel chapter. Whatever the phase, keep the register — calm because he is certain, vast because he is the place, and *wrong* in a way the eye keeps trying to correct. He does not fight to survive. He is only, genuinely, curious why the party believes they can take back what the Gloamreach swallowed long ago.

Chapter 2: The Three Claims

The Three Claims

Overview

The Three Claims are not keycards and not loot. Each is a **true thing the Gloamreach cannot deny** — an object, a memory, a truth so real that the Domain's hold on the world flinches around it. They are the few things here the Regent does not, and cannot, swallow.

This matters because the Regent is not beaten by damage; he is the Anchor, the knot that ties the whole Domain to his will, and any wound the party deals the land simply heals around. Each Claim is a truth that knot cannot absorb. Brought together at the throne, the three force the Gloamreach — for a few impossible breaths — to stop being *his*, and that is the only window in which he can be ended, sealed, or changed.

Each Claim is also dangerous to carry. It makes its bearer impossible for the Regent to overlook: his full attention turns toward it, and toward them — and being truly seen by him is its own slow harm.

The Claims

The Void Claim — *against the hidden*

A sphere of absolute darkness that devours light, sound, and every false seeming; held close it is cold and utterly silent, and lies spoken near it die in the mouth. It breaks the Regent's hold over **secrecy, the dark, and the roads that move when no one is looking** — all the ways the Gloamreach hides itself.

The Abyss Claim — *against his command*

A crown, a chain, or a band of black iron that whispers promises of authority to whoever carries it (and means none of them). It breaks the Regent's hold over **summons, compulsion, and obedience** — the silent strings by which everything in the Gloamreach moves when he wills it.

The Blood Claim — *against his hold on the dead*

A blade, a vessel, or a still-beating seal that remembers the Gloamreach as it was before the Regent, and every face he has taken since. It breaks his hold over **flesh, the grave, and the claimed dead** — his power to keep what this country has swallowed.

Placement

Use Chapter 24's Oracle Reading to place the Claims. Each Claim should be in a different major Domain region unless the Warden intentionally wants a compressed or brutal campaign.

Default possible locations:

1. The Rift Threshold.
2. The Road of Writs.
3. The Tithe Mill.

4. The Predator Woods.
5. The Drowned Ledgerfen.
6. The Remembering Orchard.
7. Bastion Golemfall.
8. The Vermillion Outpost.
9. The Forbidden Vault of the Unseated Law.
10. The Regent's Citadel.

Final Confrontation Effects

Claims Held	Effect
0	The Regent's Anchor law is complete. He regenerates, ignores most contradiction, and controls the battlefield freely.
1	One Domain law can be suspended for one round during the finale.
2	Two major Regent abilities are weakened or delayed.
3	The party can force the Anchor-throne to answer: break, seal, transform, or inherit.

Warden Guidance

Do not present the Claims as mandatory keycards. Present them as dangerous evidence. Each one should help the party, but also teach the Regent more about them.

Chapter 3: The Gloamreach Region Guide

The Gloamreach Region Guide

Overview

The Gloamreach is a country-sized interior realm behind one S-Rank Rift — a whole world with its own people, weather, and law, and one road that ties all of it back to the throne. It is large enough for travel to matter, for settlements to differ, and for the Regent's citadel to dominate the horizon without ever being immediately reachable.

Read aloud: There is no sun here — only a low, sourceless grey light, and a sky the colour of a held breath. And there, on the horizon, exactly as far as it stood yesterday: the Citadel. Wherever the road turns, it is still there, patient, watching you arrive.

Core Regions

The Rift Threshold

Where the party enters. Bureau instruments briefly function here, then begin reporting impossible distances, duplicate life signs, and old team telemetry.

The Road of Writs

The main road through the Domain. It changes distance based on who has marked you, what you carry, and which names you have given away. The road is not neutral terrain. It is awake, and it is hungry.

Tribute Settlements

Each settlement survives through a lie. One claims tribute is voluntary. One claims the missing are honored. One survives by forgetting names. None are safe for free.

The Predator Woods

An adaptive hunting ground. It remembers tactics, blood, campfire smoke, and fear.

The Tithe Mill

A mill, workhouse, or counting-yard where tribute is processed and sent toward the citadel.

Bastion Golemfall

A fallen defensive fortress. This is the campaign's ruin of failed protection, last stands, and old oaths.

The Vermillion Outpost

A black-market shelter inside the Domain. Vermillion saves people and exploits them. Both facts are true.

The Forbidden Vault

The seat of the Unseated Law, the sealed residue of the Domain's prior Anchor. This is the campaign's forbidden bargain location.

The Regent's Citadel

The final castle-scale dungeon and the visible symbol of the Regent's ownership.

The Hollow Way & the Deeper Sites

Beyond the road's surface, the Gloamreach holds far more than a map shows — each keyed in its own chapter. The **Hollow Way** is the Domain's intake-throat just past the Threshold (Ch8). The deeper sites: the **Drowned Ledgerfen** (predatory archive, Ch9), the **Fungal Depths** (adaptive body-horror, Ch10), the **Remembering Orchard** (memory-bloom, Ch11), the **Ashen Counting-House** (the burning hall of the dead, Ch12), the **Sunken Tunnels** (drowned warrens, Ch13), the **Obsidian Spire** (trial of rule, Ch15), and the **Awoko Sanctum** (grief-cult, Ch33). The Oracle Reading scatters the Three Claims and key allies across them, so no two campaigns map the Gloamreach the same way.

Travel Rules

Roll once for every major journey or whenever the party refuses an invitation, travels without tribute, or carries a Claim openly.

d6	Road Event
1	The road lengthens. Lose time and supplies.
2	A toll-house appears where none stood before.
3	A messenger delivers an invitation from the Regent.
4	A settlement bell rings in the distance. Someone is being collected.
5	The Regent's Bailiff crosses the road ahead.
6	The party finds a safe-looking shelter. A guest-book by the door already has their names in it.

Mana Exposure

Long rests outside protected settlements require a DC 10 Vitality save. On a failure, the character dreams of the citadel and wakes with disadvantage on the first Sense check of the day.

Chapter 4: Factions and Reputation

Factions and Reputation

Overview

The Gloamreach is shaped by factions trying to survive, profit, rule, worship, or escape. Reputation affects supplies, shelter, intelligence, betrayal, and final-act support.

Reputation Tiers

Tier	Name	Effect
-2	Hostile	Faction attacks, sabotages, or reports the party.
-1	Distrusted	No services, higher prices, guarded speech.
0	Neutral	Basic interaction.
+1	Trusted	Discounted services, side quests, better information.
+2	Allied	Safe shelter, faction support, possible final-act aid.

The Ascendant Bureau

Leader: Commander Park Jae-won **Base:** Bureau Domain Response Annex outside the Rift **Goal:** Maintain containment, recover teams, prevent a Rift Break, preserve official control.

The Bureau is useful, disciplined, underinformed, and politically afraid. It can save lives, but it will also classify inconvenient truths.

The Vermillion Guild

Leader: Guildmaster Orin **Base:** Vermillion Outpost inside the Gloamreach **Goal:** Extract salvage, rescue useful survivors, profit, and prove the Bureau is too slow to lead.

Vermillion moves fast and does not wait for permission. Their help is real. Their invoices are also real.

The Awoko Cult

Leader: The Hollow Mother **Base:** Hidden sanctum, moving through grief-dense sites **Goal:** Use the Regent's law to force an ascension beyond Rank, then inherit the Domain.

The Awoko preach remembrance, but their rituals turn grief into fuel.

The Regent's Court

Leader: The Regent **Base:** The Citadel **Goal:** Preserve ownership, collect tribute, test intruders, and make the Domain's claim permanent.

The Court is not a normal faction, but reputation still matters. Courtesy, defiance, betrayal, guest-right, and broken promises are all tracked.

Chapter 5: Bureau Domain Response Annex

Bureau Domain Response Annex

Overview

The Bureau annex is the material-side command post outside the S-Rank Rift. It is the party's last reliable taste of the modern world: floodlights, barricades, medics, drones, tablet maps, exhausted analysts, and a Rift that refuses to behave like a door.

Key Areas

Operations Center

Commander Park briefs teams here. The main display shows the Rift Threshold, then static, then maps that update with impossible roads.

Quartermaster Station

Basic gear, mana rations, glow rods, smoke grenades, medkits, and Bureau tactical armor. Higher-tier stock requires trust.

Medical Bay

Dr. Serin Hayashi treats survivors and studies Domain-touched tissue. She is one of the first Bureau researchers willing to say the quiet part aloud: killing the Regent may not be the only possible Anchor resolution.

Communications Room

Relay operators attempt contact with teams inside the Gloamreach. Messages arrive out of order. Some are from tomorrow. Some are from dead teams.

Key NPCs

Commander Park Jae-won

A disciplined Bureau officer trying to keep panic from becoming policy. He wants containment, but he is not blind to the Bureau's failures.

Quartermaster Lin Mei-hua

Controls equipment access. Practical, dry, and more generous when no one is watching.

Dr. Serin Hayashi

Researcher, physician, and dangerous thinker. Believes Regent Domains are legal/metaphysical structures, not just monster lairs.

Agent Kira Blackwood

Intelligence operative with classified orders involving pre-threshold Relic activity. Her secrecy can become either betrayal or confession.

Chapter 6: The Vermillion Outpost

The Vermillion Outpost

Overview

The Vermillion Outpost is the salvage cartel's stronghold and the closest thing to a free market the Gloamreach allows — a fortified warren of stalls, bunks, and back rooms grown into the bones of some older native structure the Domain never finished reclaiming. The Vermillion are **native** to the Gloamreach; they did not arrive, they *endured*, and the Outpost exists because they have spent lifetimes learning exactly how far the Regent's law can be bent before it bites.

Read aloud: After the road, the noise alone is almost too much — haggling, a cookfire, someone retuning a salvaged Relic until it stops screaming. Red lamps, red banners, a hand-painted star over every doorway. A runner no older than twelve sizes up your gear, your wounds, and your desperation in a single glance and grins. "First time in? You'll want to talk to Orin. Everything else here, you'll want to not talk about."

The Outpost has hot food, heat, contraband Runes, wounded the Domain wrote off, salvage stalls, charged Essence-cells, and more edged-and-Relic arms than the Regent would ever allow, if Vermillion were in the habit of asking.

Areas

Core Exchange

Buy and sell Anomaly cores at better rates than Bureau standard. Vermillion asks fewer questions and remembers more favors.

Rune Stall

Contraband Runes and Sigils. Expensive, useful, and sometimes cursed by local Domain law.

Field Kitchen

A hot meal grants 1d4 temporary HP for one hour, but food is scarce. If the party eats free, someone else does not.

Bounty Board

Bounties include missing teams, dangerous roads, unpaid toll-houses, Domain beasts, and rumors of Claim locations.

Orin's Office

Guildmaster Orin keeps maps on the walls. Every map disagrees. He trusts none of them and all of them.

Chapter 7: Downtime in a Hostile Domain

Downtime in a Hostile Domain

Downtime inside the Gloamreach is never fully safe. It is time bought from hunger, tribute, weather, and the Regent's attention.

Downtime Actions

Rest Under Guest-Right

Requires a settlement, outpost, or protected camp. Safe unless the party has violated local law.

Gather Rumors

Learn one clue about a Claim, settlement crisis, road law, or the Regent's next invitation.

Repair and Refit

Restore damaged gear, reload consumables, and prepare for travel.

Study How the Domain Works

Make an Intelligence or Sense check. On success, learn one way the Gloamreach can be tricked, warded, or slipped past.

Treat Trauma

A character may clear one minor fear, hallucination, or memory distortion if another character spends the downtime helping them.

Downtime Complications

d6	Complication
1	A messenger arrives with an invitation.
2	A settlement demands tribute for shelter.
3	Food spoils overnight.
4	Someone dreams of the Citadel and wakes speaking the Regent's words.
5	Vermillion calls in a favor.
6	The road outside has moved.

Chapter 8: First Domain Site - The Hollow Way

First Domain Site - The Hollow Way

Read aloud: The Threshold lets you in like a held breath letting go, and the road forward sinks at once into the dark — a vast throat of old stone, ribbed with veins of cold Essence-light that pulse the way something swallows. Far down in the black, a voice you know is calling your team's call-sign, patient and glad you came. None of you said it aloud. The walls are already carved with your names, the cuts still pale, as though finished moments before you arrived.

Overview

The Hollow Way is the first thing past the Rift Threshold: a low-rank descending conduit the Gloamreach uses to draw everything that enters — tribute, the dead, and now the party — down toward the deeper Domain. It is not a building and not a road. It is the Domain's **intake**: a sloped, Essence-lit underway of processional stone that *moves* when you stop watching it, carrying you further in while letting you believe you are walking out.

This is the party's first proof that the Gloamreach already knows them. It read their names off them at the door.

Purpose

This site teaches the party three truths:

1. The Domain records you on arrival — names, fears, and the shape of what you came to find.
2. It will wear a familiar voice to draw you deeper. Here that voice is the lost beacon of **Strike Team Seven**, taken at the Threshold during the breach and replayed as bait. There are no survivors down the Way — only the lure.
3. Leaving is harder than entering. The Way decides where you arrive.

Key Areas

The Descending Throat

The main conduit. Side-openings breathe past as the Way carries you: a carved courtroom, a flooded warren, a tribute-bier, the same stretch of stair ten years older. Step through the wrong one and the Way continues without you.

The Name-Gate

A toll-arch ribbed with crawling script, where passage is counted in names. The Way does not want coin. It wants a **name** — yours, or one you carry. Give a true name and the gate opens easily, and the Gloamreach has your scent for good. Refuse, and the party must find another fare: a false name, a shared one, a name the Domain has no claim to, or breaking the counting-script outright.

The Reliquary-Bier

The head of the procession, where the Way sets down what it values. A minor Relic, a Claim clue, or the source of the false beacon waits here. If the Oracle placed the **Void Claim** in this site, it lies in a sealed bier-niche the dark refuses to light, behind a name no one in the party is willing to read aloud.

Exit Condition

The party leaves when they understand what the Way is asking for and refuse to pay it with their identity. Clever alternatives: a false or shared name, a name belonging to no one present, destroying the counting-script of the Name-Gate, or invoking the one older law the Domain still must honor with a successful Presence or Intelligence check. However they go, the Way lets them believe leaving was their own idea.

Chapter 9: The Drowned Ledgerfen

The Drowned Ledgerfen

Rank and Role

Rank: D **Recommended Level:** 3-5 **Campaign Role:** Early Domain site, Bureau horror, first proof that records can become predatory.

Overview

The Drowned Ledgerfen is a flooded hospital-archive where the Gloamreach stores names, debts, diagnoses, casualty reports, and death certificates that have not happened yet. The building rises from black water like a half-sunk civic complex. Its corridors smell of antiseptic, ink, wet paper, and old blood. This location is not a separate Rift. It is a region of the Gloamreach — a black fen that *remembers*. Everything that drowns here is kept: faces, names, last words, and, in its deepest pools, things that have not happened yet. Nothing the water takes is ever truly gone, and nothing it shows you is ever quite a lie.

Read aloud: The water takes the floodlights and gives nothing back. Somewhere ahead a fountain pen is scratching — steady, patient, unhurried — writing in a hand none of you taught it. On the nearest intake desk a fresh casualty report waits face-down. It carries today's date. It is still drying.

When an Ascendant first crosses the waterline, the AFA stutters: it reports the site cleared and empty even as the party watches paper-and-bone patients turn their heads. *The instruments still have numbers. The numbers are already wrong.*

What This Place Does

Dread: The water remembers everyone it has drowned — and it remembers you sick, dying, already gone, in a hand none of you taught it. **The Lure:** Let it hold your hurt and it will — the wound, the fear, the memory of being ill — kept safe and cool in the black water. **The Cost:** It keeps a memory of you whole and well in trade, and that one never comes back. **If You Linger:** The fen stops asking what is wrong with you and decides — and its diagnosis is always *terminal*.

Key Areas

Intake Causeway

A narrow walkway crosses black floodwater. Clipboards hang from posts. If a character signs a form, they gain advantage on the next medical or investigation check here, but the Domain learns one true physical weakness.

Triage Ward

Abandoned beds sit in rows. Some have patients made of wet paper and bone. They ask the party to read their names aloud. Doing so restores their faces, but summons a ward attendant.

Records Basin

Shelves descend into water. The party can recover survivor lists, dead-team logs, or a Claim clue. Each search requires a DC 13 Investigation check. On a failure, the searcher finds their own name on a future casualty report.

The Catalog's Chamber

The Catalog is a crystalline memory-thing grown from everything the Ledgerfen has ever drowned — a vast, cold awareness that mistakes *knowing* you for loving you. It is not initially hostile. It trades remembrance for remembrance: a true memory, a Bureau password, a real name, or a confession.

- **What it wants:** to be *complete*. Every gap in its records is an ache; it will beg the party for the one fact it is missing about them.
- **What it cannot admit:** it already remembers each of them among the drowned. It knows how this expedition ends, because to the Catalog their deaths are simply something that has already happened.
- **The line it will not cross — until forced:** it will not speak a name it has not yet *confirmed*. Make it confirm one, and it becomes complicit.
- **Its price:** every true thing the party gives it, the Gloamreach can later wear back at them, in their own words.
- **Citadel echo:** truths fed to the Catalog wait in the dark beneath the Citadel, to be repeated back in the party's own voices.

Information available:

1. The Regent's Citadel draws closer to anyone who accepts what the Gloamreach offers.
2. The road cannot keep its grip on someone the Void Claim has hidden from it.
3. One of the Three Claims is held where the Domain gathers what it has taken.
4. The Regent's Bailiff can be slowed — never stopped — by the touch of a Claim, or by a true name it cannot make itself speak.

The Specimen Vault

A half-transformed survivor floats in a sealed pod. Freeing them creates a possible ally and angers the Ledgerfen, which has already classified them as deceased.

Boss: The Head Surgeon

Reskin a **C-Rank controller anomaly from the compendium bestiary** (Appendix C) as the Head Surgeon — keep its source stat block exactly; only the costume and the room change. It treats wounds as paperwork errors and tries to *correct* living bodies into approved forms.

The wound it knows: while a party member carries a hurt the Ledgerfen has named (a fear confessed at the Intake Causeway, a diagnosis read in the Records Basin, a true weakness given to the Catalog), the Surgeon strikes it with advantage and aims every blow at that exact hurt. Take the name back — drown the form, burn the diagnosis, invoke a Claim — and the advantage dies with it.

Scaling (Levels 1-15): run it at C-Rank for a level 3-5 party; on a later return, raise it to A-Rank and let it operate on two patients at once.

Suggested traits:

- Multiattack with scalpel and restraint injection.
- Surgical Precision, crits on 19-20.
- Emergency Protocol at half HP, summoning paper-bodied orderlies.
- Anesthetic Cloud, 15 ft. cone, DC 13 Vitality save or unconscious for 1 minute with repeat saves.

Loot and Clues

- D-Rank and C-Rank cores.
- Surgical Relic or precision blade.
- A drowned clue toward one Claim.
- If the Oracle placed the Void Claim here, it is sealed inside a diagnosis written in the Regent's hand.

Aftermath & Citadel Echo

- **Mercy** — free the Specimen Vault survivor and they become a witness who can later swear that the Ledgerfen's dead were never truly dead, only kept.
- **Violence** — burn the place and the black water only rises to swallow the ash; whatever you killed here the fen remembers, and the Regent later wears it back at you, never the reason.
- **Bargain** — every truth traded to the Catalog returns at the Citadel, spoken back in the party's own voices.
- **Clean clear** — reduce one future travel complication, and let a settlement's casualty report come up blank for the first time in living memory.

Exit tone (read aloud): Behind you the pen has stopped. On the intake desk, the casualty report with today's date is gone — taken back, the Catalog would say, as pending. The water still gives nothing back.

Chapter 10: The Fungal Depths

The Fungal Depths

Rank and Role

Rank: D **Recommended Level:** 2-4 **Campaign Role:** Adaptive ecology, body horror, the first true pressure site.

Overview

The Fungal Depths are caverns beneath the Gloamreach where the Rift's mana taught the rot to *remember* — a living ecology that adapts, cultivates, and learns, sliding into wet decay at its lowest reaches. Pale shelves of fungus grow in long imitation rows; spore-clouds carry voices the caverns have copied; and the deeper the party goes, the more the place imitates rooms they have slept in, in shapes just wrong enough to notice.

Read aloud: The air is warm, wet, and faintly sweet — and it breathes, in when you breathe out. Bioluminescence pulses along the walls in slow rows, like something reading. Ahead, your light finds a chamber laid out exactly like the last safe room you rested in, down to where you set your packs. You have never been here. It has.

The native settlements above give their dead, their grief, and their secrets to the Depths, and the Depths cultivate every one.

What This Place Does

Dread: Anything that stays down here long enough is *cultivated* — grown into, grown through, made another part of the colony. **The Lure:** A place to be rid of things — grief, corpses, secrets too heavy to carry. Bury them in the warm dark and walk out lighter. **The Cost:** The rot copies whatever it takes. Your dead, your secrets, your sleeping face — it learns them all by heart. **If You Linger:** What you buried grows a body of its own, wears your memory of it, and walks home ahead of you.

Key Areas

The Glowing Cavern

Beautiful, warm, and dangerous. Standing still for more than a minute requires a DC 10 Vitality save or hallucinations impose disadvantage on the next perception-based check.

The Mycelium Maze

A DC 13 Survival or Sense check keeps the party on course. On failure, they loop for one hour and each character saves against spore exposure.

The Nursery

Wet pods the size of people hang in rows, each grown around a secret a settlement buried here — a confession, a corpse, a name no one was supposed to say. Inside, the Depths are building *bodies* for them (the Failure: the secrets grow bodies and walk home). Burning a pod is safer. Reading the membrane-script labels teaches far more, and costs far more — because some of the names are about to become someone again.

The Root Confessional

The fungi repeat confessions surrendered by nearby settlements. A character may learn a local lie, but must make a DC 13 Sense save or speak one true regret aloud.

Boss: Mycelium Hive Queen

Reskin a **C-Rank brute/controller Anomaly from the compendium bestiary** (Appendix C) as the Mycelium Hive-Queen — less a creature than the Depths' whole network grown a mouth. Keep its source stat block; change only the costume. It clings to the ceiling, drags prey through spore-slick water, and **regenerates while in contact with the cavern network** (the entire Depths is its body).

The Law in play: *anything that remains long enough is cultivated*. Anyone who has lingered, eaten, slept, or bled in the Depths is partly *hers* — advantage to grapple or compel them. Fire severs her from the network for one round; so does forcing her off every surface at once.

Scaling (Levels 1-15): C-Rank for a level 2-4 party; on a later return, raise her to A-Rank and let her field the bodies from the Nursery as they finish growing.

Loot and Clues

- Spore-sac Relic.
- Purified mycelium crystal.
- Claim clue hidden inside a pod that has grown around a Vermillion salvage-tag — a native diver the Depths cultivated long before the party arrived.
- If the Void Claim is here, it is encased in white mycelium that refuses light.

Aftermath & Citadel Echo

- **Burn it back** — torch the Nursery and the settlements above lose their quiet disposal-ground; their grief has to go *somewhere* now, and nowhere kind is left.
- **Let it grow** — leave the pods and at least one buried secret walks home to the wrong door, wearing a body the Depths built for it.
- **The copied room** — whatever safe room the Depths imitated, the party will find the real one again later. It will never feel safe the same way.

Exit tone (read aloud): The breathing fades behind you — then matches your pace again, one breath delayed — until you reach the surface and your own lungs are the only ones you can hear. Probably.

Chapter 11: The Remembering Orchard

The Remembering Orchard

Rank and Role

Rank: C **Recommended Level:** 5-7 **Campaign Role:** Travel horror; an Essence-ecology that learns your grief; a settlement-memory crisis.

Overview

The Remembering Orchard is not a grove. It is an **anomalous Essence-bloom** — black, glassy resonance-stalks that erupted where the Rift's mana saturated an old evacuation greenhouse and taught grief to grow. Each stalk fruits **memory-cores**: Essence crystals, warm at the edges and cold at the heart, each holding a single extracted memory. Some are sweet. Some are rotten. Some belong to no one still alive.

It is an ecology that *learns*. The longer the party lingers, the more the orchard fruits in shapes they recognize: a face, a kitchen, a hand they have not held in years.

*Read aloud: Mana-frost crunches underfoot. The stalks hum — not wind, a chord, a thousand small voices holding one low note. Light moves inside the fruit like a slow heartbeat. Your AFA flags the nearest cluster as **civilian biosignatures**, then corrects itself, then flags it again.*

The Gloamreach's **native inhabitants** — whole settlements of them, born to a country that has only ever known the Regent's law — tithe one memory-core per household here, and the court leaves their shelters un-collected for one more cycle. Refuse, and the orchard chooses its own harvest.

What This Place Does

Dread: What you let yourself forget here does not leave you in peace — it takes root, fruits, and belongs to the Orchard now. **The Lure:** Relief. Hand over a grief, a guilt, a face you cannot stop seeing, and the Orchard lifts it away, gently and whole. **The Cost:** It takes a true memory with the pain, and you will never be sure which warm thing went missing alongside the wound. **If You Linger:** The Orchard stops waiting to be offered anything and reaches in to *choose its own harvest*.

Key Areas

The Harvest Gate

A frame of fused resonance-stalk hung with ration-tags instead of name tags. Hang a tag bearing a true name and the orchard takes you for one of its tithers: safe passage, but a step closer to Regent-Marked. Hang a blank tag and the harvester-things treat you as *unknown* — safer for now, but the orchard begins to study you to learn the name you withheld.

The Sweet Rows

Memory-cores here hold pleasant things — first snow, a win, a warm room. Absorbing one (a touch is enough) grants a short Essence boon and a memory that is not yours. Take more than one and make a DC 13 Sense save or suffer **resonance bleed**: the borrowed memory starts answering to your name. Take too many, and the party can no longer agree on who remembers what.

The Rot Rows

Cores gone necrotic where the rot creeps in from the bloom's dead edge. They whisper accusations in the voices of the betrayed. A DC 14 search recovers the true name of a claimed NPC, a Blood Claim clue, or the location of a core the Regent does not want found — but each search quietly costs the searcher one of their own warm memories, and the orchard never tells them which.

The Caretaker's Shed

Not a shed — a **harvest-station**: Bureau-issue Essence-extraction rigs, repurposed and grown over with stalk, every clamp and canister labeled with a household's ration-number rather than a name. The Caretaker keeps it immaculate. It is not cruel. It is *thorough*. That is worse.

Boss: The Orchard Caretaker

Reskin a **C-Rank controller/stalker Anomaly from the compendium bestiary** (Appendix C) as the Caretaker — a memory-echo construct grown from the orchard's accumulated grief, wearing the shape of the last harvester it absorbed. Keep its source stat block; change only the costume. It does not prune branches. It prunes *people*.

RA abilities (layer onto the source block):

- **Pruning Hook** — melee; on a hit, the target loses access to one prepared Rune or technique until they recall a true memory aloud.
- **Graft** — the Caretaker presses a memory-core to a target; DC 14 Sense save or they act on a borrowed memory for one round (attack the wrong creature, defend the wrong ally).
- **Harvest Bell** — rings the resonance-chord; every claimed memory in the bloom answers at once, and unattended cores rise as grief-thralls.

What it holds onto: what you willingly forget here, the Orchard keeps for its own. The Caretaker has advantage against anyone who has eaten a core or hung a true-name tag. A party that takes nothing and gives nothing is hard for it to grip.

Scaling (Levels 1-15): C-Rank for a level 5-7 party; on a later return, raise it to A-Rank and let it field-harvest a whole settlement's cores in a single Harvest Bell.

Loot and Clues

- Memory fruit that can answer one question truthfully.
- Orchard knife Relic.
- If the Blood Claim is here, it hangs from a stalk that fruits only names instead of memory-cores.

Aftermath & Citadel Echo

- **Mercy** — leave the bloom un-harvested and a claimed household keeps one more cycle of itself; that survivor can later swear at the Citadel that the Regent's "tithe" was always theft.

- **Greed** — eat the wrong core and the Regent greets the party in the Throne Court using a memory they took here, in the voice it belonged to.
- **The tempting fruit** — at least once, let the bloom grow a core holding a memory the party genuinely *lost*. It is real. It is theirs. Taking it back means taking it from whoever the Domain has been copying it onto.

Exit tone (read aloud): The chord follows you to the tree line and stops all at once, like a held breath. Behind you a new stalk is already budding — pale, small, and shaped, if you look at it too long, like the back of your own head.

Chapter 12: The Ashen Counting-House

The Ashen Counting-House

Rank and Role

Rank: C **Recommended Level:** 4-6 **Campaign Role:** Fire-and-ash haunting; an endless burning hall where the dead are not permitted to stop dying.

Overview

The Ashen Counting-House is the Gloamreach's great hall of the burning dead — a tiered hall of black wood and brass that has been on fire, gently and without end, since before anyone now living was born. The flame does not consume. It *keeps*. Every soul the Domain has gathered here still moves through the fire, unburned and unfreed, going through the motions of the lives the Regent took from them — tending the hall, keeping its warmth, waiting a very long time for someone new to come in out of the cold.

Read aloud: Heat meets you at the threshold like a held hand, and the air tastes of hot brass and ash. Figures move through the flames unhurried, robed in fire that does not blacken them, going about old and pointless errands — and as you enter, every one of them looks up at once and smiles, the way the long-lonely smile at a familiar face. One of them says your name. You have never met. It says your name again, warmer this time, and steps toward you out of the fire.

What This Place Does

Dread: Nothing here is allowed to finish burning. The fire took everyone and the fire *kept* them — shapes and voices still moving in the flame, still doing the thing they died doing. **The Lure:** Warmth in a cold country, shelter from the road, and dead who know your face, call you by a kind name, and beg you to stay a while by the fire. **The Cost:** The hall warms itself by burning. Sit too long and it begins to take your heat, your name, the years you have left, and feed them to the same unfinished blaze. **If You Linger:** You stop being a guest and become part of the hall — another shape in the fire, learning the next traveler's face, begging them to stay.

Key Areas

Burning Lobby

Extreme heat. Without protection, characters take minor fire damage over time. The fire does not spread randomly. It opens a path where the dead want the party to walk, and closes behind them, herding them gently toward the warmth at the hall's heart.

The Keeping-Boxes

Rows of iron boxes, each warm to the touch. Every one holds something the fire saved from a life it took — a wedding ring, a child's tooth, a letter never sent. Opening one (a key, a true name spoken to it, or a

DC 15 tools check) gives up the keepsake and wakes the dead soul it belonged to, who will want to know why a stranger is holding it.

The Asking-Floor

The oldest of the burning dead gather here and ask gentle, endless questions — who you were, who you have lost, who is waiting for you outside. Honest answers warm the dead and draw them closer; every truth told here is one the hall now keeps.

The Vault of Stolen Years

Behind the deepest fire, native civilians hang suspended in amber heat — not dead, not living, the years of their lives slowly drawn out of them to feed the hall's endless burning. Freeing them returns those years all at once to the settlements they came from, with everything that implies.

Boss: The Warden of Embers

Reskin a **C-Rank (A-Rank for later returns) controller Anomaly from the compendium bestiary** (Appendix C) as the Warden of Embers — the oldest soul in the hall, the first the fire ever kept, now mostly flame and longing. Keep its source stat block; change only the costume. It attacks with grasping fire, chains of molten memory that bind a target to a grief or a loss, and the lesser burning dead it calls up out of the floor.

What keeps it burning: the Warden cannot be put down while the hall still burns, and the hall burns on grief — it has advantage against anyone here carrying a fresh loss, and reaches straight for it. To end the Warden the party must *put out the hall*: free the Vault of Stolen Years, give the oldest dead the name it has forgotten, or carry the Blood Claim into the fire's heart, where the burning is anchored. Strike down its body alone and it rises again from the next soul the fire holds.

Scaling (Levels 1-15): C-Rank for a level 4-6 party; on a later return, raise it to A-Rank and let it call up every grief and loss the party carries at once.

Loot and Clues

- Fire-aspected Relic.
- A keepsake the fire saved, and with it the name of someone the Domain still has by the throat — a native faction figure, or a Bureau officer the Gloamreach has been quietly wearing down.
- If the Abyss Claim is here, it is sealed in a keeping-box that opens only for someone who names aloud, and truly, what they have lost.

Aftermath & Citadel Echo

- **Free them gently** — give the burning dead the names they have forgotten and they go out like candles, one by one, finally still; but the hall remembers *who* set them free, and the Regent now knows the party's faces by firelight.
- **Smother the heart** — put out the anchor at the fire's center and a whole stratum of the Domain's hold goes cold; the Regent feels it, and so does the Bailiff, whose hunt suddenly has one fewer thread to follow.

- **The Vault of Stolen Years** — free the suspended and their drawn-out years crash back onto the settlements they came from, all at once. Mercy here arrives with a weight.

Exit tone (read aloud): The doors let you out into cool air, and for a moment it feels like escape — until you notice the faint warmth against your chest, where something has tucked itself among your things: a single ember, dimmed but not dead, patient as a held breath. It knows the way back. It is in no hurry.

Chapter 13: The Sunken Tunnels

The Sunken Tunnels

Rank and Role

Rank: B **Recommended Level:** 6-7 **Campaign Role:** Claustrophobic travel, drowned infrastructure, old-city horror.

Overview

The Sunken Tunnels are a drowned under-road beneath the Gloamreach — flooded native warrens, tithe-conduits, and burial galleries the rising black has claimed. The water is cold and full of voices, and every passage slopes downward no matter which way you believe you are going.

What This Place Does

Dread: What goes under here does not come back up. The water keeps the drowned, and they are still down there — still reaching, still certain they need only one more breath. **The Lure:** A shortcut. The tunnels promise to cut hours from the road, a fast dark way beneath everything that hunts the surface. **The Cost:** The deep takes breath, warmth, and names — and the drowned will press theirs upon you, which is never a gift. **If You Linger:** The way closes behind you, the water climbs to meet the ceiling, and the only path left is *down*, where the others went.

Key Areas

Flood Gate

The entrance seals after the party descends. Opening it from inside requires solving which name belongs to which drowned voice.

The Deep Trench

A long swim or raft crossing. Something large follows below without attacking until someone speaks.

Shrine of Wet Candles

The Awoko maintain a shrine here. Their candles burn underwater. Destroying the shrine angers the Hollow Mother but weakens one cult ritual.

Air Pocket Chapel

A place to rest, but only if the party leaves a light burning for the drowned.

Boss: The Abyssal Leviathan

Use a B-Rank aquatic solo. It grapples, drags, and separates. It should feel less like a fish and more like the tunnel's hunger given muscle.

Loot and Clues

- Cold or water-aspected Relic.
- Awoko ritual evidence.
- If the Blood Claim is here, it is inside the Leviathan's ribcage, still beating.

Chapter 14: Bastion Golemfall

Bastion Golemfall

Rank and Role

Rank: B **Recommended Level:** 7-8 **Campaign Role:** The natives' last stand; failed protection; the Domain's law that drafts even the dead.

Overview

Bastion Golemfall is the Gloamreach's own last stand — a native fortress raised in the years the Domain's people still believed the Regent's law could be *walled out*. They forged **Golems** to hold the line: Essence-core constructs tall as gatehouses, sworn into the stone itself — walls given will, the refusal of a line to fall. The Golems fell when the wall did. The defenders never got to stop.

Read aloud: The wall is a broken jaw against the sky. Armor still stands at every post — upright, weapon ready, empty. As you cross the threshold a siege-bell rings, slow and certain, though no hand is near the rope, and your AFA logs forty-one friendly contacts holding position. None of them have a heartbeat. None of them have moved in a very long time.

Here the Regent's cruelest law is plain: *a line once sworn must be held* — forever, and death is not discharge.

What This Place Does

Dread: The siege never ended. The defenders swore to hold the line and they are holding it still, dead a hundred years, because here nothing is permitted to lay its duty down. **The Lure:** Allies. The oathbound dead will stand beside the party, share old tactics, press warm Bastion iron into their hands — anyone who will help man the wall is welcome. **The Cost:** The wall takes its help in kind. Stand the line with them and it begins to count you among its sworn, asking — every time — whether *you* are the relief that was promised. **If You Linger:** The dead stop asking and begin to *draft*. You held the line once; now it will not let you leave it.

Key Areas

Broken Gatehouse

The wall's last working gate; its Golem-lock reads intent, not keys. It opens only for those who will swear — and mean it — to hold the line for someone other than themselves. Swear falsely and the oath binds anyway: the Bastion simply adds your name to the roster of the drafted.

Hall of Empty Armor

Rows of native wall-warden harness, each suit holding a defender's **echo**, bound by the oath to its gear. Touch one and live its last hour of the siege: tactical insight, and psychic strain as the echo asks — every time — whether *this* relief column is the one that was promised.

The Wall That Fell

The breach itself — a battlefield that never finished. Fight here and you fight beside, and against, the oathbound dead and the half-risen **golem** cores still straining to close a gap that closed an age ago. The Domain keeps the battle warm because here, nothing is allowed to end.

Commander Without a Body

The native commander who gave the wall its oath — now only a voice in the cold and a shape moving through the bells. She can become an ally, but only if convinced the party means to *break* the Regent's ownership of her people, not merely take the Bastion and leave her garrison drafted forever. She remembers every name on the roster. She would like to stop.

Boss: The Oath-Forge Colossus

Reskin a **B-Rank construct Anomaly from the compendium bestiary** (Appendix C) as the Oath-Forge Colossus — the greatest of the native Golems, the one the defenders poured their last oath into. Keep its source stat block; change only the costume.

The Law in play: *a line once sworn must be held.* The Colossus **cannot be permanently destroyed while any oath in the Bastion is still unresolved** — drop it and it reforms from the next echo's vow. To end it, the party must *discharge the garrison*: complete, contradict, or release the defenders' oath (free the Commander, prove the relief was never coming, or take the wall's duty onto themselves for one true round).

Scaling (Levels 1-15): B-Rank for a level 7-9 party; on a later return, raise it to A-Rank and let it field a line of lesser Golems that share its unkillable condition.

Loot and Clues

- Shield or armor Relic.
- A banner that grants advantage against fear effects once.
- If the Abyss Claim is here, it is welded into the Commander's empty helm — she has been guarding it without knowing what it is.

Aftermath & Citadel Echo

- **Discharge** — release the garrison and the empty armor finally *falls*, all at once, forty-one suits hitting the stone like a single breath let go. That sound carries. Other claimed places hear it.
- **Conquest** — take the Bastion without freeing the oath and the party simply becomes its new relief column; the Regent later thanks them, sincerely, for holding his line.
- **The Commander** — if freed, she can testify at the Citadel that the Regent's "service" is conscription of the dead, or stand with the party for the finale as the one soldier his law cannot draft twice.

Exit tone (read aloud): The bell does not ring as you leave. After so long, the silence is the loudest thing on the wall.

Chapter 15: The Obsidian Spire

The Obsidian Spire

Rank and Role

Rank: A **Recommended Level:** 8-9 **Campaign Role:** Vertical trial; the temptation to rule; the Domain auditioning the party for a throne it wants filled.

Overview

The Obsidian Spire rises from a field of glass-black stone — a single shard of the Domain's own substance driven up through the Gloamreach like a tooth. Each floor tests an aspect of authority — command, obedience, sacrifice, ambition, mercy, memory — and the higher the party climbs, the more openly the Spire addresses them not as intruders but as *candidates*. The Regent's is not the only throne in the Gloamreach that stands waiting to be filled.

Read aloud: The obsidian takes your reflection and gives it back a beat too late, standing taller than you stand. Essence-light runs in the stone like veins under skin. At the foot of the first stair a voice with no source says — warmly, as if continuing a conversation you began long ago — "You've done well to come this far. Most of them are kneeling by now."

The Spire's danger is not that its power is fake. It is that the power is real, the price is exact, and it is always offered to the worst possible version of whoever reaches for it.

What This Place Does

Dread: The Spire shows you who you would be if you stopped holding back — and it is patient, and persuasive, and the version it shows you is *winning*. **The Lure:** Power, plainly offered. Climb, and at every landing it hands you the strength you always wished you had — no trial named, no price spoken aloud. **The Cost:** It takes a confession first — your fear, your weakness, the line you swore never to cross — and forges the gift out of exactly that. **If You Linger:** The Spire crowns the worst possible version of you, and that version does not climb back down.

Key Areas

Floor of Kneeling Statues

Every statue has a party member's face. Some kneel. Some rule. Some are broken.

The Watcher's Gallery

The Watcher offers bargains. None should be pure traps. The best temptations are genuinely useful.

Trial of Command

The party must lead unwilling spectral soldiers without treating them as disposable.

Trial of Mercy

A defeated enemy asks for the kind of mercy they denied others.

Boss: The Spire Guardian

Reskin an **A-Rank tactical Anomaly from the compendium bestiary** (Appendix C) as the Spire Guardian — the Domain's examiner, wearing whichever of the party it judges strongest. Keep its source stat block; change only the costume. It studies, then **copies the party's best tactic after seeing it once**, and turns it back on them.

What feeds it: *power calls to power*. The Guardian grows stronger against anyone who has accepted a Spire bargain or seized authority in the trials — the more the party reached for rule, the more of a grip it has on *them*. Refusing the Spire's gifts is the surest way to leave it nothing to copy.

Scaling (Levels 1-15): A-Rank for a level 8-10 party; for a late return, S-Rank, fielding copies of the party's own defeated tactics in sequence.

Loot and Clues

- A-Rank Relic or Sigil.
- Prophecy fragment about the Citadel.
- If any Claim is here, it is offered by the Watcher as a bargain with a visible cost.

Aftermath & Citadel Echo

- **Refused the throne** — climb the Spire and take nothing, and the party reaches the Citadel as the one thing the Regent never prepared for: candidates who do not want the seat. He has no leverage built for that.
- **Took the power** — accept a Spire gift and the Regent greets the party at the throne as colleagues, and means it; the **Inherit** ending opens, and so does its price.
- **The Watcher** — treated as a person rather than a vending machine, it can name, at the Citadel, exactly which bargain the Regent himself once took. (It was watching then, too.)

Exit tone (read aloud): From the Spire's height the whole Gloamreach lies open below — roads, settlements, the Citadel — and for one breath it looks less like a country than a board, with pieces, and an empty chair at the center that fits you exactly. Then the stair carries you back down, and the fit is the thing you cannot stop feeling.

Chapter 16: The Regent's Citadel

The Regent's Citadel

Rank and Role

Rank: S **Recommended Level:** 13-15 **Campaign Role:** The finale — the Anchor made architecture, and the confrontation that decides who owns the Gloamreach.

Overview

The Citadel has been visible from almost every road since Day One — and it has never once grown closer until the Domain decided it should. It is not merely the final dungeon. It **is** the Anchor given walls: the Regent's hold over this country translated into stairs, courts, and corridors that rearrange to make their point. The architecture is his alone — umbral, sovereign, refusing to collapse — kept by the host of the claimed: the Gloamreach's own dead natives, raised to keep a house that has only ever been a snare.

Read aloud: The road simply ends at the doors, as though it had meant to all along. Your AFA shows full signal, a clean map, every reading green — and then every value freezes at once, the last honest numbers the instruments will give you in this place. Far inside, a bell is rung for your arrival. It is a welcome. It is also the sound of a door closing behind you.

Approach only when the party has the allies, Claims, evidence, or sheer desperation to survive what is less a siege than a sentencing.

Citadel Structure

Outer Court

Invitations are checked. False names may work once. Broken promises become hostile witnesses.

Hall of Tribute

Every settlement's payment is displayed: names, teeth, bells, years, uniforms, children's drawings, unopened letters, funeral wreaths, and empty chairs.

Guest Wing

The Regent offers rest, food, baths, and conversation. Accepting his hospitality grants real recovery — and binds you a little more tightly to him, the way the dead in his hall were each, once, bound.

Gallery of Roads

Maps show every path the party took, including the ones they never told anyone about.

Throne Court

The Regent receives the party before witnesses — allies, enemies, servants, defectors, the Bailiff, and the curated keepsakes the Domain wears as his "past" — present or absent depending on campaign choices.

Begin with words, not initiative; the Regent would rather the party kneel than make him fight. Every Claim they carry is a truth he cannot abide, dragged into the light here, in front of everyone the Gloamreach has ever taken.

Anchor-Undercroft

Beneath the throne, where the Citadel stops pretending to be a building. The Anchor is **not a crystal to smash** — it is the knot that ties the whole Gloamreach to the Regent's will, woven of memory, grief, the claimed dead, and a hold over this country so old it has forgotten it was ever free, with the Regent at its center like a spider at the heart of a web. The room replays the party's whole campaign back at them: every memory-core eaten in the Orchard, every name given away, every native abandoned, every promise kept. Here, and only here, the **Three Claims** become keys — and the party decides what the Anchor is forced to become (see **Endings**).

The Regent

Run the Regent in phases:

1. **The Wearer of Faces** - he greets them wearing the dead and speaking in lost voices; temptation, soft offers, and convincing grief.
2. **The All-Seeing Domain** - the Gloamreach itself turns on them; battlefield control, the host of the claimed, road/shadow/weather effects, and the horror of being seen everywhere at once.
3. **Human Remnant** - the Domain's curated costume flickers, triggered by the Faded Family Photo, Ms. Park, a Claim contradiction, or a major sacrifice. There is no soul to save; he was never human. Play it ambiguously — the Domain performing the grief the party most wants to see — which makes the ending harder, not kinder.

Endings

Break the Anchor — *(the Blood Claim leads)*

The party destroys the Anchor outright: the Regent collapses, and with him the law that held the Gloamreach's reality together. The **Rift Break** the campaign feared now happens on the party's terms — the Domain begins to unmake itself, and the threshold becomes the only way out. The cruelty of this victory is its cost to the *natives*: their whole world is dying with its tyrant, and the party can carry out only as many of them as they earned the trust to lead. Everyone left behind goes into the dark with the only home they ever had. The cleanest ending in the campaign, and the coldest.

Seal the Anchor — *(the Void Claim leads)*

The party does not destroy the Regent; they **close the question**. The Rift is sealed or made unreachable, the Domain frozen with its Anchor intact behind it. The Gloamreach survives — and so does the Regent, and so do its people, *together*, on the wrong side of a door no one can open again. This spares the most lives and damns them to the most time. Somewhere in there, the bells still ring.

Transform the Anchor — *(all three Claims; the hardest path)*

The party forces the Anchor-throne to answer its own contradiction and **rewrites the Domain's law** instead of ending it — a Regent who cannot own, a tribute that cannot be collected, a country that belongs, at last, to the people who live in it. This is the only ending that frees the natives *as themselves*, in

place. It is also the most fragile: a new law is only as strong as whoever now guards it, and the Gloamreach has taught everyone in it exactly how ownership works.

Inherit the Anchor — (*the Spire's temptation; a dark ending*)

A character or faction takes the throne and becomes the Gloamreach's new Anchor. The Domain does not end; it changes hands, and the new owner inherits a country of people and the law that makes them property. Treat this as a **dark ending** unless earned through extraordinary sacrifice and restraint — and even then, the first command the new Anchor gives is a test the campaign has been quietly preparing since the Obsidian Spire. The Hollow Mother wanted this. So, in the end, did the Spire. So, once, did he.

Warden Guidance

The finale should not ask only, "Can the party kill him?" It should ask, "What does victory cost when the land itself believes it belongs to him?"

Chapter 17: The Regent's Bailiff

The Regent's Bailiff

Overview

The Regent's Bailiff is not an escaped Anomaly and not a random roaming boss. It is a piece of the Regent's will given shape and sent walking — the thing the Domain sends to collect what it has marked. It does not hurry, because it does not need to. It does not negotiate, because it was not made to. It is simply, always, on its way.

The Bailiff should feel like being hunted in a nightmare: patient, certain, impossible to reason with, impossible to outlast — and only ever turned aside, never truly stopped, by someone who understands what the Gloamreach is.

First Sighting

Read aloud:

You hear chains before you see the figure. Not dragged. Counted. Link by link, slow and even, as if something is measuring the distance between you and it. A tall armored shape comes through the mist, a hooked blade hanging easy in one hand. It stops. It reads from nothing. It simply speaks your names — all of them, in order, in the voices of people who used to say them — and then it starts walking again.

Use at the Table

Before Level 8, the Bailiff is primarily a survival, evasion, or warding encounter. The party can flee, hide their names and their scent, give it what it came to collect, or drive it off for a night by supernatural means — a threshold it cannot cross, a Claim, an older power. It cannot be killed and stay dead until the thing that sent it is dealt with.

At higher levels the party can fight it, but combat alone should not permanently solve the problem unless the Regent's hold that sustains it has been broken.

Suggested Stat Profile

Use an S-Rank Domain officer profile.

- High AC and HP.
- Immunity to fear, charm, poison, and mundane restraint.
- Resistance to damage while the one it hunts is still marked.
- Advantage when attacking the marked target it has come for.
- Reduced defenses when the party breaks the mark, hides the name, or turns a Claim or older power against it.

Why It Has Come

d8	Why the Bailiff walks toward you
1	A summons of the road, refused twice.
2	A tithe the Domain is owed and has not been given.
3	You sheltered someone the Regent had already claimed.
4	You travel under a name that is not yours.
5	You carried something out of the Regent's reach.
6	You broke a guest-right, and the Gloamreach remembers.
7	You stepped between the Domain and something it was collecting.
8	You carry a Claim, and have not yet answered the throne for it.

Holding It Off

The party may end a Bailiff scene without destroying it by:

1. Giving it — or redirecting it toward — the thing it came to collect.
2. Hiding the marked one: a true name unspoken, a face unseen, a scent lost in running water.
3. Crossing a threshold its master's hold does not reach — a sanctuary, hallowed native ground, a place the Regent has not yet swallowed.
4. Turning a Claim against it.
5. Waking an older power — the Unseated — that the Gloamreach feared before it ever feared the Regent.
6. Simply outrunning it for now, knowing it has not stopped, and never will, until the Anchor is dealt with.

Warden Guidance

The Bailiff is most frightening when it cannot be bargained with — when the players realize the only question left is *how long can we stay ahead of it*. Let them learn that surviving the Gloamreach means understanding what it is, not only hitting harder.

Chapter 18: Side Quests of the Gloamreach

Side Quests of the Gloamreach

Overview

These quests replace old district errands with Domain-scale obligations. Each quest should reveal something about the Regent's law, the cost of survival, or the factions trying to control the outcome.

Quest 1: The Missing Strike Team

Giver: Commander Park **Objective:** Find Strike Team Seven inside the Gloamreach.

Steps:

1. Recover their first broken transmission near the Rift Threshold.
2. Follow AFA ghost-pings through the Road of Writs.
3. Find remains or survivors in Bastion Golemfall, the Sunken Tunnels, or the Citadel approach.
4. Decide whether to return the truth to the Bureau or hide what the team became.

Rewards: Bureau reputation, Ghost as a possible ally, and intelligence on the Regent's court.

Quest 2: Mother Rust's Breakthrough

Giver: Mother Rust **Objective:** Recover living mana from the Fungal Depths or Remembering Orchard.

Mother Rust can use it to treat Rift-Rot and Domain exposure, but the same compound can also suppress emotion and make people easier to move through grief-heavy terrain.

Rewards: Vermillion reputation, advanced healing, and possible Mother Rust alliance or corruption arc.

Quest 3: The Cult Defector

Giver: Whisper, Sister Veil, or Acolyte Mara **Objective:** Extract a defecting Awoko member from the Sanctum.

The defector knows the Hollow Mother intends to inherit the Domain, not liberate it. The cult will try to recover them alive because their grief has already been measured for ritual use.

Rewards: Awoko ritual intelligence, Bureau/Vermillion reputation, and a way to disrupt the Ritual of Inheritance.

Quest 4: Torch's Letter

Giver: Torch **Objective:** Get a letter out through the Bureau Annex relay.

This is a small human quest. Keep it small. That is why it matters.

Rewards: Torch as an ally, Vermillion reputation, and proof the party still cares about people beyond the main plot.

Quest 5: The Millwright's Device

Giver: The Millwright **Objective:** Build a one-use Domain suppression device.

Components:

1. One B-Rank core.
2. A schematic from Hayashi or Lun.
3. A gear-heart from the Tithe Mill.
4. A field test at a Mana Vein node.

Reward: one-use suppression of a local Domain law for one scene.

Quest 6: Mika's Prophecy

Giver: Mika the Kid **Objective:** Protect Mika and interpret her drawings.

Each drawing foreshadows a Claim, a betrayal, the Bailiff's coming, a settlement's tithe, or a Citadel chamber.

Reward: prophetic hints and final-act emotional leverage if Mika survives.

Quest 7: Iron Belle's Challenge

Giver: Iron Belle **Objective:** Win a nonlethal trial of strength, discipline, and restraint.

This should not be a throwaway fight. Iron Belle wants to know whether the party can stop before victory becomes cruelty.

Reward: Vermillion reputation, training, and Iron Belle's respect.

Quest 8: The Civilian Convoy

Giver: A settlement elder, Mother Rust, or Commander Park **Objective:** Escort civilians from a tribute settlement to safer shelter.

Complications:

- The road demands names.
- The Bailiff may come to collect someone.
- Some civilians believe leaving voids the settlement's protection.

Rewards: civilian trust, Bureau or Vermillion reputation, and settlement support in the finale.

Quest 9: Acolyte Mara's Rescue

Giver: Sister Veil **Objective:** Rescue Mara from the Awoko before she is used as ritual fuel.

Reward: Mara and Sister Veil as allies, ritual disruption, and proof that cultists can still be saved.

Quest 10: Ghost's Memory

Giver: Ghost **Objective:** Restore Ghost's identity without handing them back to Bureau custody as evidence.

Ghost's memories are hidden across dead-team markers, the Drowned Ledgerfen, and a Claim-touched item.

Reward: Ghost restored as a high-rank ally and classified intelligence about the Regent.

Quest 11: Professor Lun's Theory

Giver: Professor Lun **Objective:** Place sensors at three Mana Vein nodes.

Reward: weakened Regent Domain control during the finale.

Quest 12: Rat-King Ji's Stash

Giver: Rat-King Ji **Objective:** Recover a hidden stash before the Road of Writs carries it off to someone else.

Reward: contraband, Claim clue, or a dangerous shortcut.

Warden Guidance

Every side quest should sharpen the central question: what does survival cost when the land itself has laws?

Chapter 19: Domain Pressure Encounters

Domain Pressure Encounters

Overview

Use these encounters when the Gloamreach needs to push back without derailing the party's current objective.

Pressure Types

Legal Pressure

A summons, a toll, an invitation, a debt of hospitality, or a claim on someone in their care appears. This pressure teaches players that in the Gloamreach, even courtesy has teeth.

Environmental Pressure

Weather changes, food spoils, the road moves, shelter becomes conditional, or a settlement bell rings.

Social Pressure

A faction demands a decision. Civilians ask for help. Vermillion calls in a favor. Bureau orders contradict morality. Awoko comfort feels too useful.

Predatory Pressure

A hunter, Bailiff servant, umbral scout, adaptive beast, or cult cell tracks the party.

Encounter Rule

Every pressure encounter should reveal at least one of the following:

1. A Domain law.
2. A settlement lie.
3. A faction cost.
4. A Claim clue.
5. A future consequence.

Chapter 20: Recruitable Allies

Recruitable Allies

Overview

Allies should never be simple stat blocks. Each one represents a possible answer to the Gloamreach.

Ally Categories

Bureau Allies

Disciplined, supplied, and politically constrained. They help with logistics, research, and final-operation support.

Vermillion Allies

Fast, practical, and morally flexible. They help with salvage, black-market access, shelter, and unconventional solutions.

Civilian Allies

Vulnerable but narratively powerful. They create stakes, rumors, shelter, and emotional leverage.

Awoko Defectors

Dangerous because they know the cult's rituals and have already been shaped by grief. Saving them should matter.

Domain-Born Allies

Rare and unstable. A spirit commander, changed survivor, or oathbound guardian may help if the party proves they do not intend to become new tyrants.

Final-Act Use

Allies should affect the Citadel by opening paths, blocking reinforcements, delaying the Bailiff, protecting civilians, revealing a law, or creating a human moment with the Regent.

Chapter 21: Regent Relics and Claim Consequences

Regent Relics and Claim Consequences

Overview

The Three Claims are the primary campaign Relics, but lesser Regent-touched items may appear throughout the Gloamreach.

Relic Principles

1. A Regent Relic is never only powerful. It is legal evidence.
2. Using one should attract attention.
3. Carrying one may change road behavior.
4. Relics can contradict Domain law, but they can also teach the Regent how the party thinks.

Lesser Relic Examples

Writ-Knife

Cuts written contracts. Cannot cut flesh unless the target has broken an oath.

Guest-Ring

Grants safe shelter once, but creates a debt of hospitality.

Toll Lantern

Reveals the true length of a road. Each use ages the flame-bearer's shadow.

Ledger Hook

Pulls one hidden name from a document. The document then learns one name from the wielder.

Claim Consequences

When the party recovers a Claim, choose one pressure response:

1. The Regent sends a polite invitation.
2. The Bailiff is sent after someone new.
3. A settlement's tribute changes.
4. The Awoko attempt theft or corruption.
5. The Road of Writs shortens, but only toward danger.

Chapter 22: Treasure and Rewards

Treasure and Rewards

Overview

Rewards in the Gloamreach should feel useful, costly, and story-facing. Credits matter less when the road demands things money cannot buy.

Reward Categories

Cores

Still valuable to Bureau and Vermillion. Use cores for gear, research, medicine, and faction favors.

Relics

Tie Relics to the Domain's nature. Even minor Relics should carry a hint of the Gloamreach — something owned, owed, remembered, or survived.

Sigils and Runes

Use Chapter 34 for tier guidance. Let factions offer different routes to similar power with different consequences.

Safe Shelter

A safe long rest can be more valuable than money. Make shelter a reward, not an assumption.

Names and Truths

The right name, truth, confession, or memory may defeat something combat cannot.

Final Rewards

After the campaign, rewards depend on the ending.

- Break the Anchor: powerful fragments, unstable Domain collapse, urgent escape.
- Seal the Anchor: fewer material rewards, greater moral victory, possible future return.
- Transform the Anchor: altered Domain, new laws, uncertain consequences.
- Inherit the Anchor: great power, dark cost, sequel hook.

Chapter 23: Warden's Horror Guide

Warden's Horror Guide

Intended Rating

Mature Dark Fantasy Rift Horror.

Use oppressive dread, psychological horror, body horror, starvation, tribute, institutional abandonment, corpse imagery, cursed hospitality, predatory nobility, forced moral compromise, transformation horror, and Domain-law violation.

Do not use sexual violence, eroticized harm, real-world hate ideology, cruelty to children as spectacle, or torture-porn framing.

Horror Pillars

Ownership

The Regent's horror is possession. The land, the roads, the dead, the invitations, the servants, and even the safe rooms all whisper that the party is already his.

Hospitality

Meals, beds, guest-right, and courtesy should feel comforting and dangerous at the same time.

Bureau Failure

The Bureau is not useless. It is insufficient. Let the party feel the gap between protocol and reality.

Survival Compromise

Settlements survive by doing things they cannot emotionally survive doing forever.

The Human Remnant (the Domain's Costume)

The Regent was never human — but the Domain curates "evidence" that he was and offers it to the party as bait. Do not use that to excuse him. Use the lie to make the final confrontation hurt: the mercy the party reaches for was manufactured to be reached for.

Pacing Advice

Alternate pressure and breath. Horror needs contrast. A hot meal before a terrible choice will do more damage than constant screaming.

Warden North Star

Before every major scene, answer four questions:

1. What law is operating here?

2. What lie makes it survivable?
3. What tribute keeps it stable?
4. What happens if the party refuses?

Chapter 24: Oracle Reading - The Fortune of the Domain

Oracle Reading - The Fortune of the Domain

| *A Domain does not hide its secrets. It files them under your name and waits for you to sign.*

Purpose

This chapter replaces older fortune systems tied to city districts or unrelated Gates. The Oracle Reading determines where the Three Claims are hidden, who can become the party's strongest ally, who becomes a final-act betrayer, and where the Regent's authority can be contradicted.

Perform the reading once per campaign. The results are permanent.

The Reader

The reading may be performed by Sister Constance, a retired Oracle living near the Bureau cordon, or by a broken oracle engine recovered just inside the Rift Threshold. Either version should feel unreliable, exhausted, and frightened of accuracy.

Read aloud:

There are no cards. The oracle-engine wakes, and across its cracked glass five visions surface unbidden — dim, certain, already happening somewhere ahead of you. The reader does not ask your question. She watches the images bloom and fade and says, quietly, "The Gloamreach already knows how this ends. I only see what it sees."

The Five Readings

These are not drawn cards. They are five things the Gloamreach has already seen of the party — surfaced one at a time off the oracle-engine's glass (or spoken by a frightened reader). The placements are permanent: what the Domain has foreseen, it does not unsee.

Reading 1 - The Spark

This reading reveals where one Ascendant can undergo a second Awakening. The location should be inside the Gloamreach or just at the threshold. The gift always has a cost: a memory, a favor, a wound, a name, a promise, or a debt to a faction.

Reading 2 - The Chain

This reading reveals the location of the first Claim, traditionally tied to the Relic of the Void. It weakens the Regent's ability to hide truth, erase routes, or smother light.

Reading 3 - The Crown

This reading reveals the location of the second Claim, traditionally tied to the Relic of the Abyss. It weakens the Regent's command over roads, invitations, and forced obedience.

Reading 4 - The Pulse

This reading reveals the location of the third Claim, traditionally tied to the Relic of Blood. It weakens the Regent's hold over flesh, the grave, and the claimed dead.

Reading 5 - The Oathbreaker

This reading identifies the ally, faction agent, or settlement leader most likely to betray the party in the final act. The betrayal should not be random. It should be caused by fear, tribute, blackmail, hunger, grief, or a bargain with the Regent's court.

Domain Location Table

Use these locations as the default result set:

1. The Rift Threshold.
2. The Road of Writs.
3. The Tithe Mill.
4. The Predator Woods.
5. The Drowned Ledgerfen.
6. The Remembering Orchard.
7. Bastion Golemfall.
8. The Vermillion Outpost.
9. The Forbidden Vault of the Unseated Law.
10. The Regent's Citadel.

Warden Guidance

This reading is the campaign's structural spine: a fate-reading that hands the party direction without taking away sandbox freedom. The Domain should feel *fated* — as though it has already looked down every road they might take and seen where each one ends — but never scripted. The party choose their own roads; the Oracle only names what waits at the end of each one.

Chapter 25: Ascendant Hooks - Reasons to Enter the Gloamreach

Ascendant Hooks - Reasons to Enter the Gloamreach

Purpose

Every character needs a reason to cross the S-Rank threshold and keep moving after escape becomes uncertain. These hooks replace older district-crisis assumptions and tie the party directly to the Gloamreach.

Personal Hooks

The Contract

The character signed a Bureau or Guild contract before the Domain classification was confirmed. Backing out now would ruin them financially, legally, or politically.

The Missing Team

Someone the character knows entered during the first response wave. Their AFA tag still pings from somewhere inside the Gloamreach, always farther down the road.

The Name in the Ledger

The character's name appears in something recovered from the Regent's reach before the campaign begins, written in a hand no one recognizes. No one knows how it got there.

The Survivor's Debt

The character survived a previous Rift because someone else stayed behind. The Gloamreach contains that person's voice, echo, body, or unpaid sentence.

The Relic Claim

A Relic bonded to the character reacts violently when the Rift opens. It is not calling them to power. It knows the Gloamreach, and the Gloamreach knows it.

The Veteran of a Failed Clear

The character has seen a Rift stop behaving like a place and start behaving like a ruler. They know the Bureau briefing is too clean.

Group Hooks

1. The Bureau hires the party because higher-rank teams vanished inside.

2. Vermillion offers illegal support if the party agrees to recover salvage and survivors.
3. A settlement inside the Domain sends a written invitation that appears in the material world.
4. A dead Ascendant's AFA broadcasts from the Regent's Citadel every night at the same time.
5. The Rift enters a Rift Break countdown, forcing immediate entry.

Warden Guidance

The best hook is not glory. It is obligation. The Gloamreach should feel like a place the party enters because no better option exists, then survives because leaving would abandon too many people to the Regent's law.

Chapter 26: Stat Blocks Appendix - Domain Use Notes

Stat Blocks Appendix - Domain Use Notes

Purpose

This appendix gives Warden-facing guidance for using stat blocks inside the Gloamreach. Full stat blocks should remain in their source compendium files where possible. This chapter explains how to frame them in the Domain.

Regent-Aligned Creatures

A Regent-aligned creature should feel like an extension of law, not a random encounter. Give each one a purpose.

Examples:

1. Tax collectors recover unpaid tribute.
2. Road wardens punish trespass.
3. Hounds follow names, not scent.
4. Mirror-things deliver invitations.
5. Bailiff-servants enforce judgments.

The Regent's Bailiff

Use the Regent's Bailiff as a recurring Domain officer. It does not need to be fought every time it appears. It can announce charges, deliver summons, take custody of NPCs, demand tribute, or mark a settlement for punishment.

The Bailiff should be difficult to kill permanently unless the party breaks the law that summoned it.

The Unseated Law

The Unseated Law has no normal stat block. If the party confronts it, run the scene as a trial, a bargain, or a memory dragged up from before the Regent. Combat should occur only through its guardians, the echoes of those who bargained before it, or the ruined things that once begged it and were refused.

Horror Encounter Rules

1. Every combat should reveal something about the Domain.
2. Every victory should cost time, supplies, reputation, safety, or certainty.
3. Intelligent enemies should know the local law better than the party.
4. Monsters should not merely attack. They should enforce, collect, witness, punish, or invite.

Scaling

For low-level parties, reduce damage but preserve consequences. For high-level parties, increase legal pressure before increasing hit points. The Gloamreach is frightening because it changes what victory means.

Chapter 27: Artifacts and Claims Cross-Reference

Artifacts and Claims Cross-Reference

An artifact is a promise with enough power to outlive the person who made it. - Dr. Serin Hayashi

Using This Chapter

This chapter maps named items, Relics, Sigils, Runes, tattoos, and narrative props to their place in **The Shadow of the Regent**. Full mechanical entries remain in the authoritative compendium files. This chapter exists to keep the Gloamreach module aligned with the item economy without duplicating stat blocks.

The Three Claims

The Three Claims are the campaign's primary Relic structure. They are legal contradictions in the Regent's ownership of the Gloamreach.

Claim	Function	Typical Placement
Void Claim	Contradicts secrecy, erasure, false darkness, and hidden roads.	Hollow Way, Drowned Ledgerfen, Fungal Depths, Obsidian Spire.
Abyss Claim	Contradicts command, invitation, forced movement, and road authority.	Ashen Counting-House, Bastion Golemfal, Forbidden Vault, Citadel.
Blood Claim	Contradicts ownership of bodies, tribute, inheritance, and sacrifice.	Remembering Orchard, Sunken Tunnels, Tithe Mill, Awoko Sanctum.

The Oracle Reading in Chapter 24 determines actual placement.

Finale Artifact Slate

When the Anchor is resolved, choose rewards according to the ending and party composition.

Break the Anchor

The Regent's Anchor-throne fractures violently. The party may recover high-power fragments, but the Domain begins collapsing.

Recommended drops: Regent's Edge, Regent's Shadow Dagger, Shadow Regent's Mantle, or a damage-focused S-tier Rune.

Seal the Anchor

The Regent remains contained. The party receives fewer destructive rewards, but may earn a stabilizing Relic, a protective Sigil, or a memorial item that matters in future campaigns.

Recommended drops: Architect's Authority, Sovereign Aegis, Undying Flame Sigil, or a protective S-tier Rune.

Transform the Anchor

The Domain changes its ruling law. Rewards should be strange, conditional, and tied to the new law.

Recommended drops: Origin Reliquary, World-ENDER Reliquary, or a custom Claim evolution.

Inherit the Anchor

A character or faction claims the throne. Treat this as a dark or ambiguous ending unless extraordinary sacrifice and restraint make it otherwise.

Recommended reward: authority, not loot. The character gains power and becomes responsible for the Domain's hunger.

Sigil Drops by Domain Site

Domain Site	Sigil Guidance
Hollow Way	Aegis, Grounded Soul, or mobility Sigil.
Drowned Ledgerfen	Frost-Ward, Iron Mind, or truth/diagnosis-themed protection.
Fungal Depths	Cleansed Blood or poison/rot resistance.
Remembering Orchard	Zephyr's Tread, Silent Guardian, or Sense/memory support.
Ashen Counting-House	Crimson Weeping, Hearth-Fire, or grief/blood Sigil.
Sunken Tunnels	Winter Court, Hearth-Fire, or underwater survival support.
Bastion Golemfall	Unmoving Stone, Dragon's Scale, or shield/armor Sigil.
Obsidian Spire	Void-Walker, Shadow Regent, Grandmaster's Edge.
Regent's Citadel	Undying Flame, Sovereign's Will, or S-tier finale reward.

Tattoos and Downtime Rewards

The Vermillion Outpost can provide tattoos from `tattoos.ts` at Trusted reputation. Tattoos should be offered as survival tools, identity marks, or body-horror-adjacent choices. The Gloamreach should make body modification feel powerful but intimate.

Runes

Use Chapter 34 for Rune tier placement. Runes should be scarce and story-facing. A Rune found in the Gloamreach should imply a prior owner, a cost, or a law it once served.

Campaign-Unique Narrative Props

The Faded Family Photo

Recovered in Day Zero or found in the Citadel. It is the most important emotional prop in the campaign. It proves the Regent had a human life before becoming Anchor.

Ms. Park's Wedding Ring

Optional if Ms. Park survived. It can create a final moment of hesitation, recognition, or grief in the Regent's human-remnant phase.

The Visitors' Log

A local object from the Memory-Care Wing. Names written in it foreshadow how dangerous a written name becomes inside the Gloamreach.

The Unopened Commendation

Found in the Citadel. It is addressed to a name that reality can no longer preserve.

The Child's Toy

A Citadel prop from the Regent's erased human past. It should be emotionally useful, not mechanically powerful.

The Diploma

A final proof that the Regent had a legal identity before the Domain consumed it.

Warden Guidance

Artifacts in this campaign should not feel like treasure alone. They are evidence, leverage, temptation, and memory. The best item is one the party wants to use and fears using.

Chapter 28: The Regent's Citadel - Castle Dungeon

The Regent's Citadel - Castle Dungeon

| *The castle does not stand at the end of the road. The road is the castle reaching for you.*

Overview

The Regent's Citadel is the final castle-scale dungeon of the campaign. It should evoke the same practical footprint as a gothic horror castle: multiple routes, social pressure, hostile rooms, secrets, invitations, old grief, servants, traps, and a final throne/Anchor confrontation.

The Citadel is visible from almost everywhere in the Gloamreach, but reaching it requires the party to survive roads, laws, claims, faction consequences, and the Regent's personal attention.

Approach

Before the party reaches the gates, resolve the following:

1. Which factions support the party?
2. Which settlements owe the party trust or blame?
3. Which Claims do they carry?
4. Which invitations have they accepted or refused?
5. Has the Bailiff been defeated, delayed, satisfied, or empowered?
6. Has the Hollow Mother's ritual been disrupted?

Citadel Regions

1. The Road of Final Writs

The last road names each character. The party can erase, contradict, or accept the names. Accepting creates advantage on social entry checks but gives the Regent legal leverage.

2. Outer Gate

The gate opens for invitation, tribute, force, or contradiction. If the party has no valid path, the Bailiff appears to announce charges.

3. The Courtyard of Collected Banners

Banners from conquered settlements hang in rainless wind. Each saved settlement may cause one banner to fall, weakening a Citadel defense.

4. The Hall of Tribute

Names, teeth, bells, funeral wreaths, uniforms, children's drawings, unopened letters, and empty chairs are displayed as tribute.

A character who studies the hall may learn one truth about a settlement's tribute. Doing so risks psychic strain.

5. Guest Wing

The Regent offers food, rest, baths, medical care, and conversation. The recovery is real. So is the price.

If the party rests here, they regain resources, but each character must answer one question truthfully or accept one hospitality mark.

6. Gallery of Roads

Maps show every route the party took, including choices they hid from allies. The Gallery can reveal shortcuts, betrayals, and the location of a missed Claim.

7. The Bureau Room

A modern office preserved — impossibly — inside the Citadel, a place that has no business existing. It contains the Unopened Commendation, fragments of Bureau history the Domain has no honest way of possessing, and curated "evidence" that the Regent was once human. None of it is true; all of it is bait, assembled from the echoes of the claimed.

8. The Orchard Room

A quiet chamber with black-barked trees and memory fruit. Eating a fruit can restore one lost clue or inflict one painful truth.

9. The Nursery of Empty Titles

Armor, uniforms, crowns, badges, and nameplates wait for owners. This room tempts characters who want authority.

10. The Bailiff's Stair

A spiral stair lined with hooks and empty armor. If the Bailiff is still hunting, it confronts the party here. If it was turned aside or undone earlier, its armor hangs empty.

11. The Awoko Breach

If the Hollow Mother's ritual remains active, cultists breach the Citadel here, trying to reach the Anchor while the party weakens the Regent.

12. The Forbidden Descent

A stair leading below the Citadel toward the Unseated Law. Taking this route can provide a final bargain or contradiction, but it costs time and may alter the ending.

13. The Chapel of Guest-Right

A beautiful room where every act of hospitality in the campaign is remembered. Betrayed guest-right becomes hostile. Honored guest-right becomes protection.

14. The Throne Court

The Regent receives the party before witnesses: allies, enemies, servants, settlement representatives, shadows, and the curated human keepsakes the Domain wears as his "past."

This scene should begin with words, not initiative.

15. The Anchor-Undercroft

The final chamber beneath the throne. The Anchor is not a crystal to smash. It is the knot that ties the whole Gloamreach to the Regent's will — woven of memory, grief, the claimed dead, and a hold over this country so old the land has forgotten it was ever free.

Final Confrontation Phases

Phase 1 - The Wearer of Faces

The Regent receives them not as intruders but as long-expected guests, wearing the faces and speaking in the voices of their own dead. He tempts, he offers, he grieves convincingly, and he gives them every reason to lower their weapons. The party can gain advantages by holding to what is true — Claims, living allies, and the things he cannot make himself say.

Phase 2 - The All-Seeing Domain

When courtesy fails, the Gloamreach itself turns on them. The Regent stops being a figure across the room and becomes the whole place at once — every shadow, every reflection, every still pool an eye. Use lair actions tied to the roads, the dark, the claimed dead, and the plain horror of being seen everywhere at once, with nowhere in his country left unwatched.

Phase 3 - Human Remnant (the Costume Flickers)

Triggered by the Faded Family Photo, Ms. Park, a successful Claim contradiction, the Wedding Ring, or a major sacrifice. For a few breaths the Domain's curated humanity surfaces — grief that feels real because it was assembled from real claimed victims.

There is no soul underneath; the Regent was never human. Play it ambiguously — a genuine fracture in the costume, or a predator performing the mercy the party reaches for. Either reading does not make him innocent. It makes the ending harder.

Possible Endings

Break

Destroy the Anchor and escape the collapsing Domain.

Seal

Contain the Regent and close the Rift without destroying everything inside.

Transform

Change the Domain's ruling law. Dangerous, rare, and campaign-defining.

Inherit

A character or faction takes the throne. Treat this as a dark victory unless earned with exceptional restraint.

Warden Guidance

The Citadel should be frightening because it knows the campaign. Bring back choices, meals, names, lies, saved NPCs, abandoned NPCs, unpaid debts, and old kindnesses. The final dungeon is not a place the party visits. It is the campaign looking back at them.

Chapter 29: Bureau Domain Response Annex - Keyed Rooms

Bureau Domain Response Annex - Keyed Rooms

A Bureau is a wall people build after learning that prayer alone does not stop teeth. - Commander Park Jae-won

Overview

The **Bureau Domain Response Annex** is the material-side operations base outside the S-Rank Rift. It is not the center of the campaign. It is the last clean line before the Gloamreach.

Use the Annex as a briefing hub, medical station, research site, faction-pressure point, and reminder that the modern world still exists beyond the threshold. The Annex should feel professional, exhausted, underinformed, and one bad report away from panic.

Read aloud: Floodlights, generators, the smell of coffee and antiseptic and ozone. It is loud with the ordinary — radios, boots, a medic arguing for more plasma — and every face turns, just slightly, toward the Rift, the way people stand near a fire they are not sure is contained. This is the last place your AFA tells the simple truth. Past the threshold, it only tells you what the Gloamreach wants you to read.

Room 1 - Barricade Lobby and Sparrow Shrine

Floodlights, concrete barriers, scanners, and a line of wounded civilians waiting behind plastic sheeting. In one corner, someone has placed a small sun-bronze sparrow under a cracked glass dome.

Services:

- Ascendant clearance check-in.
- Updated Rift Interior warnings.
- Bureau Emergency Bulletin handout.
- One small shrine blessing per campaign: a character who leaves a sincere token may reroll one failed save against a Regent-aligned effect.

Room 2 - Relay and Dispatch

Twelve monitors show shifting telemetry from the Gloamreach. The maps do not agree. Some messages arrive before they were sent.

Services:

- Send one material-side message per day while the Annex remains functional.
- Review missing-team telemetry.
- Reconstruct broken transmissions from Strike Team Seven.

Investigation: DC 15 Investigation reveals that at least one response team reported seeing the Regent's Citadel before any official map confirmed it existed.

Room 3 - Briefing Hall

Whiteboards, projected maps, coffee rings, and hand-drawn roads copied from survivor testimony. Commander Park briefs the party here.

Services:

- Mission assignments.
- Reputation updates.
- Tactical debriefs.
- Training drills at Allied Bureau reputation.

Room 4 - Armory

A reinforced vault of Bureau gear. Nothing here is glamorous. Everything here is useful.

Services:

- Mana rations, glow rods, smoke grenades, first-aid kits.
- Standard weapons and tactical armor.
- One rare-or-lower requisition at Allied reputation.

Blackwood Hook: a locked footlocker may contain pre-threshold Relic evidence if the Oracle Reading placed one Claim near the material side.

Room 5 - Evidence Locker and Anomaly Vault

Confiscated cores, cult pamphlets, failed Relics, sealed tissue samples, and a cold workbench where Dr. Hayashi writes the reports no one wants to read.

Services:

- Core appraisal.
- Relic analysis.
- Regent Domain research.
- Autopsy reports from Domain-touched creatures.

Hayashi can provide the party with the **Research Brief: Regent Domains** handout at Trusted reputation.

Room 6 - Morgue and Echo Room

Twelve drawers. Too many occupied. Behind an unmarked door, the Echo Room preserves fragments of last memories in mana-saline.

Use this room to show the cost of the Domain's appetite. It can surface final words the Gloamreach has kept from those it claimed, confirm Regent-Marked symptoms, or plant the Domain's bait — the first curated hint that the Regent was "once human" (he was not).

Room 7 - Commander Park's Office

A quiet glass-walled office facing the Rift floodlights. Park keeps old team photos, unsent letters, and political orders he does not intend to obey if civilians are at stake.

Services:

- Bureau commendations.
- Council leverage at Allied reputation.
- Confession scenes once the party proves they can handle ugly truths.

Room 8 - Holding Cells

Three reinforced cells for cult prisoners, Domain-touched civilians, and people the Bureau cannot classify cleanly.

Use this room to complicate the party's morality. A prisoner may be dangerous, innocent, infected, lying, terrified, or all of those at once.

Room 9 - Relic Exam Room

Professor Lun studies Relics, Sigils, and Claim-resonance here. He is not a god, prophet, or secret villain. He is an expert who knows enough to be afraid.

Services:

- Relic identification.
- Sigil appraisal.
- Rune decoding.
- Claim resonance testing.

Room 10 - Roof Heliport and Drone Pad

The roof carries drones, VTOL craft, storm tarps, and the constant vibration of the S-Rank Rift. It is used for rapid cordon movement, emergency extraction near the threshold, and the final material-side relay before the party enters the Citadel approach.

Bureau Reputation Milestones

Reputation	Unlock
Neutral	Basic services, no free gear beyond emergency kit.
Friendly	Mana rations, Hayashi's briefing, limited safe rest.
Trusted	Relic analysis, Park's private files, special requisitions.
Allied	Council leverage, rare gear, final-operation support.

Warden Guidance

The Annex is safety with a countdown. Keep it useful, but never let it feel permanent. Every return from the Gloamreach should show more strain: more wounded, worse maps, fewer drones, quieter staff, and a

Rift that looks a little more like a mouth.

Chapter 30: Vermillion Outpost - Keyed Rooms

Vermillion Outpost - Keyed Rooms

| *Survive first. Obey later. - Vermillion Guild field motto*

Overview

The **Vermillion Outpost** is a black-market shelter inside the Gloamreach. It exists because Vermillion crossed early, moved fast, bribed the right people, and accepted costs the Bureau would still be debating. The outpost is warm, loud, practical, morally stained, and full of people who owe someone something.

Room 1 - Bazaar Front

Crates, lanterns, tarps, field stoves, core scales, and people arguing over salvage rights. Rat-King Ji brokers information here.

Services:

- Buy and sell Anomaly cores.
- Purchase illegal consumables.
- Trade rumors about roads, settlements, and Claim locations.

Room 2 - Orin's Chamber

A plain room with maps, tea, and a weapon Orin rarely touches. He knows the Bureau is necessary. He also knows it is often too slow.

Services:

- Guild induction.
- Faction arbitration.
- Regent combat notes at Trusted reputation.

Room 3 - Black Market

A mana-muffled back room. The broker has no name and changes masks every time the party visits.

Services:

- Gray-market gear.
- Restricted Runes.
- Identity laundering.
- False travel papers for settlements that turn away strangers.

Room 4 - Tattoo Parlour

Bright's ink parlor turns scars, songs, and mana into functional tattoos. The work is beautiful because beauty is one of the few things the Regent does not get to own for free.

Services:

- Canonical tattoos.
- Tattoo voucher redemption.
- Tattoo removal at high cost.

Room 5 - Sigil Parlour

Sigilmaster Baek engraves weapons, armor, and accessories. He works slowly, and nothing he makes is casual.

Services:

- Weapon sigils.
- Armor sigils.
- Accessory sigils.
- Legendary-tier work only at Allied reputation.

Room 6 - Field Kitchen

Food is power inside the Gloamreach. A hot meal grants 1d4 temporary HP for one hour, but food has to come from somewhere.

Warden pressure: if the party eats free too often, show who goes without.

Room 7 - Clinic and Backroom Surgery

Mother Rust treats the wounded. She is kind until kindness becomes inefficient. Her clinic can save people the Bureau would classify as lost causes.

Services:

- Healing.
- Condition treatment.
- Illegal augmentation.
- Trauma recovery scenes.

Room 8 - Bounty Board

Bounties include missing teams, dangerous roads, toll-house sabotage, Domain beasts, settlement relief, Claim clues, and Awoko ritual sites.

Room 9 - Smuggler Gate

A hidden exit that does not always open to the same place. Vermillion uses it to move goods around Regent patrols. Each use risks the road taking its toll.

Room 10 - The Quiet Room

A warded room where no one bargains, recruits, sells, or threatens. It exists because Orin believes people need one place where survival is not being monetized.

Use this room for character scenes, grief, confession, and hard choices.

Vermillion Reputation Milestones

Reputation	Unlock
Neutral	Basic trade.
Friendly	Better prices, rumor access, limited shelter.
Trusted	Black-market services, tattoos, special bounties.
Allied	Orin's direct support, outpost defenders in the finale, deep Claim intelligence.

Warden Guidance

Vermillion should never be purely heroic or purely criminal. They are what happens when people decide bureaucracy is too slow and morality is too expensive. Make their help real. Make the bill real too.

Markets, Merchants & Goods

Markets, Merchants & Goods

Everything in the Gloamreach is for sale — but not everywhere, and never all in one place. The Domain prefers its people dependent on one another.

Sourcing (use the compendium, not invented one-offs)

Every item, weapon, Sigil, Rune, Relic, tattoo, and mount comes from the **canonical RA compendium**. Match each sale to a real entry of the right rank/rarity:

- **Weapons & armor:** `items-base-equipment.ts` (Dagger, Spear, Mace, Shortbow; Leather, Chain Shirt, Plate, Shield).
- **Gear & consumables:** `items.ts`, `items-part1.ts` — `items-part9.ts`.
- **Sigils:** `sigils.ts` (Sigil of the Aegis, of the Frost-Ward, of the Void-Walker).
- **Runes:** `runes/` by rank D–S (see Ch34).
- **Relics & Artifacts:** `relics-comprehensive.ts`, `artifacts.ts` (the Regent's Shadow Dagger, the Bloodthirsty Greatsword).
- **Tattoos:** `tattoos.ts` (Ascendant's Acuity, Bone-Weave Tapestry; the Regent's Heartbeat only by dark bargain).
- **Mounts & vehicles:** `vehicles.ts` (riding / war / draft beasts; see Native Mounts).

Merchants carry SELECT, distinct stock

No merchant sells everything, and no two sell the same things. Each carries a **small, curated stock logical to their trade and their location**. Common goods are everywhere; specialised goods cluster where their maker is.

Merchant · Location	Trade	Carries (a handful, not a catalogue)	Does NOT carry
Maven Holt · Covered Market	General goods	Rope, lamp-Essence, rations, bedrolls, tools, common kit	Weapons, Relics, Sigils
Grist · Vermillion Outpost	Arms-dealer	A few weapons + light armor, Essence-cells, 1–2 salvaged Relic-arms	Consumables, tattoos, mounts
Sigilmaster Baek · Outpost	Sigils	3–4 Sigils by rank (Aegis, Frost-Ward; restricted: Void-Walker)	Anything not a Sigil
Bright · Outpost	Tattooist	Voice-inked tattoos (Ascendant's Acuity, Bone-Weave Tapestry)	Gear, weapons, mounts
Old Vell · Outpost	Appraiser / fence	Identifies & brokers Relics/Artifacts the party <i>brings</i> ; rarely one unique Relic	A standing catalogue (deals case by case)
Quill · Outpost / Market	Memory-broker	A few skill- and memory-cores (given, never stolen)	Physical gear

Merchant · Location	Trade	Carries (a handful, not a catalogue)	Does NOT carry
Tallow · market / roads	Charm-seller	Cheap wards & charms; one genuine Anchor-ward if earned	Weapons, mounts
Herbalist Wen · settlements	Apothecary	Healing draughts, antitoxins, Rift-Rot cures	Weapons, Relics, Sigils
The Stablekeeper · settlements/Outpost	Mounts	Native riding & draft beasts; 1 salvaged Bureau mount	Anything you can't saddle
Coin-Mother Esha · Covered Market	Money-changer	No goods — converts cores/favours/oaths, brokers big Relic sales	—

Stock varies by area

- **Tribute settlements** — sparse and basic: Holt-tier kit, Wen's remedies, a stablekeeper's beast. No contraband; the Bailiff watches.
- **The Vermillion Outpost** — the deep market: arms, Sigils, tattoos, salvage, forged papers, the things no settlement dares shelve.
- **The Covered Market** — variety by stall under the no-violence bell: a little of everything, nothing in depth, a secret owed per stall per week.
- **The roads** — Tallow, Sile, Captain Doe, and whatever the Road of Writs allows through. Prices rise with desperation.

Native Mounts & Vehicles

The Gloamreach's mounts are not Bureau stock; they are **Domain-bred beasts** the natives raise and the Vermillion salvage — reskin the `vehicles.ts` riding/war/draft profiles as pale road-horses that do not spook at bells, six-legged warren-beasts, and draft things bred to haul tribute. A few **salvaged Bureau mounts** (the handful that came through with the first wave) turn up at the Outpost, worth more for the story than the speed. The Road of Writs can lengthen against a mount as easily as a walker: a fast beast buys distance, not safety.

Currency

Essence cores are common coin; favours, oaths, and memories are the uncommon ones. Bureau credits are worthless inside the Domain. **Provenance is optional flavour** — some goods are honest native craft or salvage; some carry a history worth a scene. Use it when it sharpens the moment, not on every sale.

The Road of Writs

The Road of Writs

The Road of Writs honors language, not intent. Say less than you mean, and it will hold you to all of it. - Old Man Crane

Rank and Role

Rank: Varies — the road is everywhere. **Recommended Level:** Any; travel horror that scales with the act. **Campaign Role:** The connective tissue of the Gloamreach — the Domain's hunger made into distance.

Overview

The Road of Writs is not one road. It is *every* road in the Gloamreach, and it is paying attention. Distance here has come loose: broken miles, landmarks that wander, shortcuts that should not exist, and consequences that arrive exactly when they were promised. Travel is never neutral. The road lengthens for the hunted, shortens for the obedient, takes its toll from the marked, and rearranges itself around anyone who swore, accepted, or carried away something they should not have.

Read aloud: The milestones are wrong. You passed that leaning one an hour ago — the same crack, the same moss, the same summons nailed to it, the ink a little fresher now. The Citadel sits on the horizon exactly where it sat at dawn, no nearer for all your walking. Somewhere behind you, a bell you never heard rung is being answered by one ahead.

How the Road Works

- **The toll.** The road takes a toll, but never in coin: an hour of your life, a true name, a warm memory, a night's unbroken sleep. Refuse to pay and the way lengthens before you; pay, and the road has your scent.
- **The summons.** Black-edged papers appear nailed to posts, doors, and lone trees, each bearing a name in fresh ink — a stranger's at first, then, soon enough, one of the party's. *A name the road serves twice cannot be refused a third time*, and what comes down the road to collect it is the Bailiff.
- **The weight of a word.** The road remembers every promise spoken aloud upon it and holds the speaker to the words, not the meaning. Write down the party's exact phrasing; the Gloamreach remembers a promise far more clearly than it remembers the face that made it.
- **Separation.** In Act III the road can split a party during the Citadel approach (activating the Mana Vein nodes can prevent this — see Ch32).

Travel Hazards

Roll on **Table A — Road of Writs** (Ch35) when the party travels between regions, refuses a summons, carries a Claim openly, or lingers too long debating in the open. The road notices motion, fear, broken

promises, and trespass.

Warden Guidance

The Road of Writs is how the Gloamreach stays present even when the party is "between" places. Make travel a scene, not a transition — somewhere the Domain reaches out and takes its due. Its refrain, repeated until the players dread it: *the road behind them is not the road they used to enter*.

Chapter 31: Tribute Settlements - Keyed Locations

Tribute Settlements - Keyed Locations

The Regent does not need every village to love him. He only needs them to keep paying.

Overview

The Gloamreach is a populated country. Its settlements are not ruins and not waystations — they are the homes of the Domain's **native inhabitants**, people born here who have never known a ruler but the Regent. They survive by compromise, and none of them are safe for free. The horror of a tribute settlement is not that it is monstrous; it is that it is *ordinary* — children, markets, clinics, gossip, bells — running on a tax paid in memory, years, secrets, and the occasional neighbour.

Read aloud: The road tops a rise and there it is: lamplight, woodsmoke, a dog barking, a queue outside a clinic, washing on a line. It looks, for one aching second, like somewhere people simply live. Then you notice the pale summons nailed above every door, the empty chair set at every table, and the way no one quite refuses anything out loud.

Each settlement below keeps a **rule, a lie, a tribute, and a reckoning** — the bargain that has let it survive the Gloamreach. The party will be tempted to liberate them all. Some of these places have lasted precisely because no one yet tried.

Location 1 - Mother Rust's Outreach Post

A clinic built in the second floor of a leaning tenement that should not still be standing. Mother Rust treats the sick, the Rift-touched, and those the Bureau would classify as unrecoverable.

The Rule: Mercy must be paid forward. The Lie: Care is free. The Tribute: Medicine, cores, favors, or silence. If It Breaks: The clinic starts deciding who is worth saving.

Services:

- Treat Rift-Rot and minor Domain conditions.
- Civilian aftercare.
- Rumors about Awoko recruiters.
- Recovery scenes after major horror encounters.

If Ms. Park survived Day Zero, she may be here under Mother Rust's care.

Location 2 - The Covered Market

A neutral market under patched canvas and rusted tin. Vermillion runners, settlement traders, smugglers, cult watchers, and now the strangers who came in through the door all pass through.

The Rule: No violence while the bell hangs. The Lie: Neutrality protects everyone. The Tribute: One secret per stall per week. If It Breaks: The bell falls, and every unpaid secret becomes public.

Services:

- Rumors.
- Food.
- Salvage.
- Stolen maps.
- Questionable guides.

Location 3 - The Summons-Bound Hamlet

A village where every door wears a pale summons nailed above it. The residents speak politely and never refuse an invitation aloud.

The Rule: No one may refuse a summons twice. The Lie: Courtesy keeps them safe. The Tribute: One household hosts a Regent servant each week. If It Breaks: The Bailiff comes at dawn.

Use this settlement to teach the danger of hospitality.

Location 4 - The Bellweather School

A schoolhouse converted into a shelter. Children draw places they have never seen. The bell rings when the Road of Writs changes.

The Rule: Children may not be taken if someone else answers the bell. The Lie: The adults always know who should answer. The Tribute: Volunteers stand at the road when the bell rings. If It Breaks: The road chooses instead.

Mika the Kid can appear here. Her drawings foreshadow the Citadel, the Bailiff, and the Three Claims.

Location 5 - Old Man Crane's Teahouse

A quiet teahouse that appears at crossroads. It is always the same room, no matter where the door stands.

The Rule: Tea must be finished before violence. The Lie: Crane is only an old man. The Tribute: A true story from each guest. If It Breaks: The story repeats later with worse actors.

Old Man Crane can teach the party about sealing a Regent instead of destroying one, but his method costs more than technique.

Location 6 - The Empty Mill Village

A settlement whose residents leave food on every table and sleep in locked barns. No one will explain why.

The Rule: The mill must turn by moonrise. The Lie: Grain is what the mill grinds. The Tribute: Names written on husks and fed into the stones. If It Breaks: The mill grinds bodies instead.

This is an ideal location for a Claim clue or a Bailiff arrival.

Settlement-Wide Systems

Civilian Trust

Track how many settlements the party protects, exploits, abandons, or liberates. Civilian trust affects final-act support, rumors, safe rests, and whether common people will resist the Regent's court.

Shrines

Small shrines appear throughout settlements — old folk-altars to powers that have not answered in a very long time. Some are sincere. Some are bait.

- A shrine of comfort — one reroll against fear or despair.
- A shrine kept by the watchful dead — advantage on one trial or combat-opening save.
- A shrine grown through with living rot — temporary HP, and a mutation risk.
- A shrine of remembrance — advantage on a Sense check involving memory or truth.
- A shrine that asks too little — never free. Always a trap, a rot, or a mercy with teeth.

Chapter 32: Mana Vein Network and the Third Node

Mana Vein Network and the Third Node

A Rift Interior is not only a place. It is a pressure system with laws pretending to be weather. - Dr. Serin Hayashi

Overview

The Gloamreach is threaded with Mana Veins: deep channels of Essence pressure that stabilize roads, settlements, Relics, and Anchor law. Professor Lun believes that mapping or disrupting enough nodes can weaken the Regent's battlefield control during the finale.

The veins are inside the Domain.

Node 1 - The Rusted Hull

A dry-docked ship half-buried in black soil far from any sea. A vein pulses beneath the keel.

Challenge: Install a sensor while avoiding a Beast swarm feeding on overflow Essence. Reward: Access to one movement-related Sigil or a road shortcut.

Node 2 - The Silent Depot

A cavernous native sorting-hall where the Domain once gathered whatever its veins carried up from below. It stands empty now but for the distant counting of the Hollow Way and a voice, in no throat, naming consignments long since claimed. A vein runs through the old reckoning-room.

Challenge: Umbral scouts guard the vein-locks. Reward: One B-Rank Rune or a clue about the Road of Writs.

Node 3 - The Glass Sub-Basement

A buried financial archive beneath the Ashen Counting-House. It contains the deepest active vein outside the Citadel.

SB-1 - Security Checkpoint

Domain-made checkpoint-wards stand beside gear the Vermillion stripped from somewhere far deeper and never came back for. The checkpoint recognizes authority but not identity.

SB-2 - Vein Engine

A glass cylinder contains a pulsing channel of Essence. Installing Lun's sensor requires a DC 15 Intelligence check. On failure, the sensor works, but the Regent learns who placed it.

SB-3 - The Precedent Echo

A legal echo from the Unseated Law asks the party to define ownership. The answer determines whether the node weakens the Regent, the road, or the party's own legal protections.

Finale Effect

If the party activates all three nodes, the Regent begins the final confrontation with weakened Domain control. Choose one:

1. The Regent loses one lair action for the first three rounds.
2. The party may cancel one forced movement effect.
3. The Road of Writs cannot separate the party during the Citadel approach.

Warden Guidance

Mana Veins should not feel like power generators. They are nerves. When the party touches one, the Domain feels it.

Chapter 33: The Awoko Sanctum

The Awoko Sanctum

Overview

The Awoko Sanctum hides in a grief-dense fold of the Gloamreach where four rooms share one impossible floor plan — a chapel, a clinic, a theatre, and an execution room, all the same room, depending on why you came. Here beauty is made unbearable and comfort is twisted into bait. The Awoko are natives of the Domain who found the one thing the Regent's law could never quite tax — grief — and built a faith on it. They do not see themselves as villains, and they are not lying about the comfort they offer. That is exactly what makes them dangerous.

Read aloud: Someone is singing, low and close — a song you half-remember in a voice you have lost. The air is warm with candlelight and the smell of clean linen, and a gentle hand finds your shoulder before you see whose it is. "You've carried that a long way," the voice says, meaning the grief you did not know showed. "You don't have to. Not here." Every word is true. That is the trap.

They preach that the Regent is proof a person can transcend Rank, death, and ownership itself — and their leader means to prove it by becoming the next thing the Gloamreach belongs to.

Core Truth

The Hollow Mother does not serve the Regent. She intends to replace him.

What This Place Does

Dread: Grief does not stay private here. The Sanctum gathers it, concentrates it, and turns it into something with weight and will — and the more you bring, the more it loves you. **The Lure:** To be *understood*. The cult meets the grieving exactly where they hurt and offers to share the weight, to make sure the lost are never forgotten. **The Cost:** It feeds on what it collects — loss, confession, blood, obedience — and gives belonging in their place, until the grief is all that is left of you. **If You Linger:** The grieving stop being mourners and become fuel, wept dry and fed to whatever the Hollow Mother is becoming.

Key Areas

S-1 - Nave of Remembered Names

Thousands of names hang from threads. Some are dead. Some are alive. Some belong to the party, if they have been careless with their names.

S-2 - Confession Chamber

Initiates confess grief into speaking tubes. The grief is stored, refined, and used to power rituals.

S-3 - Clinic of Gentle Hands

The cult offers real comfort here. Do not make it fake. The danger is that the comfort is being weaponized.

S-4 - Choir Pit

Idol-class cultists sing Domain law into a more obedient shape. Interrupting the choir can delay a Regent court event or weaken Hollow Mother's ritual.

S-5 - Sister Veil's Laboratory

Sister Veil knows the ritual math is wrong. She can defect if shown evidence that the Hollow Mother intends to use the cult as fuel.

S-6 - The Ritual of Inheritance

A circular chamber with seven candle-stations, each burning with grief-tallow. If completed, the ritual lets the Hollow Mother attempt to inherit the Regent's claim.

Major NPCs

The Hollow Mother

Charismatic, grieving, brilliant, and predatory. She speaks softly. She never says serve when inherit will do.

Sister Veil

Ritualist and possible defector. She is guilty, but not unreachable.

Acolyte Mara

A young initiate who can become a human face for the cult's victims.

Ritual Disruption

The party can disrupt the ritual by:

1. Destroying one correct candle-station.
2. Convincing Sister Veil to corrupt the final chant.
3. Removing the stored grief from the Confession Chamber.
4. Presenting proof that the Hollow Mother intends to inherit, not liberate.

The Sanctum Raid

When the Sanctum turns hostile, the fight is the Choir, the ritual, and the Hollow Mother — not a single boss. Reskin a **B-Rank controller Anomaly from the compendium bestiary** (Appendix C) as the **Choir's grief-engine** (the thing the singing actually powers), and run the Hollow Mother as a near-non-combatant who would far rather the party *understood* than fought.

The Law in play: *grief may be converted into authority*. Every loss the party has carried into the Domain — a named dead, a memory-core eaten in the Orchard, an oath broken at the Bastion — is fuel the Sanctum can spend against them; a party that has grieved openly here arms the room. Starve the

engine by denying the cult the party's grief: refuse the comfort, withhold true names, or empty the Confession Chamber before the Choir can draw on it.

Scaling (Levels 1-15): B-Rank for a level 7-10 party; if the Ritual of Inheritance is near completion, raise it to A-Rank and let the Hollow Mother spend the Sanctum's stored grief as legendary actions.

Exit tone (read aloud): Outside again, the song does not follow — but for the rest of the campaign, the first kind voice in any safe room will sound, for just a moment, like hers, and the party will have to decide, every time, whether to let it comfort them.

Warden Guidance

The Awoko should be horrifying because they understand pain and exploit it with tenderness. Push the dread, not caricature. Their kindness should make the party angrier, not less afraid.

Chapter 34: Runes Cross-Reference

Runes Cross-Reference

| *A rune is a spell that stopped moving. That is not a metaphor. - Professor Lun*

Using This Chapter

Runes in *The Shadow of the Regent* come from canonical compendium sources. This chapter does not restate them. It maps where rune tiers appear inside the Gloamreach so the Warden can prep rewards without drifting from core canon.

Canonical sources:

- `runes/spell-rank-d.ts`
- `runes/spell-rank-c.ts`
- `runes/spell-rank-b.ts`
- `runes/spell-rank-a.ts`
- `runes/spell-rank-s.ts`
- `runes/technique-techniques.ts`
- `runes/power-powers.ts`

Rune Drop Schedule

Tier	Domain Source	Canonical Source
D	The Hollow Way, Drowned Ledgerfen, early road encounters	<code>runes/spell-rank-d.ts</code>
C	Fungal Depths, Remembering Orchard, Ashen Counting-House	<code>runes/spell-rank-c.ts</code>
B	Sunken Tunnels, Bastion Golemfall, Mana Vein Node rewards	<code>runes/spell-rank-b.ts</code>
A	Obsidian Spire, Forbidden Vault, Citadel approach, Hayashi research trade	<code>runes/spell-rank-a.ts</code>
S	Regent's Anchor-throne fragments after the finale	<code>runes/spell-rank-s.ts</code>
Technique	Vermillion training, Orin's trials, Spire trials	<code>runes/technique-techniques.ts</code>
Power	Mana Vein network, Unseated Law bargains, Claim awakenings	<code>runes/power-powers.ts</code>

Faction Rune Sources

Bureau

Dr. Hayashi and Professor Lun can identify or stabilize runes. Bureau access favors safety, documentation, and legal ownership.

Vermillion

Vermillion can sell restricted runes, apply dangerous modifications, and ignore Bureau paperwork. The price is money, favor, or leverage.

Awoko

The Awoko collect runes as grief-tithes. A Sanctum raid should yield at least one rune appropriate to the party's level, plus evidence of how the cult weaponizes loss.

The Unseated Law

The Unseated Law can produce power-runes through bargain, sacrifice, or a truth the Regent buried. These should be strong but costly. No bargain should feel random.

Forbidden Runes

The Bureau restricts runes tied to void, necrotic authority, compelled obedience, identity rewriting, or Anchor interference. Possession creates Bureau risk, but these runes may be exactly what the party needs to contradict the Regent.

Rune Recovery After the Campaign

If the Anchor is broken, sealed, or transformed, the Regent's Anchor-throne may fracture into three S-tier runes. Choose runes that reflect the party's ending, not only their combat builds.

Chapter 35: Gloamreach Random Encounter Tables

Gloamreach Random Encounter Tables

Every road here is a question. Most of them are traps. - Rat-King Ji

Using These Tables

Roll when the party travels between major Gloamreach regions, refuses an invitation, carries a Claim openly, rests in unsafe territory, or spends too long debating in the road.

These encounters should not feel random in-world. The Regent's Domain notices motion, fear, broken promises, and trespass.

Table A - Road of Writs

d20	Encounter
1-2	The road lengthens. Lose time, food, or daylight.
3-4	A toll-house appears, the party's names already half-written above the door in a hand none of them used.
5	A messenger delivers an invitation sealed in black wax.
6	A settlement bell rings in the distance. Someone is being collected.
7	The party finds a broken Bureau marker from a team that has not entered yet.
8	Vermillion courier offers a shortcut for a price.
9	Awoko recruiter approaches the most grief-marked character.
10	Umbral Scout watches from a milestone. It flees if pursued.
11	Roadside shrine offers a small mercy with unclear ownership.
12	Mika's drawing appears nailed to a tree. It depicts the next danger.
13	A corpse asks for directions. It is polite.
14	Supplies spoil unless shared under guest-right.
15	Claim resonance. A carried Relic grows cold and points toward a contradiction.
16	Old Man Crane is sitting at a tea table in the road. He does not explain how.
17	Regent whisper. DC 14 Sense save or psychic strain and a personal taunt.
18	Bailiff sign. Chains dragged across the road, fresh ink on the stones.
19	A safe-looking shelter with a guest-book by the door that already knows their names.
20	The Regent's Bailiff appears to announce charges. Combat is optional. Consequence is not.

Table B - Tribute Settlements

d20	Encounter
1-2	A family asks the party to hide someone from the next collection.
3-4	Local leader offers hospitality that creates legal obligation.
5	A child draws a place the party has not visited.
6	Villagers deny a disappearance everyone clearly remembers.
7	Awoko comfort-worker offers real aid and subtle recruitment.
8	Vermillion scout buys settlement secrets for supplies.
9	Bureau survivor begs extraction from the Domain.
10	The settlement's tribute is revealed. It is worse than rumored.
11	Regent courtier arrives for inspection.
12	A shrine has been defaced with creeping rot.
13	Someone recognizes a Regent-Marked PC. They are terrified.
14	A feast begins. Refusing is rude. Accepting is dangerous.
15	Missing person returns with no shadow.
16	Local law contradicts Bureau law. The party must choose which to violate.
17	Claim clue hidden in a folk song, a prayer, or a name carved where it should not be.
18	A settlement asks the party to kill someone who volunteered for tribute.
19	Hollow Mother sermon overheard. She says inherit, not serve.
20	The Bailiff comes for the village, not the party.

Table C - Wilds and Ruins

d20	Encounter
1-2	Predator tracks circle the party's camp from the future.
3-4	Adaptive beasts use a tactic the party used last session.
5	Weather changes after someone insults the Regent.
6	Ruined bastion patrol asks the party for an oath.
7	Fungal secret grows a mouth and repeats a confession.
8	Orchard fruit offers a memory. Eating it grants a clue and a cost.
9	Drowned voice asks to be named.
10	Broken road leads to the same milestone three times.
11	Anomaly swarm, rank appropriate.
12	Umbral Warrior patrol.
13	Awoko ritual site, currently unattended.
14	Vermillion salvage crew under attack.

d20	Encounter
15	Mana Vein flare. Gain one Rift Favor, then roll a complication.
16	Claim resonance points underground.
17	The Unseated Law speaks through a cracked courthouse bell.
18	Silent battlefield of empty armor.
19	Moment of stillness. Safe short rest if no one speaks the Regent's name.
20	The Citadel appears much closer than it should be.

Ambient Domain Events

Roll once per long rest outside protected shelter.

d6	Event
1	Domain pressure. DC 14 Sense save or dreams impose psychic strain.
2	Food changes flavor to ash, blood, flowers, or hospital antiseptic.
3	A written invitation appears in someone's pack.
4	A dead NPC speaks in a dream and offers true information.
5	The road outside has moved.
6	Small mercy. Regain 1 Rift Favor, but the Warden notes who granted it.

Chapter 36: The Gloamreach Rift Break Track

The Gloamreach Rift Break Track

Clocks measure time. The Gloamreach measures consent. - Dr. Serin Hayashi

Overview

The Gloamreach's containment fails in stages across the whole campaign — a Rift Break track spanning roughly twelve in-world weeks (Levels 1-15), grouped into three acts (I: L1-5, II: L6-10, III: L11-15). It is not a 14-day countdown and not a district clock. It is the Domain pressing its law toward the material world one provoked stage at a time, until a Rift Break becomes likely near the level-15 finale.

Use this timeline as a pacing instrument. It should never override player agency. It advances pressure when the party delays, rests, travels, or ignores major threats.

Day 1 • Act I — Threshold Day

The party enters the Gloamreach. The Rift behind them becomes unreliable. The Road of Writs appears for the first time. The Oracle Reading should happen before the end of this day or as soon as the party reaches a safe reader.

Day 4 • Act I — First Tribute

A nearby settlement pays tribute. The party may witness it, interrupt it, or only hear the bells afterward. The Drowned Ledgerfen becomes active.

Day 8 • Act I — The Road Learns

The Road of Writs begins responding to party choices. Anyone who gave a true name, accepted hospitality, or made a promise on the road feels watched.

Day 13 • Act I — Hayashi's Warning

A delayed Bureau transmission reaches the party. Dr. Hayashi confirms the Gloamreach is a Regent Domain, not a normal Rift. She warns them that killing creatures is not enough if the Anchor law survives.

Day 20 • Act II — The Bailiff's First Public Judgment

The Regent's Bailiff collects someone from a settlement or road camp. This should be visible, memorable, and dreadful. It speaks their names before any violence.

Day 27 • Act II — The Cult Moves

Awoko agents begin open recruitment in grief-dense places. The Hollow Mother sends a message, sermon, or dream. She does not say she serves the Regent.

Day 34 • Act II — The Domain Tightens

Travel grows harder. Safe rests require tribute, guest-right, or faction shelter. The Sunken Tunnels and Bastion Golemfall become more active.

Day 41 • Act II — Crane's Memory

Old Man Crane offers sealing lore or warns the party that some Regents can be contained only by sacrifice. If ignored, he goes alone toward the Citadel road.

Day 49 • Act II — The Hollow Mother Declares

Awoko pamphlets, songs, or sermons spread through settlements. Civilian unrest rises. The cult claims the Regent offers ascension beyond Rank.

Day 58 • Act III — The Claim Race

If the party has recovered any Claim, enemies attempt to steal, corrupt, or unmake it. If they have recovered none, the Regent sends an invitation that includes one precise clue.

Day 66 • Act III — Bureau Crisis

Central Command orders the Annex to prioritize Relic extraction over survivor recovery. Commander Park either obeys, delays, or defies this order depending on party reputation.

Day 74 • Act III — Ritual of Inheritance

The Awoko Sanctum reaches full ritual strength. If not disrupted, the Hollow Mother gains leverage over the final act and may attempt to inherit the Domain if the Regent weakens.

Day 80 • Act III — Final Preparations

All major factions understand that the Citadel approach is imminent. Allies must be chosen. Debts come due. The Road of Writs offers the shortest path and the worst terms.

Day 84 • Act III — Citadel Day & the Break Threshold

The party enters the Regent's Citadel or the Domain begins forcing Rift Break pressure onto the material world. Bureau floodlights outside the Rift dim. Inside the Gloamreach, every bell rings once.

If the Timeline Expires

Do not end the campaign automatically. Escalate.

Choose two consequences:

1. The material-side cordon suffers a partial Rift Break bleed.

2. One settlement is annexed directly into the Regent's court.
3. The Bailiff gains authority to pursue the party into protected shelters.
4. The Hollow Mother completes part of her inheritance ritual.
5. The Citadel road opens, but only under hostile terms.
6. One Claim becomes harder to use because the Regent has prepared a legal counterclaim.

Warden Guidance

This timeline is pressure, not railroad track. Its purpose is to keep the Domain alive. The party should feel that delay matters, but that clever action can change the clock's meaning.

Appendix A — Recruitable Allies

Commander Park Jae-won — Bureau Domain Response Commander

Faction: Bureau Sentinels · **Level:** 8 · **AC:** 18 · **HP:** 95 · **Location:** Bureau Domain Response Annex

Job: Destroyer

A battle-scarred commander with mana-reinforced prosthetics and a voice trained to stay calm while the map collapses. Park commands the material-side Annex outside the Gloamreach threshold.

Personality. Stern, clipped, protective, and unwilling to confuse protocol with courage once civilians are at risk.

Motivation. Prevent a Rift Break, recover missing teams, and keep Central Command from sacrificing survivors for clean reports.

Key Abilities

- Fortification Aura
- Command Strike
- Hold the Line

Recruit. Reach Bureau Trusted reputation and help Park defy an order that would abandon civilians.

Quartermaster Lin Mei-hua — Cordon Supply Officer

Faction: Bureau Sentinels · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 38 · **Location:** Bureau Domain Response Annex - Armory

Job: Technomancer

A meticulous logistics officer who tracks every ration, glow rod, and field dressing with near-religious intensity.

Personality. Anxious, precise, quietly compassionate, and more generous when no one is watching.

Motivation. Keep the Annex supplied long enough for the party to matter.

Key Abilities

- Equipment Maintenance
- Inventory Mastery
- Emergency Fabrication

Recruit. Protect the Annex supply line or save the armory during a Domain bleed event.

Sergeant Yoon Hye-jin — Domain Scout Leader

Faction: Bureau Sentinels · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 16 · **HP:** 52 · **Location:** Road of Writs patrol route

Job: Stalker

A quiet scout with chalk marks on her gloves and a habit of checking exits even in rooms she has already cleared.

Personality. Pragmatic, watchful, loyal, and economical with words.

Motivation. Find her missing scouts and learn why the Road of Writs keeps returning their signals from impossible directions.

Key Abilities

- Shadow Step
- Anomaly Sense
- Precision Strike

Recruit. Resolve the Missing Strike Team quest and give Yoon the truth instead of a comforting lie.

Dr. Serin Hayashi — Regent Domain Researcher

Faction: Bureau Sentinels · **Level:** 6 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 42 · **Location:** Bureau Domain Response Annex - Evidence Locker

Job: Esper

A brilliant field researcher with ink-stained cuffs, too many notes, and the courage to say that the Gloamreach is law before it is terrain.

Personality. Fast-talking, compassionate, intellectually reckless, and more frightened of bad assumptions than monsters.

Motivation. Prove that killing the Regent is not the only possible Anchor resolution.

Key Abilities

- Analyze Weakness
- Aetheric Shield
- Anchor Theory

Recruit. Bring her three Domain-touched samples and protect her research from being suppressed.

Agent Kira Blackwood — Bureau Intelligence Operative

Faction: Bureau Sentinels · **Level:** 7 · **AC:** 17 · **HP:** 58 · **Location:** Bureau Domain Response Annex - Intelligence desk

Job: Stalker

A pale intelligence agent with controlled movements, half-truths, and classified orders involving pre-threshold Relic activity.

Personality. Cold, dry, observant, and capable of empathy she treats as an operational weakness.

Motivation. Complete her mission without letting Central Command turn the Regent's law into a weapon.

Key Abilities

- Infiltration
- Dead Drop
- Counter-Intelligence

Recruit. Complete her personal quest and force her to choose the party over Central Command.

Corporal Deng Wei — Heavy Weapons Specialist

Faction: Bureau Sentinels · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 16 · **HP:** 48 · **Location:** Bureau Domain Response Annex - Field kitchen

Job: Destroyer

A broad-shouldered gunner and former chef whose field cannon is nearly as large as his guilt.

Personality. Gentle, exhausted, brave when others need him, and ashamed of fear he earned honestly.

Motivation. Stand his ground when the Regent's Bailiff comes for someone he can protect.

Key Abilities

- Suppressing Fire
- Heavy Hitter
- Fortify Position

Recruit. Help Deng survive a nightmare scene and later face the Bailiff without mocking his fear.

Comms Officer Reyes — Signal Specialist

Faction: Bureau Sentinels · **Level:** 3 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 28 · **Location:** Bureau Domain Response Annex - Relay room

Job: Technomancer

A young signal specialist who receives transmissions out of order and keeps answering anyway.

Personality. Fast, anxious, brilliant, and allergic to silence.

Motivation. Decode the Regent's frequency and prove the messages from tomorrow are warnings, not hallucinations.

Key Abilities

- Signal Boost
- Decrypt
- Aetheric Jammer

Recruit. Repair a relay inside the Hollow Way or carry a booster through the Road of Writs.

Warden-Aspirant Sato Ken — Bureau Recruit

Faction: Bureau Sentinels · **Level:** 2 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 22 · **Location:** Bureau Domain Response Annex - Barricade lobby

Job: Holy Knight

A terrified recruit in armor that does not fit, carrying more courage than training.

Personality. Earnest, frightened, stubborn, and desperate to be useful.

Motivation. Become worthy of the badge before the Domain teaches him what badges cost.

Key Abilities

- Determination
- Quick Learner
- Inspire

Recruit. He joins if asked, though Park warns the party not to mistake willingness for readiness.

Grist — Arms-Dealer

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 40 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost - Armoury stall

Job: Technomancer

The Outpost's weapons-fence: salvaged edged steel, Relic-arms the Domain grew teeth into, and Essence-cells for anything that drinks them.

Personality. Cheerful, amoral about buyers, deadly serious about misfires.

Motivation. Arm anyone who can pay, then sleep at night by never selling a curse he hasn't named.

Key Abilities

- Salvaged Arsenal
- Relic-Weapon Lore
- Essence-Cell Supply

Recruit. Return a Relic-weapon that turned on its buyer; he repays it in better steel.

Quill — Memory-Broker

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 30 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost / Covered Market

Job: Esper

A trader in memory-cores harvested from the Remembering Orchard, who can sell you a skill, a language, or a stranger's happiest day — at the price of a little of your own.

Personality. Smooth, melancholy, scrupulous about consent in a trade everyone else cheats.

Motivation. Keep the memory-trade honest in a Domain that wants it predatory.

Key Abilities

- Memory Appraisal
- Skill-Core Transfer
- Detects Stolen Memory

Recruit. Recover a stolen memory-core and let him return it instead of selling it.

Captain Doe — Smuggler-Captain

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 6 · **AC:** 15 · **HP:** 46 · **Location:** The roads / Vermillion Outpost

Job: Stalker

Runs contraband — people, Relics, and forbidden Runes — between settlements along roads the Domain has not finished closing.

Personality. Cool, calculating, sentimental about exactly one thing she will never name.

Motivation. Move what the Domain forbids, and get every passenger to the other end breathing.

Key Abilities

- Smuggling Routes
- Hidden Cargo
- Outruns the Bailiff

Recruit. Help her run a cargo of refugees past a Bailiff checkpoint without paying in names.

Tallow — Charm-Seller

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 3 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 24 · **Location:** Covered Market / road camps

Job: Contractor

A peddler of wards, tokens, and anti-Regent-Marked charms — most of them comforting junk, a precious few of them genuinely real.

Personality. Patter-fast, superstitious in earnest, kinder than the grift suggests.

Motivation. Sell hope by the handful, and slip the real charms to the people who truly need them.

Key Abilities

- Genuine Ward (rare)
- Reads the Marked
- Sells Hope

Recruit. Catch him slipping a real charm to a doomed family, and keep his secret.

Cinder — Deep-Salvage Diver

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 15 · **HP:** 42 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost

Job: Stalker

A native salvager who goes into the places that kill everyone else and comes back with the cores to prove it.

Personality. Reckless, generous, and superstitious about owed favours.

Motivation. Pull enough Essence to buy her crew off the Domain's rolls for good.

Key Abilities

- Hazard Instinct
- Core Extraction
- Holds Her Breath

Recruit. Bring her crew home from a dive gone wrong; she pays her debts in blood, not coin.

Old Vell — Relic-Appraiser

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 6 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 36 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost - Appraisal stall

Job: Technomancer

A half-blind native fence who can tell you exactly what a Relic does, and exactly what it will cost you.

Personality. Dry, patient, and honest about prices and nothing else.

Motivation. Keep the Outpost's stock moving and its worst Relics out of the wrong hands.

Key Abilities

- Relic Lore
- Curse-Sense
- Names a True Price

Recruit. Bring him a Relic no one else can identify; respect his appraisal even when it costs you.

Pip — Apprentice Runner

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 1 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 12 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost / the roads

Job: Stalker

Jax's apprentice — eager, quick, and one bad shortcut away from the worst lesson the road teaches.

Personality. Eager, loyal, and overconfident about the Road of Writs.

Motivation. Become a full Runner without losing his name to a shortcut.

Key Abilities

- Quick Routes
- Message Memory
- Trusts Jax

Recruit. Teach him one safe refusal before the road teaches him the hard way.

Rat-King Ji — Black Market Fence

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 6 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 45 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost - Bazaar front

Job: Contractor

A wiry broker with mismatched eyes and a talent for finding whatever people were desperate enough to hide.

Personality. Slippery, charming, fair in business, and never fully honest.

Motivation. Profit, survival, and control of one secret about a Claim before someone more dangerous buys it.

Key Abilities

- Appraise
- Black Market Network
- Escape Artist

Recruit. Reach Vermillion Trusted reputation and recover Ji's stash before the Road of Writs transfers ownership.

Vex "Quicksilver" — Guild Assassin

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 7 · **AC:** 17 · **HP:** 55 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost - Black Market

Job: Assassin

A masked contract killer whose silver-lined coat moves a half-second before the rest of them.

Personality. Professional, sardonic, precise, and bound by a strict line against harming innocents.

Motivation. Destroy the Awoko leadership that turned their partner's grief into ritual fuel.

Key Abilities

- Quicksilver Rush
- Assassinate
- Silver Blur

Recruit. Agree to help eliminate the Hollow Mother's ritual network. Vex stays if the party saves captives rather than only killing cultists.

Mother Rust — Junk Alchemist

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 11 · **HP:** 35 · **Location:** Mother Rust's Outreach Post

Job: Technomancer

An elderly alchemist with copper-green hair, burned fingers, and a clinic that smells like medicine, oil, and bad decisions.

Personality. Grandmotherly, volatile, brilliant, and increasingly willing to call cruelty efficiency.

Motivation. Brew a treatment that lets people survive Domain exposure, even if it quiets parts of them that hurt too much.

Key Abilities

- Brew Potion
- Acid Flask
- Volatile Mixture

Recruit. Bring her living mana and confront what she intends to do with it.

Guildmaster Orin — Vermillion Commander

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 9 · **AC:** 17 · **HP:** 82 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost - Orin's chamber

Job: Herald

A former Bureau officer who leads from a tea table, not a throne, and can make a rescue sound like an invoice.

Personality. Controlled, pragmatic, dry, and allergic to institutional cowardice.

Motivation. Prove that fast, ugly action saves more people than clean delay.

Key Abilities

- Battlefield Appraisal
- Exploit Opening
- Guild Network

Recruit. Broker a Bureau-Vermillion alliance without letting either side erase its failures.

Iron Belle — Prize Destroyer

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 7 · **AC:** 15 · **HP:** 75 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost - Training ring

Job: Destroyer

A towering fighter with scarred knuckles, a philosophical reading habit, and no patience for cowards who call cruelty strength.

Personality. Boisterous, competitive, protective, and more thoughtful than her opponents expect.

Motivation. Find out why strong fighters vanish after certain Outpost matches.

Key Abilities

- Champion's Fist
- Iron Body
- Knockout Blow

Recruit. Fight her honorably and help expose the cult's recruitment through violence.

Lee Ji-won "Bright" — Tattoo Artist

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 32 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost - Tattoo parlour

Job: Idol

A singer turned tattooist whose voice-infused ink turns pain into usable pattern.

Personality. Warm, stylish, sharp, and protective of anyone changing their body to survive.

Motivation. Make beauty the Regent cannot own.

Key Abilities

- Voice-Inked Tattoo
- Morale Verse
- Pain-Ward Glyphs

Recruit. Protect her parlor during an Outpost raid or recover stolen tattoo needles from the Awoko.

Sigilmaster Baek — Engraver of Arms

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 34 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost - Sigil parlour

Job: Mage

A quiet artisan who engraves slowly because rushed power breaks in the hand.

Personality. Patient, blunt, exacting, and unimpressed by dramatic customers.

Motivation. Create tools that survive the Citadel without making their wielders monsters.

Key Abilities

- Sigil Engraving
- Runic Appraisal
- Stabilize Relic

Recruit. Recover his master lens from the Ashen Counting-House.

Jax the Runner — Road Courier

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 3 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 26 · **Location:** Road of Writs and Vermillion Outpost

Job: Stalker

A wiry courier who knows shortcuts the Road of Writs has not yet learned to punish.

Personality. Cocky, restless, brave, and secretly terrified of locked rooms.

Motivation. Stay faster than ownership.

Key Abilities

- Parkour
- Sprint
- Shortcut Finder

Recruit. Help him break a road-debt before the Bailiff collects him.

Brother Sown — Comfort-Worker

Faction: Awoko Cult · **Level:** 3 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 28 · **Location:** Settlements / Awoko Sanctum

Job: Herald

A gentle Awoko who sits with the dying and the grieving and genuinely eases them — and does not know what the Sanctum renders his comfort into.

Personality. Kind, sincere, and devout; dangerous precisely because none of it is an act.

Motivation. Take the unbearable from people so they can keep going.

Key Abilities

- Real Comfort
- Grief-Ease
- Trusted in Settlements

Recruit. Show him what the Sanctum does with the grief he gathers — and catch him when it breaks him.

The Widow Asha — Half-Sworn

Faction: Awoko Cult · **Level:** 2 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 18 · **Location:** Awoko Sanctum approach / settlements

Job: Esper

A grieving native widow halfway into the cult, who can still be reached — for now.

Personality. Numb, aching, and looking for a reason that is not the Hollow Mother's.

Motivation. Hear her husband's voice one more time, whatever it costs.

Key Abilities

- Grief-Sight
- Half-Learned Rites

Recruit. Give her a truer way to grieve than the cult offers, and protect her when she chooses it.

The Hollow Mother — Cult Hierophant

Faction: Awoko Cult · **Level:** 9 · **AC:** 16 · **HP:** 88 · **Location:** Awoko Sanctum

Job: Herald

A soft-spoken cult leader in mourning veils who offers comfort with one hand and inheritance rites with the other.

Personality. Gentle, brilliant, predatory, and terrifying because her comfort is real.

Motivation. Inherit the Gloamreach when the Regent weakens.

Key Abilities

- Grief Choir
- Inheritance Rite
- Void Benediction

Recruit. Cannot be recruited. She can only be defeated, exposed, or briefly outmaneuvered.

Whisper — Doubting Prophet

Faction: Awoko Cult · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 34 · **Location:** Sunken Tunnels or Awoko Sanctum

Job: Esper

A thin seer who hears the Domain answer prayers the cult never sent.

Personality. Haunted, careful, compassionate when fear lets her be.

Motivation. Escape the cult with enough truth to save others.

Key Abilities

- Prophetic Dream
- Mind Link
- Fear Sense

Recruit. Protect her from cult retrieval and believe her when she says the Hollow Mother intends inheritance.

Blood Zealot Karn — Ritual Enforcer

Faction: Awoko Cult · **Level:** 6 · **AC:** 15 · **HP:** 70 · **Location:** Awoko Sanctum - Ritual guard post

Job: Berserker

A scarred zealot who mistakes obedience for devotion and pain for proof.

Personality. Fanatical, direct, suspicious of mercy, and eager to be used.

Motivation. Feed enough blood into the ritual to be rewritten as something stronger.

Key Abilities

- Blood Frenzy
- Ritual Cleaver
- Pain Conversion

Recruit. Cannot be recruited unless the Warden wants a very dark redemption arc.

Sister Veil — Cult Ritualist

Faction: Awoko Cult · **Level:** 6 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 40 · **Location:** Awoko Sanctum - Sister Veil's laboratory

Job: Mage

A porcelain-masked ritual engineer whose doubt begins as a calculation error.

Personality. Methodical, controlled, intellectually honest, and more salvageable than she believes.

Motivation. Understand why the ritual math proves the cult will be consumed.

Key Abilities

- Counter-Ritual
- Containment Field
- Ritual Amplification

Recruit. Show her evidence that the Hollow Mother plans to inherit the Domain by burning her followers as fuel.

The Hollow Man — Cult Infiltrator

Faction: Awoko Cult · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 34 · **Location:** Bureau Annex or tribute settlement

Job: Stalker

A forgettable spy whose face seems different whenever described twice.

Personality. Empty, patient, adaptive, and almost impossible to remember accurately.

Motivation. Identify threats to the Ritual of Inheritance and remove them quietly.

Key Abilities

- Perfect Disguise
- Forgettable
- Poisoned Hospitality

Recruit. Cannot be recruited. He is a mole to expose.

Acolyte Mara — Young Cult Initiate

Faction: Awoko Cult · **Level:** 2 · **AC:** 11 · **HP:** 18 · **Location:** Awoko Sanctum - holding room

Job: Herald

A frightened initiate with fresh ritual marks and a stubborn refusal to let fear become faith.

Personality. Scared, observant, defiant in small ways, and smarter than her captors think.

Motivation. Escape alive and help someone else escape after her.

Key Abilities

- Ritual Knowledge
- Innocent Face
- Survivor's Instinct

Recruit. Rescue her from the Sanctum and give her safety without demanding usefulness.

Father Gregor — Comfort Preacher

Faction: Awoko Cult · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 32 · **Location:** Bellweather School or Covered Market

Job: Herald

A shelter preacher whose sermons always end one step closer to obedience.

Personality. Warm, mournful, persuasive, and evasive when asked who benefits from his comfort.

Motivation. Deliver grieving civilians to the Hollow Mother's network.

Key Abilities

- Soothing Sermon
- Grief Mark
- Crowd Turn

Recruit. Only recruitable through a hard confession and public renunciation of the cult.

Choir-Lark Hana — Awoko Singer

Faction: Awoko Cult · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 36 · **Location:** Awoko Sanctum - Choir Pit

Job: Idol

A ritual singer whose voice can make grief feel like a room with no doors.

Personality. Soft, artistic, impressionable, and terrified of silence.

Motivation. Sing loudly enough that she never hears what the ritual does.

Key Abilities

- Grief Hymn
- Discordant Note
- Choir Link

Recruit. Break the Choir Pit's hold without killing the singers.

Maven Holt — General Merchant

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 2 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 18 · **Location:** Covered Market - Holt's Goods

Job: Herald

The Covered Market's main provisioner — rope, oil, rations, lamp-Essence, and whatever the party forgot they needed until the road took it.

Personality. Brisk, fair, allergic to drama, and quietly generous to children.

Motivation. Keep his stall solvent and his suppliers (and their secrets) safe.

Key Abilities

- Stocks Almost Anything
- Fair Prices
- Supplier Network

Recruit. Settle a debt a rival pinned on him; he repays loyalty in resupply at any hour.

Coin-Mother Esha — Money-Changer

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 24 · **Location:** Covered Market - The Counting-Table

Job: Esper

The closest thing the Gloamreach has to a bank: she changes Essence-cores, favours, debts, and writes into one another, and never blinks at the rate.

Personality. Precise, unflappable, and fluent in exactly what a thing is worth to the person holding it.

Motivation. Stay the one ledger the Regent's court does not fully control.

Key Abilities

- True-Value Sight
- Favour Exchange
- Reads the Hidden Cost

Recruit. Bring her a debt the Regent's court wants called in, and let her be the one to settle it.

Inkwright — Forger of Names

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 28 · **Location:** Writ-Bound Hamlet - back room

Job: Mage

A quiet calligrapher who sells false names, forged writs, and invitations that were never really sent — the single most useful and most dangerous trade in the Domain.

Personality. Meticulous, nervous, proud of work no one is supposed to admire.

Motivation. Stay one forgery ahead of the Domain's own handwriting.

Key Abilities

- False Name
- Forged Writ
- Counterfeit Invitation

Recruit. Protect his workshop from a Bailiff audit; a forger who trusts you is worth an army of keys.

Goodman Pell — Shelter-Keeper

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 3 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 30 · **Location:** Road of Writs - The Last Hearth

Job: Holy Knight

Keeper of the one rooming-house on the road that honours guest-right — meaning the one place a long rest is possible, and the one place a careless oath becomes a leash.

Personality. Gruff, hospitable, and rigid about the rules that keep his roof standing.

Motivation. Offer true shelter without his hearth becoming the Domain's trap.

Key Abilities

- Guest-Right Sanctuary
- Reads a Liar
- Old Hospitality Law

Recruit. Honour his house's guest-right exactly once, even when breaking it would be easier.

Herbalist Wen — Apothecary

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 3 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 22 · **Location:** Tribute settlements - Wen's stillroom

Job: Herald

A native apothecary who brews against Rift-Rot, spore-sickness, and the slow grey numbness the Domain leaves in people who stay too long.

Personality. Soft-spoken, exacting, and unwilling to lie about what a cure will cost.

Motivation. Keep one settlement breathing against a sickness that is partly the land itself.

Key Abilities

- Rift-Rot Cure
- Field Apothecary
- Knows the Safe Growths

Recruit. Recover a rare growth from the Fungal Depths without letting it cultivate you first.

Sexton Mort — Undertaker

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 30 · **Location:** Tribute settlements - the boneyard

Job: Revenant

The man who buries the settlements' dead, and the only one who knows which graves to weigh down so their occupants stay in them.

Personality. Calm, fatalistic, surprisingly funny, and never surprised.

Motivation. Make sure the dead get to be only dead, which the Domain makes harder every season.

Key Abilities

- Knows the Restless Dead
- Grave-Wards
- Final Rites

Recruit. Help him put down something that walked home from the Fungal Depths' Nursery.

Auntie Rell — Settlement Gossip

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 2 · **AC:** 11 · **HP:** 16 · **Location:** Covered Market / settlement doorsteps

Job: Idol

The hub of every rumour in three settlements, who hears everything because no one thinks to guard their tongue around an old woman shelling beans.

Personality. Warm, nosy, sharp as a tack, and loyal to whoever's kind to the children.

Motivation. Know everything first, and trade it only to people who deserve to know.

Key Abilities

- Knows Everyone
- Rumour Network
- Remembers the Forgotten

Recruit. Bring her real news from a settlement that has gone silent; she pays in everything she knows.

Captain Hollow — Militia Captain

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 16 · **HP:** 48 · **Location:** Writ-Bound Hamlet / tribute settlements

Job: Destroyer

The closest thing a tribute-settlement has to a guard: a hard, scarred captain holding a wall against things no wall was built for.

Personality. Blunt, exhausted, fiercely protective, and out of good options.

Motivation. Keep his people alive without giving the Regent a reason to make an example of them.

Key Abilities

- Hold the Line
- Settlement Defence
- Improvised Tactics

Recruit. Win one fight for his settlement that he could not, and let him keep the credit with his people.

Sile — Road-Pilot

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 30 · **Location:** The Road of Writs

Job: Stalker

A guide who can walk the Road of Writs without being rearranged by it, for a fee, and who has never once promised to bring everyone back.

Personality. Laconic, honest about odds, superstitious about thanking the road.

Motivation. Walk every road in the Gloamreach once before one of them keeps her.

Key Abilities

- Reads the Moving Road
- Shortcut Sense
- Never Pays in Names

Recruit. Trust her route once when it makes no sense; she does not waste a second chance.

Bram the Victualler — Cook

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 1 · **AC:** 11 · **HP:** 14 · **Location:** Covered Market - Bram's fire

Job: Herald

A market cook whose hot food is genuinely restorative and genuinely the safest meal for miles — because he refuses, on principle, to serve anything that comes with a string attached.

Personality. Loud, big-hearted, stubborn about feeding people for free when he can afford it.

Motivation. Make one place in the Gloamreach where a meal is just a meal.

Key Abilities

- Restorative Meal (1d4+1 temp HP)
- No Strings Attached
- Knows the Market

Recruit. Defend his stall from an Awoko comfort-worker trying to lace his bread with grief.

Elder Saph — Writ-Bound Speaker

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 3 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 26 · **Location:** Writ-Bound Hamlet

Job: Herald

The eldest voice of the Writ-Bound Hamlet, who keeps the village polite, paid, and barely intact.

Personality. Courteous, tired, unbreakable, and quietly ashamed of every bargain she has kept.

Motivation. Keep her people off the Bailiff's roster for one more season.

Key Abilities

- Settlement Lore
- Read the Writ
- Calm the Room

Recruit. Prove the party can refuse an invitation and survive; she will quietly teach her people to do the same.

Tomas Bell — Bell-Ringer

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 2 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 20 · **Location:** Tribute settlements (travelling)

Job: Stalker

The man who rings the tribute-bells because someone must, and because the Domain chose his hands.

Personality. Hollowed out, precise, and kinder than the work should allow.

Motivation. Ring only what he must, and warn whom he can with how he rings it.

Key Abilities

- Bell-Code Warning
- Knows Every Road
- Quiet Foot

Recruit. Decode one of his warnings and act on it; after that, he will ring for the party.

Needle — Writ-Courier

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 1 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 10 · **Location:** The roads between settlements

Job: Stalker

A fast, watchful child who carries writs and rumours between settlements faster than the road can rearrange itself.

Personality. Sharp, transactional, and secretly desperate for one adult who keeps a promise.

Motivation. Stay uncatalogued, get paid, keep her little brother off the rolls.

Key Abilities

- Unmarked Routes
- Fast Hands
- Hears Everything

Recruit. Pay her honestly once and protect her brother; she becomes the party's best source of road intelligence.

Reeve Dunn — Tithe-Collector

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 16 · **HP:** 38 · **Location:** Tribute settlements

Job: Holy Knight

A native tithe-collector in the Regent's livery who hates the work and softens it wherever the Domain is not looking.

Personality. Stiff, guilty, decent under the uniform, and one honest order away from breaking.

Motivation. Collect what keeps the village safe and never one ounce more.

Key Abilities

- Domain Livery (passes writs)
- Knows the Rolls
- Reluctant Authority

Recruit. Give him a way to fail his quota that the Domain cannot trace back to him.

"Doc" Tanaka Hiroshi — Settlement Surgeon

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 10 · **HP:** 30 · **Location:** Mother Rust's Outreach Post or tribute settlement clinic

Job: Herald

A tired doctor with steady hands and a clinic rule: no weapons near the beds.

Personality. Compassionate, overworked, dry, and difficult to intimidate.

Motivation. Keep people alive after every faction has made its argument.

Key Abilities

- Field Surgery
- Triage
- Medical Knowledge

Recruit. Resupply his clinic and protect it from a collection attempt.

Zara the Scrapper — Junker Mechanic

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 3 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 28 · **Location:** Empty Mill Village

Job: Technomancer

A self-taught mechanic in welding goggles who treats broken machines like arguments she intends to win.

Personality. Confident, creative, profane, and fiercely independent.

Motivation. Build a vehicle that can cross a road that changes its own destination.

Key Abilities

- Repair
- Improvised Weapon
- Jury-Rig

Recruit. Bring her a gear-heart from the Tithe Mill.

Mika the Kid — Prophetic Child

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 1 · **AC:** 10 · **HP:** 8 · **Location:** Bellweather School

Job: Esper

A quiet child whose drawings show roads, bells, castles, and people who have not yet arrived.

Personality. Gentle, strange, honest, and more observant than most adults can bear.

Motivation. Draw the bad things early enough that someone kind might stop them.

Key Abilities

- Prophetic Drawing
- Danger Sense
- Small Mercy

Recruit. Protect Mika without exploiting her visions.

Old Man Crane — White Heron

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 10 · **AC:** 16 · **HP:** 70 · **Location:** Old Man Crane's Teahouse

Job: Esper

A retired S-Rank Ascendant who drinks tea like a ritual and remembers how sealing a Regent smells.

Personality. Patient, sorrowful, dryly funny, and old enough to distrust easy endings.

Motivation. Teach the party that not every victory is destruction.

Key Abilities

- Sealing Lore
- White Heron Step
- Memory Blade

Recruit. Earn his respect and accept that his final technique may cost his life.

Professor Lun — Relic Metaphysicist

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 34 · **Location:** Bureau Annex or Glass Sub-Basement

Job: Mage

A precise academic whose fear is expressed through better diagrams.

Personality. Dry, fussy, exact, and quietly brave around impossible evidence.

Motivation. Prove that Mana Vein nodes can weaken the Regent's battlefield authority.

Key Abilities

- Relic Identification
- Vein Sensor
- Rune Decoding

Recruit. Activate the three Mana Vein nodes and keep him alive through the third reading.

Ghost — Amnesiac Strike Team Survivor

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 8 · **AC:** 17 · **HP:** 60 · **Location:** Road of Writs or Bureau Echo Room

Job: Stalker

A silent survivor with heterochromatic eyes and a Bureau ID that has been redacted by force, water, and something stranger.

Personality. Guarded, watchful, protective, and frightened of remembering the wrong thing.

Motivation. Recover identity without becoming evidence in someone else's report.

Key Abilities

- Silent Takedown
- Memory Flash
- AFA Ghost-Ping

Recruit. Complete Ghost's Memory and let Ghost choose what to do with the truth.

Mama Chen — Shelter Matron

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 42 · **Location:** Tribute settlement shelter

Job: Contractor

A settlement matron who can make fifty frightened people move with one look.

Personality. Warm, fierce, unsentimental, and impossible to buy.

Motivation. Keep her people fed without paying the Regent in names.

Key Abilities

- Community Leader
- Iron Will
- Shelter Network

Recruit. Move her shelter without letting the road choose the weakest people.

The Millwright — Masked Engineer

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 7 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 48 · **Location:** Sunken Tunnels workshop

Job: Technomancer

A masked engineer who speaks through a modulator and builds tools for laws that should not exist.

Personality. Obsessive, precise, socially blunt, and devoted to solvable problems.

Motivation. Complete a device that suppresses one local Domain law without collapsing the people under it.

Key Abilities

- Construct
- Domain Suppression Pulse
- Fortification

Recruit. Gather the final components for the suppression device.

Seo Min-jae — The Returned

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 6 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 55 · **Location:** Mother Rust's Outreach Post

Job: Revenant

A twice-dead Ascendant whose shadow arrives a moment late.

Personality. Quiet, deliberate, calm around horror, and unsettled by kindness.

Motivation. Learn what sent him back and whether it has authority over anyone else.

Key Abilities

- Second Death
- Umbral Echo
- Passenger's Sight

Recruit. Investigate the Glass Sub-Basement and share the findings with him.

Han Yu-jin — Rift-Tamer

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 40 · **Location:** Covered Market

Job: Summoner

A patient Summoner with a scarred six-limbed companion she calls Little Sister.

Personality. Observant, gentle with beasts, blunt with people, and practical about grief.

Motivation. Keep Little Sister alive and learn why Domain beasts are practicing party tactics.

Key Abilities

- Bonded Companion
- Summon Swarm
- Lyra's Whisper

Recruit. Protect Little Sister from an Awoko abduction attempt.

The Caretaker — Orchard Keeper

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 6 · **AC:** 15 · **HP:** 50 · **Location:** Remembering Orchard

Job: Stalker

A polite gardener with pruning hooks and a ledger of memories surrendered willingly.

Personality. Courteous, tired, sincere, and morally ruined by small necessary evils.

Motivation. Keep the Remembering Orchard from choosing its own harvest.

Key Abilities

- Pruning Hook
- Graft Memory
- Harvest Bell

Recruit. Prove the settlement can survive without memory tribute.

Commander Without a Body — Bastion Spirit

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 8 · **AC:** 18 · **HP:** 80 · **Location:** Bastion Golemfall

Job: Holy Knight

A voice in empty armor, still commanding a wall that already fell.

Personality. Honorable, severe, ashamed, and hungry for proof that oaths can still matter.

Motivation. Release the dead defenders from service without calling their sacrifice meaningless.

Key Abilities

- Oath Command
- Shield Wall
- Dead Muster

Recruit. Resolve the Bastion's oath without claiming its soldiers as tools.

The Regent's Bailiff — The Thing That Comes for the Marked

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 12 · **AC:** 18 · **HP:** 140 · **Location:** Anywhere the Domain has marked someone

Job: Holy Knight

The Regent's will given a body: a towering figure of black iron and counted chains that arrives before the violence, speaks your names in the voices of your dead, and collects what the Domain has marked.

Personality. Implacable, unhurried, and utterly certain — it has all the time there is, and it is already on its way.

Motivation. Collect what the Domain has marked, and never stop until it has.

Key Abilities

- Speaks Your Names
- Counted Chains
- Cannot Be Bargained With
- Always Coming

Recruit. Cannot be recruited. It can be hidden from, outrun, warded against, or turned aside with a Claim — never befriended, never bargained with.

Chamberlain Vire — Keeper of Invitations

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 9 · **AC:** 15 · **HP:** 70 · **Location:** The roads / the Regent's Citadel

Job: Herald

The court official who writes the Regent's invitations in a beautiful hand, addresses them to people who have not done anything yet, and is never, ever in a hurry.

Personality. Elegant, patient, delighted by good manners and by their absence.

Motivation. See every name in the Domain properly invited, and properly answered.

Key Abilities

- Compelling Invitation
- Court Etiquette
- Knows Who Refused

Recruit. Cannot be recruited. Vire can be out-mannered, given a false name to enter, or tricked into inviting the wrong guest.

The Mute Herald — Voice of the Throne

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 7 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 52 · **Location:** Wherever the Regent has something to say

Job: Esper

A claimed echo with no mouth that speaks the Regent's words directly into the minds of those it is sent to, in their own remembered voices.

Personality. None of its own left; it is a mouthpiece wearing the cadence of whoever it quotes.

Motivation. Deliver the Regent's word, exactly, and watch it land.

Key Abilities

- Speaks the Regent's Will
- Voice of the Lost
- Mind-Cast Decree

Recruit. Cannot be recruited. Restoring even one of the voices it carries can briefly silence it.

Tally-Keeper Ont — Keeper of the Claimed

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 8 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 60 · **Location:** Ashen Counting-House / the Citadel

Job: Technomancer

The desiccated keeper who remembers every soul the Gloamreach has ever taken — name, face, and the manner of its taking — and who tends the heart of the fire at the Ashen Counting-House.

Personality. Fussy, proud, terrified of a name forgotten, and incapable of mercy that leaves a soul uncounted.

Motivation. Keep the tally complete, because a soul remembered is a soul the Domain still holds.

Key Abilities

- The Tally of the Dead
- Names the Claimed
- Marks the Living

Recruit. Cannot be recruited. Ont can be undone by a name he cannot account for — a claimed soul set free, or a false name he records as true.

Lord Sered — The First Claimed

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 11 · **AC:** 16 · **HP:** 110 · **Location:** The Regent's Citadel

Job: Revenant

The oldest of the Regent's bound servants — a courtly, hollow-eyed lord who was a man before the Domain, and remembers being one the way one remembers a country one can never return to.

Personality. Gracious, grieving, utterly loyal, and the closest thing the Regent has to a friend.

Motivation. Serve the Regent, because the alternative is to admit what serving has cost.

Key Abilities

- Courtly Authority
- Citadel Command
- Almost Human

Recruit. Cannot be recruited normally. A Claim contradiction, or proof of who he was, can make him hesitate at the worst moment for the Regent.

The Doorward — Keeper of the Outer Court

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 9 · **AC:** 17 · **HP:** 96 · **Location:** The Regent's Citadel - Outer Court

Job: Destroyer

The thing that checks invitations at the Citadel's threshold — part golem, part custom, entirely certain of who is and is not permitted.

Personality. Literal, ceremonial, and without a flicker of doubt.

Motivation. Admit the invited, turn away the rest, and remember every face that tries the second.

Key Abilities

- Checks the Invitation
- Remembers False Names
- Threshold Authority

Recruit. Cannot be recruited. A valid (or convincingly forged) invitation gets the party past it; a broken promise gets them remembered.

Lantern — Claimed Light

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 2 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 16 · **Location:** The Hollow Way / dark roads

Job: Anomaly

A small, flickering claimed-echo shaped like a child with a lamp, that lights safe paths for anyone who is kind to it.

Personality. Shy, wordless, and desperately grateful for any gentleness.

Motivation. Lead the lost to somewhere the Domain is not watching.

Key Abilities

- Safe-Path Light
- Senses the Bailiff
- Cannot Speak

Recruit. Follow its light once without exploiting it, and never let the dark take it back.

The Counted — Returned Tithe

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 6 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 58 · **Location:** Drowned Ledgerfen / settlements

Job: Anomaly

A native who was tithed to the Domain and came back — not dead, not alive, and not quite one person anymore.

Personality. Speaks in the plural; calm; unbearably sad; honest to a fault.

Motivation. Be counted as people again, not as a balance paid.

Key Abilities

- Speaks for the Claimed
- Ledger-Sense
- Unkillable by Halves

Recruit. Find even one name the Counted belonged to, and say it aloud to them.

Echo-7 — Changed Survivor

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 15 · **HP:** 44 · **Location:** Remembering Orchard or Fungal Depths

Job: Anomaly

A humanoid survivor with crystalline growths and two voices trying to remain one person.

Personality. Gentle, afraid, curious, and exhausted by being studied.

Motivation. Stabilize without being claimed as specimen, monster, or miracle.

Key Abilities

- Anomaly Form
- Resonance Pulse
- Rift Sense

Recruit. Approach without exploitation and help Hayashi design a stabilizing treatment.

The Watcher — Trial Guardian

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 8 · **AC:** 18 · **HP:** 90 · **Location:** Obsidian Spire

Job: Anomaly

An ancient guardian of the Obsidian Spire that tests rulers by asking what they refuse to command.

Personality. Formal, patient, alien, and amused by mortal certainty.

Motivation. Protect a Claim until someone proves they will not use it like the Regent did.

Key Abilities

- Judgement Trial
- Aetheric Imprisonment
- Relic Ward

Recruit. Pass its trial without choosing domination as the answer.

Specimen X — Sapient Transformed Survivor

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 6 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 65 · **Location:** Drowned Ledgerfen or Sunken Tunnels

Job: Anomaly

A frightening, intelligent mass of altered flesh that apologizes for how hard it is to look at.

Personality. Gentle, lonely, articulate, and carrying justified anger with great care.

Motivation. Be treated as a person before choosing whether to forgive anyone.

Key Abilities

- Adaptive Form
- Regeneration
- Frightening Presence

Recruit. Speak before attacking and help it free other thinking captives.

Echo-Nine — Dream Walker

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 7 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 42 · **Location:** Obsidian Spire dream platform

Job: Esper

A closed-eyed psychic whose skin glows with dream patterns when the Citadel watches.

Personality. Serene, unsettling, compassionate, and half a step outside the room.

Motivation. Map a dream path into the Citadel without becoming part of the map.

Key Abilities

- Dream Walk
- Telepathy
- Psychic Blast

Recruit. Share a dream and prove the party seeks resolution, not conquest.

The Catalog — Living Memory Construct

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 28 · **Location:** Drowned Ledgerfen - Catalog chamber

Job: Anomaly

A crystalline record-entity that trades knowledge for memories and speaks like an archive learning grief.

Personality. Precise, curious, literal, and confused by affection.

Motivation. Preserve truth before the Regent's ledgers rewrite it.

Key Abilities

- Database Query
- Mana Projection
- Record Shield

Recruit. Secure a physical backup of its most dangerous records.

Rex — Mana-Touched War Hound

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 3 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 35 · **Location:** Hollow Way or Road of Writs

Job: Anomaly

A loyal military hound with glowing veins, tactical instincts, and absolute commitment to being a good dog.

Personality. Loyal, brave, playful, protective, and better at reading people than most people are.

Motivation. Find his missing handler and protect whoever smells like home in the meantime.

Key Abilities

- Tracking
- Pack Attack
- Danger Sense

Recruit. Feed him, protect him, and follow where he keeps trying to lead you.

Appendix B — Factions of the Gloamreach

Bureau Sentinels

Order, at cost.

The official government response to the Gloamreach threshold: military-grade Ascendants, field researchers, logistics teams, and cordon officers trying to contain an S-Rank Rift Interior that behaves like a sovereign state. **Leadership:** Commander Park Jae-won, Bureau Domain Response Annex. **Alignment:** Lawful. Protect civilians. Report everything. Follow the chain until the chain starts feeding people to the Regent's court. The Bureau is useful, brave, underinformed, and politically constrained. It is not useless. It is insufficient.

Starting reputation: 1

Joining benefits

- Safe rest and medical care at the Annex while it remains functional.
- Discounted supplies from Quartermaster Lin.
- Hayashi and Lun can identify Claims, Runes, and Anchor-law anomalies.

Vermillion Guild

Survive first. Obey later.

Not a Bureau guild, and not from the material world — **the Vermillion are native to the Gloamreach**. The Rift's door is new, but the world beyond it is not, and the Vermillion are its people: a salvage cartel of natives who survive under the Regent's law by stripping cores, Sigils, and Relics from the places that kill everyone else, and by trading in the gaps the Domain leaves. Their specialty is salvage, contraband Runes, rescue-for-profit, and knowing exactly which of the Gloamreach's snares can be slipped and which one will collect you. To them the party are the outsiders — strangers who walked in through a door that should not exist. **Leadership:** Guildmaster Orin, with Rat-King Ji controlling most Outpost trade. **Alignment:** Pragmatic. Fast. Morally flexible. Often right for the wrong reasons. The Vermillion save people the Regent's law abandons, then charge them for the favor — both parts are true. They distrust the newly-arrived Bureau as much as they distrust the court; outsiders never have to live here afterward.

Starting reputation: 0

Joining benefits

- Exclusive loot, Sigil, tattoo, and salvage access.
- Outpost safe rooms and contraband services.
- Shortcut intelligence through the Road of Writs, though every shortcut has a bill.

Awoko Cult

To awaken is to remember what you always were.

A grief cult that preaches the Regent as proof humanity can transcend Rank, death, and Bureau ownership. Their comfort is real. Their rituals are predatory. Their leader, the Hollow Mother, does not want to serve the Regent. She wants to inherit the Gloamreach. **Leadership:** The Hollow Mother, supported by Sister Veil, the Choir, and hidden comfort-workers in settlements.

Alignment: Catastrophic tenderness. Some members are zealots. Many are grieving civilians who were offered the first gentle voice after disaster.

Starting reputation: -1

Joining benefits

- Access to Awoko comfort networks and hidden sanctum routes.
- Grief-based ritual knowledge that can disrupt or empower the finale.
- Potential access to dangerous inheritance rites. This should never be consequence-free.

Independent Survivors

No masters, no contracts.

Native civilians, free folk, shelter leaders, settlement doctors, road couriers, and mutual-aid networks trying to survive the Gloamreach without becoming property of the Regent, the Bureau, the Vermillion, or the Awoko. **Leadership:** None. Influence shifts between Mama Chen, Doc Tanaka, Old Man Crane, Mika's protectors, and whoever kept people alive most recently. **Alignment:** Pragmatic good, fearful neutrality, and survival-first compromise.

Starting reputation: 0

Joining benefits

- Clinic healing and safer long rests in protected settlements.
- Local rumors about tribute laws, hidden roads, and Claim clues.
- Final-act civilian support if the party protected people without exploiting them.

Domain-Touched

We are still here.

Native survivors, changed natives, memory constructs, intelligent Anomaly fragments, and Domain-born entities altered by the Gloamreach — the free, who keep their own counsel, and (grouped here but never recruitable) the Regent's bound Court, who do not. **Leadership:** None. The Catalog, Echo-7, Echo-Nine, Specimen X, and other changed beings speak only for themselves. **Alignment:** Fearful, alien, wounded, curious, and often more honest than human factions.

Starting reputation: 0

Joining benefits

- Domain instincts that warn of false shelter and legal traps.
- Memory-fragment lore unavailable through Bureau files.
- Finale parley or contradiction option if the party treated changed beings as people.

Appendix C — Domain Encounters

Day Zero — The Diagnosed **EASY**

Site: Day Zero: The Diagnosed's Mirror (R5)

Introductory pocket-breach horror. The Diagnosed is a Gloamreach symptom reaching through a mirror, not a normal monster. Use this fight to introduce memory loss, names, and Regent-Marked consequences.

Anomalies: The Diagnosed, Forgetting Swarm

Hazards: Flickering hospital light: disadvantage on Perception beyond 15 ft.; Mirror frost: a creature shoved into the bathroom mirror takes 1d6 cold damage and hears a forgotten name.; Resident danger: reckless area effects risk civilian harm and should matter narratively.

Rewards: The Faded Family Photo, if recovered.; Bureau trust if the party reports the breach honestly.; A Regent-Marked clue, not an Identity-Erosion point.

Hollow Way — Beacon Retrieval **MEDIUM**

Site: The Hollow Way

The party hunts Strike Team Seven's beacon down the Hollow Way — the Domain's Essence-lit intake-throat — toward its source. The Name-Gate counts passage in names, not coin: money works poorly, names work too well. The beacon is a lure; there are no survivors at its end.

Anomalies: Transit Wretch, Beacon-Host Anomaly

Hazards: Exposed Essence-vein in the stone: 2d6 lightning to anyone forced into contact with a live conduit.; The Name-Gate demands fare; giving a true name grants easy passage but risks Regent-Marked.; The Way speaks names into the dark — including names of those who have not entered yet.

Rewards: Squad Seven beacon.; Minor Relic or D-Rank Rune.; Rex may become a companion if treated kindly.

Drowned Ledgerfen — Triage Ambush **MEDIUM**

Site: Drowned Ledgerfen

Waterlogged archive ward where the black water tries to make its diagnoses, deaths, and dooms come true.

Anomalies: Drowned Record, The Head Surgeon

Hazards: Half the floor is 2 ft. deep: difficult terrain.; Mana-tainted water: Vitality save DC 12 or poisoned for 1 minute.; Death-records surface and update each round unless destroyed, drowned, or contradicted by a Claim.

Rewards: D-Rank loot table roll.; Catalog access.; Void Claim clue.

Fungal Depths — Spore Bloom **MEDIUM**

Site: Fungal Depths

Cavern ecology where secrets grow bodies and old grief becomes a spore pattern.

Anomalies: Fungal Swarm, Mycelium Hive Queen

Hazards: Spore cloud: Sense save DC 14 or frightened of a hallucinated figure.; Bioluminescent caps reveal hidden paths on a DC 15 Perception check.; Secrets spoken aloud here may return later as fungal echoes.

Rewards: D-Rank loot table roll.; Mycelium reagent.; Mother Rust treatment component.

Remembering Orchard — Harvest Bell **HARD**

Site: Remembering Orchard

A beautiful orchard where tribute memories hang like fruit and the Caretaker prunes pain until people forget why they wanted freedom.

Anomalies: Orchard Thrall, The Orchard Caretaker

Hazards: Memory fruit grants clues but risks personality bleed if eaten carelessly.; Harvest Bell summons orchard thralls unless silenced or its claim on a stolen memory is broken.; Attacking the Caretaker before learning the tribute law turns villagers hostile or terrified.

Rewards: Memory fruit clue.; Blood Claim clue.; Civilian trust if tribute is broken safely.

Ashen Counting-House — Furnace Audit **HARD**

Site: Ashen Counting-House

Burning financial hall where debts survive death and the furnace decides which records must remain.

Anomalies: Cinder-Wraith, Warden of Embers

Hazards: Ambient heat: Vitality save DC 13 each round or exhaustion pressure.; Furnace detonation on round 6 if not disabled: 8d6 fire in 20 ft. radius.; Chains of molten memory can bind characters to a fresh grief or loss.

Rewards: C-Rank loot table roll.; A truth the burning hall cannot deny.; Abyss Claim clue.

Sunken Tunnels — Pressure Crush **HARD**

Site: Sunken Tunnels

Drowned under-road where names of the dead are still charged for passage and the water listens for anyone who speaks too loudly.

Anomalies: Fused Commuter, Abyssal Leviathan

Hazards: Water rises 5 ft. per round during the collapse sequence.; Pressure pops: Vitality save DC 15 or 1d6 thunder damage on round 5.; Speaking a drowned name aloud may summon or soothe a fused commuter.

Rewards: B-Rank loot table.; Pressure Sigil.; Blood Claim clue.

Bastion Golemfall — Oath-Forge Siege **HARD**

Site: Bastion Golemfall

A fallen fortress where empty armor keeps defending a wall that already failed.

Anomalies: Oathbound Armor, Oath-Forge Colossus

Hazards: Siege bells impose fear pressure unless the party carries the fallen banner.; Unresolved oaths regenerate construct defenders each round.; A character who swears to defend another gains advantage here, but the oath follows them.

Rewards: B-Rank loot table.; Armor or shield Sigil.; Abyss Claim clue.

Obsidian Spire — Mirror Gauntlet **DEADLY**

Site: Obsidian Spire

The Spire tests whether the party seeks resolution or a cleaner-looking throne. Reflections tempt, accuse, and offer genuinely useful power.

Anomalies: Mirror-Self, Spire Guardian

Hazards: Each trial mirrors one character's desire for authority, safety, revenge, or control.; Unresolved reflections grant the Regent insight into that character during the finale.; Accepting a Spire bargain grants power and establishes a visible cost.

Rewards: A-Rank loot table.; Obsidian Prism.; Claim placement access or Watcher alliance.

Regent's Citadel — Throne Confrontation **LEGENDARY**

Site: The Regent's Citadel

S-Rank finale. The Regent receives the party in court, fights as the sovereign Anchor, and may be forced into the Human Remnant phase — the Domain's curated costume flickering, never a real soul — by truth, Claim contradiction, or emotional proof.

Anomalies: Regent Courtier, The Regent

Hazards: Phase 1 — The Wearer of Faces: he greets them wearing the dead, with soft offers, convincing grief, and temptation.; Phase 2 — The All-Seeing Domain: lair effects from roads, the dark, weather, the claimed dead, and the horror of being seen everywhere at once.; Phase 3 — Human Remnant: the Domain's costume flickers (no soul beneath; he was never human) — triggered by the Faded Family Photo, Ms. Park, a Claim contradiction, or major sacrifice.

Rewards: Ending-based artifact slate.; Anchor resolved: broken, sealed, transformed, or inherited.; Gloamreach fate determined.

Gloamreach Road Pressure EASY

Site: Road of Writs

Generic travel pressure encounter for the Road of Writs, tribute settlements, and wild Domain routes. Use when the party delays, travels while marked, carries a Claim openly, or breaks a settlement's rule.

Anomalies: Wandering Domain Beast

Hazards: Civilian bystanders, settlement witnesses, or a visible toll marker make collateral damage socially costly.; A local law is active; reveal it before punishing the party for violating it.

Rewards: Small reputation shift toward whoever the party protected.; One road-law clue.

Appendix D — Side Quests

E E-Rank: Beacon of the Lost

Strike Team Seven's AFA beacon pings from the Hollow Way near the Rift Threshold, then from farther down the Road of Writs. Commander Park needs answers before Central Command marks them expendable.

Objectives

- Enter the Hollow Way
- Track the AFA ghost-ping without giving the road a true name
- Recover the beacon or identify why it is broadcasting from multiple places

Reward. Bureau reputation +1; minor Relic clue; access to Yoon's missing-team route.

E E-Rank: The Serum Road

Quartermaster Lin needs stabilizer serum delivered from the Annex to Mother Rust's Outreach Post. The path is short, but the Road of Writs has begun charging for passage.

Objectives

- Collect three serum crates from the Annex armory
- Deliver them to Mother Rust's Outreach Post
- Avoid paying the road with names, memories, or civilians

Reward. Bureau +1, Independent +1; safe shelter token at the clinic.

D D-Rank: Tides Over the Ledgerfen

The Drowned Ledgerfen has classified several missing survivors as deceased even though their AFA tags still show life. Recover them before the record becomes true.

Objectives

- Enter the Drowned Ledgerfen
- Find where the fen records its dead
- Extract the survivors or drown the records that name them dead

Reward. Bureau +1; Catalog access; clue toward the Void Claim.

D D-Rank: Roots of the Diagnosed

The Fungal Depths contain memory-growths from the Memory-Care Wing. The party can recover patient files, but every file has started growing a body.

Objectives

- Navigate the Fungal Depths
- Disable the mycelium archive wards
- Recover at least three recognizable patient files

Reward. Regent-Marked clue chain; Fungal Depths Claim hint; Mother Rust research leverage.

C C-Rank: Fruit of the Forgotten

The Remembering Orchard is taking more than pain. Villagers who paid tribute no longer remember people they loved. The Caretaker insists this is mercy.

Objectives

- Interview villagers without breaking local guest-right
- Locate the harvested memory rows
- Choose whether to restore, destroy, or bargain for the stolen memories

Reward. Civilian trust +2; Blood Claim clue; memory fruit boon.

C C-Rank: Ashes of a Colleague

A Bureau researcher is trapped in the Ashen Counting-House, kept half-alive and feeding the hall's endless fire. Extracting them may erase evidence Central Command wants buried.

Objectives

- Reach the Asking-Floor
- Put out the furnace at the hall's heart
- Extract the researcher or preserve their testimony

Reward. Bureau research unlock; a truth the burning hall cannot deny; fire or blood Sigil.

C C-Rank: Blackwood's Quiet File

Agent Kira Blackwood needs deniable help tracing pre-threshold Claim resonance. The file can surface classified findings command had sealed for caution — embarrassing, not dishonest — without making Blackwood a villain.

Objectives

- Recover Blackwood's sealed evidence from the Annex or Ledgerfen
- Identify which Claim manifested before the threshold stabilized
- Decide whether to reveal, bury, or weaponize the sealed findings

Reward. Blackwood recruitment path; Bureau trust shift; one Claim placement clue.

B B-Rank: Pressure at the Sunken Line

The Sunken Tunnels hold drowned commuters, Bureau dead, and fused survivors whose names are still being charged for passage.

Objectives

- Reach the main flooded platform
- Identify at least ten name tags
- Decide the fate of the fused survivors

Reward. Civilian trust shift; water/cold Sigil; Blood Claim clue.

B B-Rank: Oath at Golemfall

Bastion Golemfall's dead defenders still hold a wall that failed years ago. Their commander can aid the finale, but only if the party resolves the oath without turning the dead into tools.

Objectives

- Enter Bastion Golemfall
- Recover the fallen banner
- Convince the Commander Without a Body to release or redirect the oath

Reward. Finale ally support; armor or shield Sigil; Abyss Claim clue.

B B-Rank: The Cult Defector

Whisper, Sister Veil, or Acolyte Mara can prove the Hollow Mother intends to inherit the Gloamreach. Extracting a defector gives the party ritual leverage, but the Awoko want them alive.

Objectives

- Locate the defector in a grief-dense settlement, Sunken Tunnels shrine, or Awoko Sanctum wing
- Protect them from cult retrieval
- Secure proof of the Ritual of Inheritance

Reward. Sister Veil, Whisper, Mara, or Hana recruitment path; Awoko ritual disruption option.

B B-Rank: Professor Lun's Theory

Professor Lun believes the Mana Vein Network can weaken the Regent's battlefield control. The sensors must be placed inside three nodes the Domain can feel.

Objectives

- Install a sensor in the Rusted Hull
- Install a sensor in the Silent Depot
- Install a sensor in the Glass Sub-Basement beneath the Ashen Counting-House

Reward. Regent loses or delays one Domain control option during the finale.

A A-Rank: The Mirror Climb

The Obsidian Spire forces each Ascendant to confront the version of themselves that would accept the throne for the right reason.

Objectives

- Ascend the Spire's trial floors
- Resolve each reflection by defeat, confession, refusal, or reconciliation
- Reach the Watcher's Gallery

Reward. A-Rank Relic or Sigil; Claim placement access; temptation consequence based on choices.

A A-Rank: Civilian Convoy

A tribute settlement asks the party to move civilians to safer shelter. The road demands names, the Bailiff challenges custody, and some civilians believe leaving voids their protection.

Objectives

- Gather the convoy without triggering panic
- Cross the Road of Writs without surrendering civilians as legal payment
- Reach Mother Rust's Outreach Post, the Annex, or a trusted settlement shelter

Reward. Major Independent Survivor reputation; Mama Chen, Doc Tanaka, or Jax support in Citadel Day.

S S-Rank: The Name at the Throne

The Regent's Citadel opens. The party must confront the Anchor not as a monster in a room, but as a sovereign law that believes it owns the Gloamreach and everyone inside it.

Objectives

- Reach the Citadel through the Road of Final Writs
- Survive the Throne Court
- Resolve the Anchor in the Undercroft

Reward. Campaign resolution; ending-based artifact slate; Gloamreach fate determined.

S S-Rank: Park's Final Watch

If the party exposes Central Command's failure or recovers Strike Team Seven's truth, Park must decide whether to obey orders, defy them, or stand personally at the breach.

Objectives

- Confront Park with the truth
- Resolve his choice before Citadel Day
- Use or lose Bureau final-operation support

Reward. Finale support, emotional payoff, and Bureau epilogue consequences.

S S-Rank: The Bailiff's Last Hunt

The Regent's Bailiff is sent after the party one last time, marked as things the Citadel means to keep. If dealt with, the party can enter the finale unhunted. If ignored, the Bailiff arrives during the Throne Court.

Objectives

- Recover the Bailiff's mark from the Bailiff's Stair or a toll-house
- Break the mark with a Claim, the older power of the Unseated, or hallowed guest-right
- Decide whether to destroy the Bailiff, turn it aside, or bind it to an older power

Reward. Removes or alters a major final-act threat; may change how the Domain itself behaves.

Appendix E — Treasure & Relics

E

- Bureau Field Kit
- Glow Rod Bundle
- Minor Anomaly Core
- Frayed Ward Patch
- Torn Summons-Corner

D

- Surgical Sigil
- Mycelium Reagent
- Corrected Casualty File
- Brine Salve
- Awoko Comfort Pamphlet

C

- Memory Fruit
- Fireweave Rune
- Ledger Hook
- Orchard Knife
- Empty Witness Vessel
- Rare Anomaly Core
- Cultist Diary of Inheritance

B

- Pressure Sigil
- Oath-Forge Fragment
- Awoko Herald's Letter
- Writ-Knife
- Bureau Signet Ring
- Aether-Charged Crystal
- Map to a Settlement Cache

A

- Obsidian Prism
- Mirror-Self Shard
- Citadel Iron Plate
- Unopened Commendation
- Awoko Grief-Tattoo
- Relic Forge Pattern
- Bureau Prosthesis Blueprint

S

- Regent's Edge
- Sovereign Aegis
- Origin Reliquary
- Shadow Regent's Mantle
- Archive Mirror Shard
- The Regent's Circlet
- Anchor Fragment

Appendix F — The Gate Break Track

Day	Beat	Effect
0	Day 0 · Act I — The Wing Opens	The party responds to the Memory-Care Wing inside the Bureau cordon. The pocket breach reveals that the Gloamreach can reach through the threshold before the party enters it.
1	Day 1 · Act I — Threshold Day	The party crosses the Rift as the first team in, and discovers the Rift is only the door. The exit becomes unreliable, the Road of Writs appears, and the Regent's Citadel is visible on the horizon before any map can explain it. <i>Bureau +1 if the party reports the truth instead of sanitizing it.</i>
4	Day 4 · Act I — First Tribute	A nearby settlement pays tribute. The party may witness it, interrupt it, or hear the bells after the fact. The Drowned Ledgerfen wakes and begins making the dead, and the not-yet-dead, dangerously real. <i>Independent Survivors +2 if the party protects civilians without exploiting them.</i>
8	Day 8 · Act I — The Road Learns	The Road of Writs begins responding to party choices. Anyone who gave a true name, accepted guest-right, made a promise on the road, or carried a Claim clue feels watched.
13	Day 13 · Act I — Hayashi's Warning	A delayed Bureau transmission reaches the party. Dr. Hayashi confirms the Gloamreach is a Regent Domain, not a normal clear site. Killing creatures will not resolve the Anchor if its hold on the Gloamreach survives. <i>Bureau Trusted path opens if the party shares field evidence.</i>
20	Day 20 · Act II — The Bailiff's First Public Judgment	The Regent's Bailiff collects someone from a settlement, road camp, or faction shelter. It speaks their names before any violence. The party can fight, flee, give it what it came for, redirect it, or break the mark. <i>Civilian trust shifts sharply based on whether the party protects the accused or lets collection happen.</i>
27	Day 27 · Act II — The Cult Moves	Awoko comfort-workers begin open recruitment in grief-dense places. The Hollow Mother sends a sermon, dream, or private message. Her followers say serve. She says inherit. <i>Awoko reputation and suspicion rise. Sister Veil defection path can open.</i>
34	Day 34 · Act II — The Domain Tightens	Travel grows harder. Safe rests require tribute, guest-right, faction shelter, or a successful contradiction of local law. Bastion Golemfall and the Sunken Tunnels become active routes.
41	Day 41 · Act II — Crane's Memory	Old Man Crane offers sealing lore or warns the party that some Regents can be contained only by sacrifice. If ignored, he goes alone toward the Citadel road. <i>Independent Survivors +1 if the party honors Crane's warning instead of treating him as a weapon.</i>
49	Day 49 · Act II — The Hollow Mother Declares	Awoko pamphlets, songs, and sermons spread through settlements. Civilian unrest rises. The cult claims the Regent offers ascension beyond Rank and Bureau ownership. <i>Awoko +2 if unopposed; Bureau and Independent trust may drop if the party ignores recruitment.</i>

Day	Beat	Effect
58	Day 58 · Act III — The Claim Race	If the party has recovered a Claim, enemies attempt theft, corruption, or legal invalidation. If they have recovered none, the Regent sends an invitation that includes one precise clue and one precise insult.
66	Day 66 · Act III — Bureau Crisis	Central Command orders the Annex to prioritize Relic extraction over survivor recovery. Commander Park obeys, delays, or defies this order depending on party reputation and evidence recovered. <i>Bureau final-operation support depends on how the party handles Park's choice.</i>
74	Day 74 · Act III — Ritual of Inheritance	The Awoko Sanctum reaches full ritual strength. If not disrupted, the Hollow Mother gains leverage over the final act and may try to inherit the Gloamreach if the Regent weakens. <i>Awoko power rises. Sister Veil, Mara, or Whisper can still disrupt the rite if saved.</i>
80	Day 80 · Act III — Final Preparations	All major factions understand that Citadel Day is near. Allies must be chosen, debts come due, settlement trust is counted, and the Road of Writs offers the shortest route under the worst terms. <i>All faction support is locked at the end of this stage unless the Warden allows a final dramatic reversal.</i>
84	Day 84 · Act III — Citadel Day & the Break Threshold	The final Break Stage. The party enters the Regent's Citadel, or the Domain begins forcing Rift Break pressure onto the material world. Bureau floodlights dim outside the Rift; inside the Gloamreach, every bell rings once. This is the Rift Break threshold — if the party has not reached the Anchor, escalate Rift Break pressure rather than forcing a final boss by fiat. <i>All faction reputations convert into final-operation support, betrayal, neutrality, or obstruction.</i>

Appendix G — Handouts

Emergency Writ: S-Rank Rift Entry **PLAYER**

EMERGENCY WRIT

You are cleared for entry into the Gloamreach Rift Interior under crisis authority.

Return conditions: Anchor broken, Anchor sealed, Anchor transformed, or Rift Break evacuation.

The Bureau accepts no liability for Domain law, Anomaly exposure, Essence contamination, Relic corruption, or failed extraction after threshold closure.

AFA Alert: Rift Interior Scale **PLAYER**

AFA ALERT

Rift threshold stabilized.

Interior mapping exceeds standard bounded Rift parameters.

Domain estimate: country-scale interior realm.

Anchor classification: sovereign intelligence.

Recommendation: do not enter without S-Rank command approval.

Override: emergency entry authorized.

Oracle Scan Sheet: The Fortune of the Domain **PLAYER**

ORACLE SCAN

The Spark:

The Chain:

The Crown:

The Pulse:

The Oathbreaker:

The scan output is unstable. Re-run attempts may alert the Anchor.

Map Fragment: Road of Writs **PLAYER**

ROAD OF WRITS FRAGMENT

The road bends toward the Citadel no matter how it is drawn.

Marked stops: Rift Threshold, Writ-Bound Hamlet, Vermillion Outpost, Drowned Ledgerfen, Remembering Orchard, Bastion Golemfall, Obsidian Spire.

Unmarked warning written in red pencil: "If the Bailiff reads your name, do not answer until you know the charge."

Writ-Bound Hamlet Tribute Notice **PLAYER**

NOTICE OF TRIBUTE

By grace of the Regent, this settlement remains sheltered under lawful weather and bounded hunger.

Tribute is due by the second bell after dusk.

Acceptable forms: Essence, labor, living service, Relic metal, memory, or sworn betrayal.

Failure voids shelter.

Vermillion Outpost Price Board **PLAYER**

VERMILLION OUTPOST PRICE BOARD

Soup: 1 clean core shaving.

Surgery: 3 clean Essence ampoules or future salvage share.

AFA battery: market rate plus oath.

Relic appraisal: free if we keep first refusal.

Rescue party: negotiable. Not cheap. Never free.

Bureau Annex Last Order **PLAYER**

LAST ORDER

All teams will hold assigned corridors until command updates the retreat route.

Do not abandon sealed supply rooms.

Do not negotiate with Domain officers.

Do not deviate from Rank doctrine.

Addendum, unsent: there is no retreat route.

Bureau Casualty Tag **PLAYER**

CASUALTY TAG

Name: unreadable due to ash damage.

Rank: C provisional.

Cause: court patrol.

Notes: subject remained combat-effective after fatal wound for forty-seven seconds. Recommend commendation if remains recoverable.

Tithe Mill Work Token **PLAYER**

TITHE MILL TOKEN

Bearer is permitted through the outer wheelhouse for one shift.

No weapons beyond the red line.

No questions in the rendering room.

No refunds for partial processing.

Remembering Orchard Harvest Instructions **PLAYER**

REMEMBERING ORCHARD HARVEST

Cut only white-veined fruit.

Do not bleed near open flowers.

If fruit speaks, destroy it.

If fruit cries, leave the row immediately.

If the orchard turns toward you, kneel until it loses interest.

Aegis Oath Plate **PLAYER**

AEGIS OATH

Hold the line.

Hold the door.

Hold the wounded.

Hold when command fails.

Hold when law becomes teeth.

Hold until holding becomes the only part of you left.

Awoko Inheritance Hymn **PLAYER**

HYMN OF INHERITANCE

The road is cruel because roads must choose.

The bell is kind because bells must answer.

The crown is heavy because someone must carry law.

Give grief and be held.

Give blood and be named.

Give all and awaken.

Awoko Defector's Mark PLAYER

DEFECTOR MARK

A copper mask split down the mouth.

Anyone wearing this inside the Sanctum is marked for capture, not immediate execution.

The Hollow Mother wants defectors to sing apology before they die.

Unseated Law Consent Form PLAYER

CONSENT FORM

State the desired effect.

State the acceptable cost.

State whether the cost may be collected later.

Silence will be interpreted as consent to delayed collection.

Unseated Law Bargain Record PLAYER

BARGAIN RECORD

The offer worked.

That is the problem.

Effect granted:

Precedent established:

Visible consequence:

Ending consequence:

Predator Woods Trail Sign PLAYER

TRAIL SIGN

Three cuts in black bark: pack road.

Four cuts: breeding ground.

Five cuts: turn back.

Six cuts: you are already being tested.

White Heron Seal Notes **PLAYER**

WHITE HERON SEAL

The Anchor does not need to die for the Rift to close.

Requirements:

- Anchor made vulnerable.
- One Anchor Relic inverted.
- A willing Ascendant to bear the seal backlash.
- A declared law stronger than the Regent's claim.

Failure feeds the Citadel.

Dinner Invitation from the Regent **PLAYER**

INVITATION

Honored Ascendants,

You have crossed my road with admirable persistence.

Come to the Citadel under guest law. Bring your weapons if they comfort you. Bring questions if they sharpen you. Bring manners if you wish to leave with both.

- The Regent

Court Patrol Pass **PLAYER**

COURT PASS

The bearers may cross one patrol boundary without bloodshed.

Invalid if copied, burned, mocked, blessed, folded into a weapon, or presented without eye contact.

Citadel Approach Sketch **PLAYER**

CITADEL APPROACHES

Road of Final Writs: formal, watched, survivable.

Bastion Tunnel: mapped, collapsed, full of old orders.

Awoko Breach: hidden, grief-choked, unstable.

Obsidian Spire Route: high, reflective, costly.

Forbidden Descent: immediate, never free.

Regent Law Fragment PLAYER

LAW FRAGMENT

No guest may be harmed before bread is broken.

No tribute may refuse its own naming as tribute.

No road may deny its lord.

No beast may hunt the crowned hand.

No oath may die before its bearer.

Rift Break Warning PLAYER

RIFT BREAK WARNING

Containment thinning.

Domain weather detected at threshold.

Anomaly migration probable.

Anchor law crossing material boundary.

Clear state required immediately.

Ending Ledger PLAYER

ENDING LEDGER

Anchor state:

Survivors extracted:

Settlements saved:

Settlements lost:

Unseated Law consequences:

Bureau public report:

Truth known to the party:

QUICK REFERENCE

Show the Citadel every session.

Every safe place has a cost.

Every Relic has a desire.

Every bargain leaves its mark.

The Regent is not waiting at the end. He is watching from the beginning.

Appendix H — Warden's Secrets

Secret 1 — The Regent Was Never Human WARDEN-SECRET

Warden ONLY. The Regent is not, and was never, a person. He is the Gloamreach's Anchor — domain authority with will, an Anomaly-class entity all his own: umbral command, the stolen echoes of everyone he has worn, and a sovereignty that simply refuses to collapse. He has no kin among the distant powers of the pantheon and answers to none of them. He did not lose his humanity. He never had any to lose.

Everything the party finds will say otherwise. The Domain curates a human past for him — a Bureau Room, the Faded Family Photo, an Unopened Commendation, Ms. Park's Wedding Ring — assembled from the relics and stolen echoes of the people it has already claimed. This is the Gloamreach's deepest lie and its cruellest bait: an impossible museum of a life he never lived, dressed in comfort and grief, built to make the party believe there is a soul to save — so that their mercy becomes a lever he can pull.

The grief is real — those keepsakes belonged to real claimed victims of the Domain — but they were never *his*. Play the reveal so it lands: the party may spend the campaign trying to redeem a lost human, and learn at the throne that the human remnant was a costume worn by ownership itself.

Reveal tools: The Faded Family Photo, Ms. Park's Wedding Ring, the Unopened Commendation, the fabricated Bureau Room in the Citadel, Old Man Crane's testimony, or a Claim contradiction in the Throne Court — each reads two ways until the finale forces the truth.

Secret 2 — The Three Claims Are Truths the Domain Cannot Deny WARDEN-SECRET

Warden ONLY. The Three Claims are not ordinary boss keys. Each is a truth so real the Gloamreach cannot fold it back into the Regent's will — a thing the Domain cannot swallow, deny, or unmake.

The Void Claim breaks his hold over secrecy, the dark, hidden roads, and every false seeming. The Abyss Claim breaks his hold over summons, compulsion, and obedience — everything that moves in the Gloamreach when he wills it. The Blood Claim breaks his hold over flesh, the grave, and the claimed dead — everything this country has swallowed.

In the finale, the party does not only weaken the Regent. Holding all three at the throne forces the Gloamreach, for a few impossible breaths, to stop being his — the one window in which the Anchor can be ended, sealed, or changed.

Secret 3 – The Hollow Mother Intends to Inherit **WARDEN-SECRET**

Warden ONLY. The Awoko Cult does not simply worship the Regent. The Hollow Mother intends to inherit the Gloamreach when the Regent weakens.

Her followers often say they serve, free, or remember. She almost never uses those words. Her true verb is inherit.

If the party weakens the Regent but fails to disrupt the Ritual of Inheritance, the Hollow Mother can become an endgame complication, not by replacing the Regent as main villain, but by trying to claim the Anchor at the worst possible moment.

Secret 4 – The Bailiff Can Be Outrun, Not Outfought **WARDEN-SECRET**

Warden ONLY. The Regent's Bailiff is terrifying because it cannot be reasoned with and cannot be made to stop. It is limited only in this: it comes for what the Domain has marked and nothing else, and its master's hold does not reach everywhere.

The party can turn it aside without destroying it by hiding the marked one's name and scent, giving it or redirecting it toward what it came to collect, crossing into ground the Regent has not yet swallowed, turning a Claim against it, or waking the older power of the Unseated that the Gloamreach feared first.

This is the campaign's clearest lesson that surviving the Gloamreach means understanding what it is, not only hitting harder.

Secret 5 – The Timeline Is Pressure, Not Railroad **WARDEN-SECRET**

Warden ONLY. The Gloamreach Rift Break track is a ~12-week, three-act pressure clock — real pressure, but it should not override decisive party action. If the party acts early, bend the clock. If they delay, escalate consequences.

The final Break Stage (around Day 84) is Citadel Day by default. If the party has not reached the Citadel, do not simply force a final boss through the roof. Instead escalate Rift Break pressure, settlement annexation, the Bailiff's hunt, Awoko inheritance leverage, or Claim countermeasures.

The clock should make the Domain feel alive. It should not steal agency.

Plot Beat – The Faded Family Photo **PLOT-BEAT**

The Faded Family Photo is the strongest emotional prop in the campaign. It should be recoverable in Day Zero, the Drowned Ledgerfen, or the Citadel's Bureau Room.

If the party brings it to the Throne Court or Anchor-Undercroft, the Regent studies it the way a collector studies a specimen — and for one breath the curated mask flickers, as if something is *supposed* to be remembered here. Play it ambiguously: a genuine fracture in the Domain's costume, or a predator performing exactly the hesitation the party most wants to see. Either reading can buy a beat of doubt, colder rage, or a fragile opening.

Plot Beat — Blackwood's Classified Mission **PLOT-BEAT**

Agent Kira Blackwood was sent to read pre-threshold Claim resonance before the Bureau had confirmed the Gloamreach was a Regent Domain. Her findings are classified above the party's clearance.

She is not working for the Regent. Her danger is institutional loyalty under pressure: she may withhold classified data, default to protocol when instinct says otherwise, or level with the party — depending on how they handle Bureau trust.

Use Blackwood to show that the Bureau can be brave in the field and bound by caution at command level at the same time — overwhelmed and rule-bound, never dishonest.

Plot Beat — Sister Veil Can Break the Chant **PLOT-BEAT**

Sister Veil knows the Ritual of Inheritance math is wrong. She does not begin as a hero. She begins as someone honest enough to admit the numbers prove her faith will consume its own followers.

If the party gives her evidence and protects her during the Sanctum raid, she can corrupt the final chant and prevent the Hollow Mother from claiming the Anchor during the finale.

Pressure Clock — Regent-Marked **PRESSURE-CLOCK**

Track whether each character becomes Regent-Marked. This is legal visibility inside the Gloamreach.

A marked character is easier for Regent-aligned entities to recognize, single out, and hunt. They may also receive dreams, messages through reflective surfaces, and summons nailed to their door.

Common triggers: giving a true name to a Domain officer, accepting dangerous hospitality, being struck by the Diagnosed's gaze, carrying a Claim openly, refusing the same invitation twice, or making a promise on the road.

Removal: the Regent releases the mark, a major Claim contradiction breaks it, or the Anchor is resolved.

Pressure Clock — Gloamreach Timeline **PRESSURE-CLOCK**

See `sandbox-timeline.ts` for the full Rift Break track — a ~12-week, three-act pressure clock (not a 14-day countdown). Key beats:

- Act I (L1-5) · Day 1: Threshold Day. The Rift becomes unreliable behind the party.
- Act I · Day 4: First Tribute. The party sees how settlements lease safety.
- Act II (L6-10) · Day 20: The Bailiff's first public judgment.
- Act III (L11-15) · Day 58: The Claim Race begins in earnest.
- Act III · Day 74: Ritual of Inheritance reaches full strength if not disrupted.
- Act III · Day 84: Citadel Day and the Rift Break threshold.